ROMANS

Truth in Paradox

A Brief Commentary

Harry Bultema

Foreword by John H. Bultema

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FOREWORD

My father's method of exposition of this great epistle is a little unusual. A "paradox" is something apparently absurd or incredible, yet true; something seemingly contradictory, yet consistent. For example, consider one brief passage found in this book:

"Dead unto sin - alive unto God" (Romans 6:11). We have indeed, in reality, been crucified unto sin, and a crucified person was a person that was dead indeed. But we are alive unto God. Dead and alive at the same time. What a paradox!

Some of these expositional writings on Romans originally appeared in the monthly Bible study magazine, *The Morning Star* (which my father founded and edited) from June 1951 through November 1954.

Pastor Harry Bultema had a great love for the Word of truth with its message to Israel and the distinctive revelation of the mystery of grace to the Body of Christ through His apostle Paul. In this exposition of Paul's letter to the Romans, he makes crystal clear the difference between God's two programs - to Israel and the Body. There is therefore a noticeable emphasis in this work concerning Pastor Bultema's great love (as a reflection of God's great love) for the people of Israel. In this light it is noteworthy that Dad's last three sermon s in the Muskegon Berean Church were on the subject of Romans 11; "Hath God Cast Away His People?"

Growing up in a busy parsonage with seven "PK's," I was not privileged to play ball or go fishing with my dad like many other young boys. As I grew older, however, I came to realize that the burden of responsibility the Lord had laid upon my father's heart required the faithfullness of a pledge of love to his Savior which mandated total dedication to the study, reading, preaching, and writing about his wonderful Word. The lights in Dad's study would be on early in the morning, and often well beyond midnight. I am amazed at the hours of study, prayer, and meditation that enveloped his life until the Lord gently took him home in 1952.

Romans: Truth in Paradox is a portion of the fruit of that labor. In this book there is a precious blend of solid Grace truth and many stirring devotional thoughts. I know you will be blessed as you read it.

John H. Bultema

Autumn, 1988

Muskegon, Michigan

CHAPTER 1

THE WORLD CONDEMNED

Spiritual truth is always the higher union of two opposite truths. Truth may be compared to the pendulum which rhythmically swings from one central point to two opposite extremes. This dramatic form of revealed truth runs throughout the Scriptures, but is by far the most marked in Paul's Epistles.

Your faith is spoken of throughout the world - I make mention of you always in my prayers (1:8, 9).

After Paul has spoken about the three creative calls, he posits this antithesis. Paul was called from heaven not to be an apostle, but the very call of the risen Lord constituted him an apostle. The creative call gives the believers the right to be named "the called of Jesus Christ." The same God who once at creation said, "let there be light," said to these Gentiles dead in sins, "live," and they had life in Christ Jesus.

Further, they were not called to be saints, but the efficacious, inner and creative call of God constituted them saints. Their sainthood originated in the same creative call as Paul's apostleship. Viewed from God's side, the faith of the Roman believers was the organic and unbreakable bond that bound them to Christ. Faith was the hand that accepted Christ from the human side, but in reality it was the invisible work of God by which they were incorporated into the crucified and risen Savior. This good work which God commenced was now worked out by them to be demonstrated to the outside world. What God wrought into them, they wrought out in a life of faith and in the obedience of faith.

In reality their works of faith were spoken of, but in a beautiful way Paul says their faith was spoken of in all the Roman world. When faith in Christ is evident, it speaks and is spoken of as here. Saints today are often either the quiet of the land whose faith never speaks or is spoken of, or they low like the bulls of Bashan on the streets of Gath and Ashkelon. The whole world talked about their faith, but there was but one man who spoke without ceasing to the Lord about them. This proves it is easier to talk about the faith of others than to talk in faith of others to God. It is considerably easier to talk about the works of faith of others than to practice the prayer of faith in regard to others. We have here the antithesis of thousands to one. The thousands spoke of faith, the one man prayed in faith.

I long to see you, that I may impart unto you some gift - that I may be comforted - that I might have some fruit (1:11-13).

Paul was always on the giving side, since his whole personality glowed with the love of Christ and love must give. He wanted to give them the gospel of grace, some spiritual gift, some comfort, some strength. He does not say yet that he wanted to make them complete in Christ as he later said in Colossians 4:12 of Epaphras. If Paul had been exorbitant in his expression of purpose and insincere he would have intimated that he

came only for their good and that he had no ulterior motive in his coming than to help them, but he could honestly testify as a normal believer that he hankered also for comfort and fruit from them. He gives himself exactly as he is. He knows that God's people can comfort one another (1 Thess. 4:18), and he is not ashamed to confess that he often needs the comfort of other believers. It is sheer arrogance and pride to claim that a person does not need comfort. Real communion of saints is not a one-sided affair, but a bilateral action. It is action proceeding from the other party to you and from you to the other party. Paul knew full well that when he edified the saints their reaction would in turn weather favorably upon Paul; the husbandman would eat of the fruit, the shepherd would drink of the flock, in a spiritual sense. The Christian worker does not only impart, he also imports some valuable spiritual material for his own precious soul.

I purposed to come to you - but was let hitherto (1:13).

Paul purposed, planned to go to Rome for a considerable period, but he was let or hindered. Who hindered him? There were really only two who could, and also actually did, hinder him. These two were the good Spirit and the evil spirit. The latter did not want him to exalt Christ in Rome, and the Holy Spirit did want him to go on the divinely appointed scheduled time. The Spirit of God, however, did not want Paul to go to the Far East, but to the West, and this makes it highly probable that the apostle here is thinking of the evil spirit. The Devil was beaten nevertheless, as he always is when the Lord plans and works; but think what it would have meant if Satan had won and prevented his coming to Rome. Then Europe might be like the dead Oriental churches today, so petrified and ossified because they have never experienced the healing breath of Paul's gospel. We may indeed well thank God at this late hour that the Spirit of the Lord prevented Paul time and again from going East and miraculously led him through storm and stress and shipwreck to Europe. He worked it out so wondrously for Paul that he could preach the gospel on his trip thither, and that the trip for him was gratis, paid by the Roman Empire. How marvelous have been God's ways with this man!

For therein is the righteousness of God revealed - for the wrath of God is revealed (1:17,18).

With the word "therein" Paul means in the gospel. We would expect him to say that the love of God was revealed in the gospel, and then he would have stated the whole truth according to some, though in reality it would have been but a half truth and fully as dangerous as a lie. Paul has before his mind the fact that the Law demanded the righteousness of God. And that what man could never give, God has revealed in the gospel. He has revealed it in Christ who has a threefold righteousness: as God, as man, and as merited on the cross of Calvary. The first two are nontransferable, but the third one has been imported from heaven, imputed by faith, and imparted by the Holy Spirit in us. Not only all peace but also all grace, love, and mercy are based upon the eternal rock of God's righteousness. It is not called the righteousness of Christ, though He merited it, but the righteousness of God, since God demanded it and is fully satisfied with it.

However, darkly silhouetted against this shining righteousness of God is the "wrath of God." The definite article is not used in the Greek. The wrath of God shall not be revealed until the coming day of wrath, the *Dies Irae,* the day of judgment. World history

is not the world judgment, as Schiller has it, but the present wrath the whole of world history manifests is clear proof that the future wrath does not slumber. Wrath is in God not an unholy passion, as in man, but the holy reaction against all unrighteousness and ungodliness.

They knew God - they glorified Him not as God (1:21).

What was to be known of God was once manifest in the heathen, for God showed it to them. Then, from creation the invisible things were "clearly seen." They could clearly see His external power and divinity, and this made them without excuse. Man often has a mawkish mercy for the poor heathen that the just and holy God does not have. He says that they are without excuse, in that when they knew Him as God, they glorified Him not as God. God is not satisfied when man merely knows Him, He wants man to glorify Him. Jeremiah cried, "Give glory to the Lord your God, before He cause darkness" (Jer. 13:16). In Malachi He asked, "Where is mine honor?" (Mal. 1:6). "Ye are bought with a price, therefore glorify God in your body and in your spirit" (1 Cor. 6:20). Whether we eat or drink, we are to do all to the glory of God (10:31). The ransomed throngs in heaven always give glory to God (Rev. 4:11). Belshazzar was destroyed, because he did not glorify God (Dan. 5:23). Herod was eaten of worms, because he did not give God the glory (Acts 12:23). The great end of all redeemed life is to glorify God, as is even all of life and existence itself. We see that not to glorify Him is the climax of sin. It is a negative sin of omission, yet it is positively the most harmful, the most blatant and God-defying rebellion against His majesty. The pleasure-mad crowds forget this solemn truth, and consequently are heading headlong toward disastrous calamities.

Professing themselves wise - they became fools (1:22).

All colleges still seriously study the Greeks who sought after wisdom, and who were the wisest nation of antiquity. In the first chapters of 1 Corinthians, Paul described the Grecian wisdom and the wisdom of the world as "foolishness" with God. It is an amazing thing that Christian institutions of learning pay so much attention to what God calls foolishness. The god of this age has succeeded in trapping Christendom into foolishness. It is no wander at all that Protestant Christendom lapsed so suddenly and completely into Rationalism. Satan trapped the professors and students into Grecian folly first, and then the German folly easily followed. They were not wise; they only professed themselves to be wise. There is an earthly and a heavenly wisdom, and they had the former, not the latter. They became one of the twenty-one different species of fools that God has portrayed in His Word.

They changed the glory of God - wherefore God gave them up (1:23, 26, 28).

There was no evolution but devolution. When the King of Babylon saw in a dream vision the glory of the world, he also saw the devolution from gold to mud, and so Paul described here not man's ascent, but the down-grade from man to creeping things in the mud. With the somber sound of a funeral knell we read here: God gave them up to uncleanness. God gave them up to vile affections. God gave them over to a reprobate mind.

In each case God gave them up to gruesome sins. He saves His people from sins, and He gives the wicked up to sins, punishing sin with sin. It is the complete antithesis

to salvation from sin. We find in the midst of our so-called Christian civilization the same judgment on the sins of modern men. We have now multitudes, yes, millions in Christian lands who are utterly enslaved to unspeakable sins that leave no doubt but that God has given them up to uncleanness and a reprobate mind. The awakening will come only in hell.

CHAPTER 2

JUSTIFIED BY FAITH

The doers of the law shall be justified - He justifieth the ungodly (2:13; 4:5).

Commentators have labored and sweat over this flagrant contradiction, and yet the solution is very simple. In the former passage Paul speaks to the Jews and applies to them "the gospel of the circumcision," and here the rule he lays down is fully applicatory. There was in Israel no other way of salvation. The doing of the Law was reckoned to Israel for righteousness (Deut. 5:29). Abraham's faith was reckoned for righteousness. Abraham's zeal was reckoned to him for righteousness. Israel's doing of the Law was not perfect, but in sovereign grace it was reckoned to them for righteousness (Deut. 5:29). In every case God's sovereign will and not man's work was the decisive factor. In the latter place the rule is stated for the Gentiles and, in fact, for Jew and Gentile for this whole age.

God abominated of old all that justified the ungodly and condemned the innocent, and these two things He has in wondrous mercy done Himself. He condemned His innocent Son after He laid our iniquities upon Him, and upon the basis of His Son's propitiatory sacrifice, He justified the ungodly. He would be unjust, if it were not for the Cross, but now He justifies the ungodly and is perfectly just.

Thou art called a Jew and restest in the law (2:14, 17).

A little child can grasp this: the Jews have the Law and the Gentiles have not. However, due to some believing that God is all through with Israel and that the church has taken Israel's place, they think the church must also have Israel's Law. It would be, however, quite easy to furnish a thousand reasons why the church cannot be Israel, but let two facts suffice: • Thirty years after Israel crucified Christ it was said in Romans 9:3,4, "My kinsmen after the flesh... who are Israelites," proving that Israel in its sin still bears the ancient theocratic and non-transferable name of Israel.

• A second fact ought to be equally convincing; Israel's present existence as a nation and God's great acts in the partially restored Israel. There is not one iota of proof that the Law was ever given to the Gentiles or to the church which is His Body, while there is irrefutable proof to the contrary. Orthodox Jewry is still, with smug complacency, resting in the Law. When shall the day dawn that Christians who claim to tremble before the majesty of the Word shall actually shed their traditionalism in order to humbly take God at His Word?

Thou teachest another - teachest thou not thyself? (2:21).

History gives clear evidence of the fact that the Jews, through their clinging to the Old Testament and through their synagogal schools, were generally the teachers of the heathen. They not only had far more light than the heathen but also more than the Mohammedans and the illiterate Christians of the oriental and medieval churches. Hence we read here that even thirty years after Christ was crucified they functioned as teachers of others; but they did not teach or drill or discipline themselves. They strictly

and rigidly laid down the Law for others but did not obey it themselves. They stole and committed adultery. History fully substantiates Paul's description. They abhorred idolatry since the Babylonian exile, but they robbed temples of their idols (2:22). Through all their sins they caused the name of God to be blasphemed among the heathen, just as we still often find it today. They did not seem to realize what Paul says, that they in this manner made themselves uncircumcision or Gentiles. On the other hand, the Gentiles who kept the Law were counted as Jews, not as saints. Paul did not call the legalistic Galatians saints.

A Jew outwardly - a Jew inwardly (2:28, 29).

Spiritual Israel is not at all the point of this passage. Two things are evidently before the mind of the apostle:

• External Judaism gloried only in the blood of bulls and goats in which God had no pleasure (Heb. 10:4, 5, 6, 8).

• The Jews who through fealty of heart were true to the name of Judah, lion of God.

The former he calls a Jew outwardly, the latter a Jew inwardly. The church is never called spiritual Israel. This is only a theological subterfuge to escape the irrefutable facts of Holy Writ in regard to Israel and the church. There is not such a thing as spiritual Israel inside the covers of the Bible, unless we first fabricate it there through a false exegesis. If, however, we insist on a spiritual Israel, then only Christ would fit that description, or perhaps the future Israel who has received the Holy spirit (Ezekiel 37) , but not the church.

Circumcision in the flesh - Circumcision in the Spirit (2:28, 29).

The former is naturally Israel or an Israelite who has not yet accepted Christ. He has only had a slight operation by hands in the flesh. It incorporated him into the holy covenant people, while symbolically it cut away the old man; it typically adumbrated the perfect cutting away of Old Adam through the self-sacrifice on the cross. Paul has the same contrast before his mind in Colossians 2:11, 12 when he speaks of the "circumcision made without hands," calling it also the "circumcision of Christ." The circumcision of the Spirit is the same as the circumcision of Christ. He is thinking of the believers who have focused their faith upon Christ and His perfect sacrifice, and now have, through God's gracious reckoning, the antitypical and true circumcision of the Cross. Transgression of the Law made the Jew uncircumcision or a heathen (2:25), whilst faith in Christ gave the Gentile the true spiritual circumcision made without hands. Here the old man was not merely symbolically cut away, but actually crucified (6:6.)

CHAPTER 3

THE RIGHTEOUSNESS OF THE LAW

Let God be true - But every man a liar (3:4, 10-18).

That God is true needs no proof. The pagan gods could lie, but our God cannot lie. All His Word proclaims this, and even the heathen King Nebuchadnezzar decreed that all His works are true (Daniel 4:37). Neither does it need proof that every man is a liar at heart, for even George Washington and honest Abraham Lincoln are not excluded. Man has all sorts of lies - scientific lies, philosophic lies, black lies, white lies, big lies and little lies, educational lies, conventional lies, church lies, spiritual lies, advertising lies, medical lies, legal lies, lies of exaggeration and of necessity, political lies, communistic lies, traditional lies, and lies found in the Bible - all substantiating the fact that man is a liar. Satan is the father of lies and the lake of fire is the final place of all liars. We live in a world of lies. With lies we have been drawn into horrible world wars which have brought in their train untold agonies among the nations. Paul does not mean to say, of course, that every person in the world is daily and momentarily actually telling lies. He does not look at man's actions and words, but at his being and his heart. He states the true fact that man is essentially a liar and he goes on to substantiate this in the following verses. He mentions seven sins and promptly locates four in the mouth (3:13, 14), and he wants to stop every lying mouth before the true God.

The righteousness of the law - the righteousness of God without the law (10:5; 3:21).

This contrast should by all means be well grasped. Many hastily conclude that the righteousness of the Law is all wrong and the same as self-righteousness, but this is not the case. The righteousness of the Law was God's economy and order for two thousand years in Israel. However, when Christ came and fulfilled the Law completely by His active and passive suffering, He became the end of the Law in the sense that He had reached the objective of the Law. This objective was that the required righteousness of the Law to be holy was to be fully realized. In His propitiatory sacrifice Christ did realize this required righteousness. The ancient bill of the Law being all paid, so to say, God now pointed to His crucified and risen Son, who by the way of the Cross has now become our righteousness (1 Cor. 1:30), and hence Christ is now the very righteousness of God apart from the Law. The word "without" fosters the erroneous idea that the Law did not exist anymore or was not in any way used anymore. Only a casual glance at the Book of Acts will convince anyone that even Paul himself used the Law as a Hebrew for the Hebrews. He circumcised Timothy, kept the feasts of Israel, took a vow, and even brought bloody sacrifices. In all this he did not compromise the truth, as many try to tell us, but he did right as a Jew. For the Gentiles, however, there was now revealed the righteousness of God apart from the Law. The Jews could, for a time, keep the Law and believe in Christ.

The law of works - the law of faith (3:27).

The law of works means the ancient Law-keeping and doing by Israel. He calls it a law for two reasons:

• A law is a rule, a regulation.

• The Law of old was God's rule for Israel.

That lie further contrasts this with the law of faith is rich in meaning, because over against the ancient rule of Law stands works, He now emphasizes the fact that faith, and not works, is the rule. He does not deviate from this rule with one single exception. It is now believe in Christ or be damned. Oh that this simple rule of faith were well grasped by Christendom, but Latin, Greek, or Protestant Christendom has as a whole never grasped this simple law of faith.

Is He God of the Jews only? - of the Gentiles also (3:29).

The Judaizers of Paul's day had the Pharisaic notion that God was exclusively the God of the Jews, just as some sects in our day have the foolish idea that they alone are the people of God. God is the God of all creation and of all the nations. Christ is called the Light of the world, and this means He some day will flood the whole world with His light. He is called the Life of the world, and this means He will some day give life to the world, which is now dead in sins. Romans 11:15 tells us how God will give life to the world of mankind. Christ even had some Gentile blood in Him through the women Thamar, Rahab, and Ruth. He was called by Simeon "a light to lighten the Gentiles" even before He was called "the glory of the people Israel" (Luke 2:32).

Justify the circumcision by faith - justify the uncircumcision through faith (3:30).

This difference in justification between Jew and Gentile has always been more or less a crux to commentators. Many have never even noticed this emphatic difference. The justification in both cases is the same sovereign act of God by which, upon the basis of the finished work of Christ on the cross, He imputes the merited righteousness of Christ to the ungodly and counts him guiltless and righteous in Christ. The hand that accepts it is also the same, namely faith, but here is a difference between Jew and Gentile. The Jews historically had some faith, as Hebrews 11 testifies, and hence they were justified *(ek,* out of) that faith, which now was no longer toward God but centered upon and into Christ. The Gentiles had never had any faith, only sheer superstition, and God had to provide them with faith. It is the gift of God (Ephesians 2:6-8), and now it was through the instrumentality or the agency of this newly granted faith that the Gentiles could be justified.

Make void the law - establish the law (3:31).

The rendering "made void" is too strong for the verb *katergeo,* which means to work down so as to make inactive. There is nothing which can ever make the Law of God void, empty, useless, or illegal. The Law is an integral part of the Word. That is forever settled in heaven and man can never unsettle it through his unbelief and rebellion. But since Paul spoke of a justification by faith apart from the Law and Law-works, this question itself was natural and to the point. No, faith did not work down the Law to an

inferior quality, but it established the Law. Why? Because we now see that rather than let the Law and its holy demands go by default, God made His Son under the Law (Galatians 4:4, 5) in order that He might atone for the broken Law to redeem them that were under the Law. Since Christ honored all the holy demands and fully met all the requirements of the Law through His own blood, faith in Christ does not dishonor but established the Law as holy and just in all its exacting obligations. Faith is never a mere revolutionary overthrow but ever an establishing proof of what God has spoken.

CHAPTER 4

FAITH COUNTED FOR RIGHTEOUSNESS

Now to him that worketh is the reward not reckoned of grace - but of debt (4:4).

The word misthos is here not "reward" but wages. If we work for someone, then our work enriches that employer in one way or another, and then he has to give us wages. We can demand our wages. They are coming to us. We have indebted the employer. But this shows we can never work for God, never enrich God who as Creator owns all things, and then put Him in debt to us for our wages. Work demands wages and excludes grace, and this would never do with the God of all grace. How absolute the contrast is between grace and works we can see in 11:6. They mutually contradict and exclude each other. But just as surely as grace and work are contradictory, so are wages and debt identical. After you have worked for a person you have put him in debt to you to pay you the set wages. How absurd is the thought that this could ever be done with God.

To him that worketh not - but believeth (4:5).

As we have just seen, work puts the employer in debt to the wage earner for wages. It can't be otherwise. Paul thinks here of the Pharisees and Judaizers who wanted to be justified by the Law-works, and in absolute contrast he says, "but believeth on him that justifies the ungodly." The two examples he adduces from sacred history are most instructive. Abraham was justified about 400 years before the Law was ever given on Mt. Horeb, a clear-cut proof he had not been justified by works of the Law. David is clear proof we are not kept justified by good works, for after he was justified, he committed three gruesome sins: adultery, murder, and the long hiding of his sins. Still, all these sins were not able to deprive him of his

justification. David could sing, "Blessed is the man to whom the Lord will not impute sin" (4:8). He saw, however, only the negative imputation and not yet the positive imputation of Christ's righteousness. Although he did not yet see this he nevertheless had it, for without it he could not have been righteous in God's sight. With both Abraham and David justification came by faith alone.

Was he in circumcision? - or in uncircumcision? (4:10).

The Law and its works did not justify Abraham, but neither did the much lauded rite of circumcision. Some ancient Rabbis oracled that God made the world for circumcision alone, and that the circumcised, and they only, would all go to heaven. But Abraham became the father of all that believe fourteen years before he was circumcised.

The heir of the world was not through the law - but through the righteousness of faith (4:13).

This proves several things. It proves Israel of old, being under the Law, could never rule the world or bring in the kingdom. It proves Christendom, largely under Law, can never bring in the kingdom and rule the world, much as it tried to for nearly two thousand years. It proves present day Israel with all its genius, leadership, and finance can never become heir of the world. It proves also that Christ and the believers shall some glad day be the divinely constituted heirs of the world. We shall be heirs of God and joint-heirs with Christ. He was delivered on account of our offenses, raised on account of our accomplished justification (4:25), the ground of our justification being completely provided in His death. The propitiation by His death was complete (John 19:30), and His resurrection was the satisfying counterpart, the proof, the receipt of the Father on the absolute sufficiency and efficiency of the atonement. The phrase "righteousness of faith" implies the Cross and the resurrection. Even our future glory, heirship, and rule of the world with Christ are all the blessed result of His death and resurrection, as well as our justification.

CHAPTER 5

THE UNGODLY ARE JUSTIFIED

We stand and rejoice in the hope of the glory of God - but we glory in tribulations also (5:2, 3).

Ancient physicians declared that there is not a malady to which the human body is subject for which there has not been provided a salutary remedy, either in the mineral, vegetable, or animal kingdom. Similarly, there is surely not a misery as the result of sin that does not find its complete remedy in the Person of Christ. In Him all fullness dwells and we are complete in Him. He not only delivers us from the ruin of Adam, but secures for us far greater blessings than Adam ever had. Adam could not rejoice in the hope of the glory of God, and especially could he not glory in tribulations as we can by His peerless power and grace. Our Savior has a threefold glory: as Man, as God, and as God-Man in one adorable Person. This latter glory consists also of His redemptive work of the past, present, and future. The full blaze of His glory is coming when He returns. It makes us stand in a world which is now reeling like a drunken man, while it makes us joyful with a joy unutterable, since it includes our perfect likeness to Him, and our sharing of all His glory with Him. But we glory in tribulations also. It is just because of the coming glories that the present tribulations are regarded as but light afflictions.

Peradventure for a good man some would even dare to die - while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us (5:7, 8).

It happens time and again, that some heroes die for a good man, or for women and children, but it never happens that a man dies for his bitterest foes. This is high above man's nature and ability. Nevertheless, what man never does, and can never do, our Christ has done at the Cross. He died for sinners who are here described in a fourfold way:

• *Without strength* - The fall knocked us out completely and bereft us of all our original strength.

• *Ungodly* - Sin left us without God as well as without hope, but Christ died for the ungodly, who were not only without God, but definitely opposed to God.

• *Sinners* - We missed the mark of the glory of God, but He came for sinners, called sinners, befriended sinners, died for sinners. While on earth sinners were His favorites. It was the only class for whom He came, the only class for whom He died.

• *Enemies* - He died for His enemies. O wondrous grace!

Not one of the ransomed ever knew,

How deep were the waters crossed;

Or how dark was the night the Lord went through,

Ere He found His sheep that was lost.

Until the law sin was in the world, but sin is not imputed when there is no law (5:13).

The verb ellogeo is found elsewhere only in Philemon 18, where it is rendered "put to account." It here also signifies to lay to one's charge, to put the debt on one's bill. Between Adam and Sinai there was much sin but no transgression and consequently no imputation of sin. The law of conscience existed but this is not in view in this phrase.

This phrase becomes more striking and meaningful when we compare it with 2 Corinthians 5:19, where we read that today God is not imputing man's trespasses unto them. This is solely due to two facts:

• The world is not now under the Law of Sinai.

• God reconciled the world unto Himself by Christ.

It is today not a sin question but the Son question. The blood of Christ will make the vilest sinner clean, and by the same blood the ungodly are justified freely from all things forever.

But not as the offence, so is also the free gift (5:15).

Adam and Christ! Universalists of ancient and modern date abuse this wondrous parallel between Adam and Christ when they reason that all the old humanity was first in Adam and now is in Christ. The real antithesis is not only between these two federal heads, but also between the two federations under these federal heads. While the old humanity is in Adam to be sure, the same humanity is not in Christ. The new humanity is only those who have entered into Christ by faith. Hence all that have not appropriated Him by a living faith stand outside the ark and are swallowed up by the floods of His fiery wrath. The apostle has clearly sounded a note of warning when he says the free gift is not as the offence. The offence is for all mankind in Adam. The free gift is accepted by faith in Christ, and the unbelievers reject this free gift through their unbelief.

CHAPTER 6

DEAD BUT ALIVE

Shall we continue in sin? How shall we that are dead to sin, live any longer therein? (6:1, 2).

Believers in Christ are dead to sin, or better, they have died to sin, and how can the dead live continually? Believers can fall in sin, as David and Peter sufficiently prove in their lives, but they cannot continue in sin, though it must be admitted that life provides us sometimes with strange cases. Many quote here John's word that "he who committeth sin is of the Devil." Arminian believers understand this as meaning that one single sin makes a person unsaved and a child of Satan who must be saved all over again, and thus many in our land are "saved" six or seven times. They need to understand the blessed truth that He by the way of the Cross became our wisdom, our righteousness, our sanctification, and redemption, and that a saved person who was crucified and raised with Him cannot possibly continue to live in sin. The saved hate sin, shun sin, watch and pray against sin, and keep their eye upon the Lord of glory by prayer, faith, and reading of the Scriptures.

Dead indeed unto sin - but alive unto God (6:11).

We have indeed, in reality, been crucified unto sin, and a crucified person was a person that was dead indeed. Here was no apparent death, nor a figurative death, but a real death, since our Head died a real death on the cross of Calvary. But we are alive unto God. Dead and alive at the same time. What a paradox! Still, there is life, more abundant life, and thus it is also with the life unto God. Some but feebly seek and sigh, moan and groan, to God in prayer, while others are filled with praise and with constant toil for Him overflowing with labors of love. Of the latter sort was Paul, of the former most modern church members.

Neither yield ye unto sin - but yield yourselves unto God (6:13).

The word "yield" has altogether gone too much out of the vocabulary of Christians. Surrender is too much of a military term. To dedicate, consecrate, and give does not express the beautiful idea of yielding, which is a term of quiet country life, like the yield of an acre. Just as the flower yields itself to the sun, the crop yields itself to the farmer, the bride yields her body to the bridegroom, so believers are to yield themselves unto God. We note that there are two kinds of yielding; to sin and to God. The sinners do daily the former, the saints are to do day by day the latter. It is this yielding that is the secret of all spiritual joy, strength, service, and fruit-bearing. If there is in the lives of believers a hunger of heart to live and labor more for God, then this is the Spirit's secret call to yield themselves fully to God (Rom. 12:1, 2). It is by this presentation of their body and soul to God that they come to know the will of God for their own lives. In this yielding lies also the secret of sound interpretation of Scripture, the objective will of God. But subjectively, they shall also find in this way the will of God for their particular way, walk, work, and holy warfare.

Ye are not under law - but under grace (6:14).

Alas, how little is our God taken at His Word. Hundreds of millions of professing Christians are still groaning under the hard yoke of the Law, if not that of Moses, then the laws of the lawmakers of the church. Israel was under Law. The books of Moses and nearly the whole Old Testament reveal this irrefragable fact. Even the Gospels reveal this. Christ was made under the Law as surely as he was made of a woman (Gal. 4:4). There was the hard yoke, which according to the Hebrew Peter, neither our fathers nor their children were able to bear, while here in the Gentile regime of grace, we can walk in the risen Lord of glory.

Ye were the servants of sin, but - ye became the servants of righteousness (6:17, 18).

Yes, once we were the slaves of sin, and we slaved, toiled and sweat hard for our wages (Rom. 6:23); but like the faint and forsaken Egyptian slave whom David found, fed, protected, and adopted, the great Son and Lord of David has found us and He has given us the great exchange of masters, so that now we do not slave any longer for the cruel queen, sin, but for the Lord of glory who sought us, bought us, and adopted us as His own, glory to God.

Ye were free from righteousness - but now being made free from sin (6:20, 22).

Paul has still the picture of slaves before him. They are now not slaving but manumitted or liberated. Once we were free from righteousness, the righteousness of God. Being away from God we were away from all of God's attributes and special blessings, but after the great and gracious change of Masters took place we were manumitted, entirely freed from the abject slavery of sin. The slavery of sin is now past, while Christ is now our righteousness through His merits on Calvary.

The wages of sin is death - but the gift of God is eternal life (6:23).

The figure of slavery is still here before the mind of Paul. The slavery was hard, but the wages are far worse. Death is found in three forms, spiritual, natural, and eternal. Here the wages encompass all three, or death in the most absolute sense. Notice, the sinner sweats and slaves in order to get into the lake of fire. God does not just send him thither, but he slaves for it. God never made that awful place for him, but for Satan and his angels, but the sinner through constant slavery works his way into it. With heaven it is just the opposite. Here it is "to him that worketh not." Here it is a royal gift, and the gifts and the calling of God are without repentance. A real gift has always the following characteristics: it is always free, unmerited, voluntary, unselfish, deliberate, designed, charitable, and irrevocable. This is certainly true of this wondrous gift and Giver. Happy the sinner who is stopped on his mad career before payday. There is no such thing as poetic justice with God!

CHAPTER 7

RELATIONSHIP TO THE LAW

Know ye not - I speak to them that know the Law (7:1).

If anyone ever lay stress upon an intelligent Christian life, it was our apostle. For the fifth time in this context he stresses spiritual knowledge, and every time the implication is clearly: You should know.

• You should know the wondrous baptism into Jesus Christ and into His death.

• You should know it is not a mere material rite of putting a member of the heavenly Lord under the element of curse, but a complete identification with Christ and His work on the Cross (verses 3 and 4).

• You should know our old man was crucified with Him (Rom.6:6), in order that the body of sin might be destroyed.

• You should know Christ has a resurrection life, and that our life in union with Him is of the same character. It is a life that "dieth no more" (Rom.6:9).

• You should know that as a slave you can only serve one master, either sin with death as wages or the Lord of glory, whose gift is salvation.

• You should know that the Law has dominion only over a living and not over a dead man (7:1).

In 1 Corinthians 6 the apostle six times exclaims: "Know ye not?" (2, 3, 9, 15, 16,19). When we realize these believers were what we would call today native Christians just come to a saving knowledge of Christ, then we can easily make up our mind how much more is expected of us and what intelligent believers we ought to be. We must not merely know about the things of God, but by faith we should know God and all He has for His own. Many have only some scraps of knowledge floating in their mind, but true sanctified knowledge comes from the direct teaching of the Word of God (2 Tim. 3:15; Ps. 119; Col. 3:10). Faith and love are the two golden keys to true knowledge.

Of what sort was the constituency of the assembly of Rome? Were they Jews or were they Gentiles? Or was it composed of both Jews and Gentiles? Much has been written on this question. Naturally those who defend the Jewish character make themselves strong with this word, whereas those who regard the Roman assembly as Gentile, invoke Romans 11:13 as proof for their view -- "I speak to you Gentiles inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles." The sanest and at the same time the most common view is that the Roman church was mainly Jewish and that it also had a large number of Gentiles. As in many places, the church grew out of the synagogue.

Israel did not know the Law, but do the majority of believers know the Law? The Law is holy, just, good, spiritual. These four characteristics exclude all antinomianism. But the Law is called a "shadow," and in a shadow nothing will grow and come to fruitage (Heb. 10:1). The Law is typified by Moses' veil (2 Cor. 3:13-16) and is called a ministry

of death and damnation. The Law is a jail, shutting one up and shutting out all freedom (Gal. 3:23; sunekleisen means shut up in prison). The Law was for Israel the pedagogue - the boyleader - to lead him unto the teacher, Christ; dispensationally, not soteriologically. The Law never saved. The Law as a mirror can never wash one clean. Who offends in one point of the Law is guilty of all (Jas. 2:10). Take one link from a chain and it is broken. Chip one piece out of a vase, and the whole is marred. One pearl lost from a necklace spoils the necklace. The Law is almost entirely negative, grace is positive. Representing the Law, Moses turned the water into blood in his first miracle. Christ turned the water into wine in His first miracle. When Moses came with the Law-tables his face did not shine, but when he came from communion with the merciful God his face shone, and he knew it not. The Law does not beautify and sanctify, grace does.

The law of her husband (7:2, 4).

Romans seven illustrates the fact that though we are legally dead to sin, sin is still in us and the strength of this indwelling sin is the Law. This chapter is an ancient battle ground; the Waterloo for many an Arminian. We have here unquestionably a leaf from Paul's autobiography, for he mentions the personal pronoun "I" thirty times; the Spirit but once in verse 6, whereas he uses the Spirit twenty-two times in the next chapter and the "I" but once.

He uses the picture of a marriage as God instituted it, the monogamous wedlock. A wife is bound to her husband as long as he lives. Death snaps this bond. She is then free to marry again. It has often escaped notice that this chapter is not only a continuation of the preceding, beginning as it does with "or," as the R.V. has it, but we also have here in this example of the marriage a second illustration of the release of the believer from the claims of the Law and from the power of sin.

The first illustration was that of the slave set free from one master so that he might serve another (6:15-23). The second is that of the marriage bond. The underlying thought, which we also met in the preceding chapter, is that law has no claim on a dead man. A dead man has no hold on his wife. Many think Paul sadly mixed his metaphors, but he could not set forth his argument in strictly logical process, since he was hampered by the fact that the Law did not die while the believers did die with Christ on the cross. Many have here hastily and erroneously concluded that the Law is dead, but the Law did not and could not die. We were crucified with Christ to the Law, and we arose with Him that we might be one with the risen Savior.

The expression "married to another" is not in the text, and a bridal theory cannot be built upon this. It simply says we should become someone else's. The argument as a whole is clearly that the Jews under the Law had to obey the Law in the same manner as a wife has to obey her husband, but the death and resurrection with Christ made them fully one with the crucified, risen Savior, and naturally now they could not be under the Law.

A woman is bound by the law to her husband - but if the husband be dead she is loosed (7:3, 4).

Paul uses here the figure of holy wedlock. A woman is married to a harsh and uncongenial man, but the marriage is broken by death, and strangely enough, not the

death of the Law, since the Law in reality could not die, but by the death of Christ, and this loosed her from her former cruel husband. Because Christ arose, now lo and behold, she can become the wife of the risen Lord, as it were. Paul here clearly shows the facts of the crucified and risen Lord rise above all the proprieties of metaphor. The One who broke the shackles of Hades, death, the grave, and hell has certainly the power and the right to break a metaphor; thrice glory to His holy name!

Fruit unto God, fruit unto death (7:4b, 5).

The thought of fruit is here continued from chapter 6. It is a natural thought involved in the idea of wedlock, for with marriage there is offspring. He spoke in 6:21, 22 of fruit unto holiness and fruit unto death, and so the close union to the Law brought forth a dead offspring whereas the union with the risen Lord brings forth an offspring unto God. Living in the flesh and for the flesh, and the sinful desires made more active by the precepts and prohibitions of the Law, the fruit was thoroughly bad and only useful for the cruel king of terror, death. But how the Cross and resurrection have made things different! That is the line of cleavage, the great boundary line between the Law and this bad fruit, and the glorious union with the risen Lord and the holy fruit unto God.

No fruit that comes from the gardens of old Adam can now please God. No fruit however fragrant and fair that does not have its rootage in the new Adam, Who died and rose, can now ever please God, because He has all His good pleasure in the Son. A Law-age of two thousand years brought a harvest in Israel of leaves, wild grapes, and fruit unto death, since it all came out of Adam's garden. In indissoluble union with the Lord of glory we can now bring holy fruit unto God and we can glorify God with much fruit and more fruit (John 15:2), but this fruitbearing is possible only when we abide in Christ (John 15:5). He wants the fruit of our lips as well as of our lives (Heb. 13:15). Galatians 5:22 describes the fruit of the Spirit. The husbandman is not concerned with leaves and fine foliage, but his eye rests with pleasure upon the fruit. He eats and enjoys the fruit, and he is glorified by much fruit.

There is apparently a difference between fruit and service; in addition to the figure of fruit, he gives the figure of service in the next verse.

But now... we should serve in newness of Spirit (7:6).

"But now" denotes a striking contrast between "being in the flesh" of verse 5 and "delivered from the Law" of verse 6. Being in the flesh and in bondage under the Law is evidently the same thing. It is the most significant teaching that God does not look upon believers as having a standing in the flesh and under the yoke of the Law. He does not regard them as standing in Adam, but as in the new Adam, the risen Redeemer. The old Adam met his Waterloo at the Cross. In no shape or manner does God ever reckon with the believer on this side of Calvary. Why should he reckon with a crucified criminal? The Cross cut the believer's history in two: when he was "in the flesh;" and now since he is in the risen Lord. The world is crucified to him and he to the world (Gal. 6:14). He now lives in Christ and in the Spirit unto God in the energy of His all sufficient grace.

Those under the Law were held in prison by the Law. This is the meaning of the phrase "wherein we were held," a picture that occurs again and again in Paul's estimate of the Law. Liberty and law cannot go together anymore than liberty and imprisonment.

The death with Christ brought escape to the prisoner, as Way rightly renders - "We have escaped by death from that which held us prisoners."

We were liberated in the great year of Jubilee introduced by the Cross in order that we should serve as voluntary loveslaves. We were freed not to do as we like, not freed to a life of license, but freed with a view to a higher service. Freedom from Law-bondage does not mean lawlessness but a new, happy, spiritual service for the risen Master and Lord. Fruit just comes, but with service there is an implication of voluntary energy, either of the flesh or of the Spirit of God. We have here evidently a contrast between the Law and the Spirit, between the oldness of the Law and the newness of spiritual service. What a pity so many still grope as slaves in the dark dungeon of the Law.

What shall we say then? Is the law sin? God forbid. Nay, I had not known sin, but by the law: for I had not known lust, except the law had said, Thou shalt not covet (7:7).

This chapter has four questions:

• "Know ye not the law hath dominion over a man as long as he liveth?" (v. 1).

• "Is the law sin?" (v. 7).

• "Was then that which is good made death unto me?" (v. 13).

• "Who shall deliver me from the body of this death?" (v. 24).

Every one of these four questions is answered. The apostle never raises a question to leave it unanswered. The great question for us, however, is who is the subject of this section? Fierce theological battles have been waged over this question. The Arminians always strenuously fight for the idea that Paul is an unsaved man here. Even a Bible student like Campbell Morgan writes, "For me no stretch of the imagination is equal to the task of convincing me that this paragraph can be applied to a regenerate man." And Morgan has great expositors like Tholuck, Meyer, M. Stuart, Weiss and Godet on his side. Philip Mauro also agrees with them. Of course the Arrninians have to see here an unconverted man in order to cling to their holiness theory, but this cannot be said of all the others.

St. Augustine and the Reformers always thought of a saved man. The Pietists of Germany found here an unsaved man. The Calvinists of Holland, Scotland, and other lands always thought Paul here speaks of himself as a saved man. VonHoffman regarded Paul speaking here as apart from Christ, and many followed him in this, as Delitzsch, Thanasius, Luthardt, Feine, Zahn, Erdos, and Zellinghaus. They all see here a Christian, but a sinning and backslidden one. That here is a saved man appears from the following:

• Here is a wrestling against the evil in such a way as one dead in sin could not do.

• A dead sinner does not even know the difference between the good and bad as does this man.

• These confessions could not well up from an unsaved heart.

• The unsaved man has a corrupt will and cannot will the good as does this man.

• It is psychologically impossible that a sinner could differentiate between his I and his indwelling sin.

• An unregenerate soul cannot truly cry that he hates the evil and loves the good.

• The unsaved has no inner man in the Scriptural sense of that term.

• The cry at the end and the paean of victory could clearly only well up from a regenerated heart.

The ego, used eight times and then hidden twenty-two more times in the verb, puts this chapter on a par with Job 29, where the patriarch also puts his ego in the limelight. Still, with neither Job nor Paul should we call this egotistical. It simply goes to prove that they narrate strictly personal experiences and not normative truths. It is therefore passing strange that so many Christians have hit upon Romans 7 as the Scripture that delineates the normal Christian experiences. Those who believe Paul speaks here as a saved man are divided into four groups:

• Many think Paul views himself here suppositionally as apart from Christ, but then all the arguments against an unsaved man being the speaker would hold here. Moreover Paul never, never projects himself as part of Christ if he does not mention the union with Christ.

• Others regard Paul here as a serious backslider; but the man who could glory at the end of his life that he had fought a good, literally, a beautiful fight, had never backslidden. He went from glory to glory and always triumphed by God's grace. By the Spirit he could say, "Follow me as I follow Christ," and in one form or another he repeatedly sets himself as the example for believers. In backsliding he could not be an example.

• Many believe Romans 7 is fully on a par with Romans 8, and this is certainly true as far as infallible and inerrant inspiration goes, but materially this is not true. As a matter of truth, the glorying in Christ ranks higher than the groaning of the I, as the real imitation of either one will speedily evince.

• It is best to view Paul here as a young believer who as a Jew wished to use the Law to improve and sanctify himself, and he now shows by his warning example that the Law can no more sanctify than justify, a warning taken to heart by only a few. Paul grew in grace and knowledge. This wrestling with the Law was for him, and for many others too, a necessary phase, a dark tunnel for his train of life.

I had not known sin but by the law (7:7c).

Paul here leaves his metaphor of wedlock and speaks of the function of the Law. With Israel the great function of the Law was purely hamartological - it had to do with sin, and more particularly, with the detection and condemnation of sin. A tremendous mistake has been made in applying this to believing Gentiles, whereby the thought has ripened into a general dogma that the Law must give both sinner and saint a knowledge of sin and thus in distress drive him unto Christ. This error implies six other errors:

• It proceeds upon the erroneous thought that Israel and the church are one. This is a fundamental heresy which has caused much misery in the history of the church.

• It supposes the Law was given to the Gentiles, whereas the Bible does not contain one hint that the Gentile believers ever received the Law of Moses.

• It proceeds upon the faulty thought that the Law is our schoolmaster to Christ, whereas Paul says in Galatians 3:24, 25 that the Law "had become" the pedagogue for Israel, whom he means with "our." After the faith in Christ had been revealed, even Israel was *ouk eti hupo paidagogon* - no longer under a pedagogue. This boyleader was only until Christ came, in a dispensational sense, and not unto Christ in a soteriological, saving sense. The Law never saved anyone.

• This is a stab at Calvary or the crucified Christ, for the sin of all the world has been revealed not at the foot of Mount Horeb, but at Mount Calvary. There we see sin and God's hate against sin, for He punished it in the death of His dear Son.

• It implies that a knowledge of sin is equal to redemption of sin, which is not true. When Cain had some knowledge of his sin he exiled himself, and when Ahithophel and Judas had some knowledge of their sin, in despair they executed themselves.

• Even the saint who knows and abhors himself as a sinner before a holy God does not need full knowledge of sin, but of the Savior. Our paragon saint, Paul, did not have the holy ambition to know his sin but he said, "that I may know Him," and he counted all things but loss and dross for the excellency of the knowledge of Christ.

But sin, taking occasion by the commandment, wrought in me all manner of concupiscence - For without the law sin was dead (7:8).

Paul gives here a personal touch. He had not known lust unless the tenth word of the Law had said, "Thou shalt not covet." Many Christians seem to think the tree of knowledge is the tree of life. Bacon said knowledge is power, but Solomon long before him said, a wise man is strong. A knowledge without Christ is an evil power, as we can see abundantly in our sad days. Knowledge is but fuel to set the world ablaze, apart from Christ. Even the man with the most profound knowledge walks in riddles. Knowledge under the sun is mere vanity. The heathen Socrates could only say, "know thyself." Modern pagans say, know nature all around thee. Modern theology says, know all about evolution. A Bible believer has a thirst and passion to know Christ who redeemed him.

The tenth commandment was for Paul a ray of light to reveal the filth in the dungeon of his heart. The Law wrought all manner of lust in him. The Law made his whole inner life one hot-bed of lust. The latent sin slumbering at the bottom of his heart became active rebellion by the holy precept. The expression "taking occasion" is aphorme, used also in verse 11, and further only in 2 Corinthians 5:12; 11:12; Galatians 5:13; and 1 Timothy 5:14. The word was used as a basis of operation in war, a point of departure, and a fulcrum. The Law was the very base that threw the searchlight into his heart and life. Apart from the Law sin was dead, here evidently in the. sense of being dormant or asleep.

The difficulty of this chapter is greatly enhanced by the fact that Paul does not consistently throughout use the pronoun I or the word law. Both terms are used in

various meanings as we shall see. Lust is love gone astray. It is love in excess and on a wrong object. Love builds up, lust blasts and breaks down. Lust is cruel and utterly selfish. It is passion gone mad, and it poisons other's with its breath. As a destroyer it has broken up many empires, and kingdoms, and it has now our Republic in its octopus-grip.

I was alive without the law once - but when the commandment came, I died (7:9).

Romans 7, like 1 Corinthians 7, is an extremely difficult chapter. Paul has here the antithesis between life and death; he is referring to the days of his youth ere he became *bar mitzvah*, or son of the commandment. As a youth, he did not feel the heavy yoke weighing down upon him, but when he became son of the Law, he died, which means the Law killed him. He is thinking especially of the tenth commandment forbidding lust. Now the conviction sprang up at once in his heart like a flash of lightning. He now felt that sin lodged in his own bosom. The curse of the Law came irreversibly, inescapably upon him. Evil thoughts sprang up in him, his conscience accused him, the doom of death was upon him. He felt that as a sinner, he died.

For I was alive without the law once (7:9-11).

If Paul is here biographical, as he undoubtedly is, then there could be but one period in his life when he was without the Law - the period of his childhood before his twelfth year, at which time he became *bar mitzvah,* son of the commandment. Then the commandment came, and sin lifted up its head like a cobra to strike at him. When the Law slumbered, sin also slumbered, but when the Law was driven home to his conscience, then sin revived, stung him, and he died. Just as the "revived" must not be taken in the sense of resurrection, so the "died" must not here be taken to mean a literal physical death. The apostle speaks with a certain oriental hyperbole. He found the human heart naturally rebels against the precepts of the Law; the stolen waters are sweet. When prohibition came into effect, folk became at once awfully thirsty. Every parent knows that children find the forbidden fruit more luscious and desirable than any other. God said, "do this and live," but Paul found himself deceived; it did not bring life but death. This "deceived" must also not be taken in a prosaic, stark, literal sense but as a poetic hyperbole. If taken as a bald literalism it makes God a deceiver, which is inherently impossible. The "was ordained" should never have been put in here, for the Law was never ordained to life; God's ordination is always effective and fruitful, but this would have been a miscarriage, a colossal failure. There was nothing accidental in the economy of the Law, because God works all things after the counsel of His will. The Law did exactly what God meant it to do - to show the exceeding sinfullness of sin, to serve as a mirror or photo of man's corrupt heart - and Paul illustrates how effective it was.

The law is holy, just and good (7:12-13).

Zealous as the writer was to disqualify the Law for justification and sanctification, he is just as zealous in defending its inherent worth. He gives it a fivefold epithet: "holy, just, and good" (v. 12). In verse 14 he calls it "spiritual." In verse 16 he calls it kalos, beautiful; in verse 12 he used the word *agathos.* The Law is holy because of its holy origin. It had its origin in the very holy Being of God. The Law is just because of its just

demands. Even when it asks of man impossible things, it asks no unjust things. The quality of justice means that it gives to each his exact dues. The Law is good. It is in fact the basis of all beneficent laws and of all ethical good among men. It is the rock-bottom of all pure morality. The Law is spiritual since it is inspired by the Spirit of God and used for spiritual ends. The Law is also beautiful in that it is an expression of God's beautiful will, and if truly obeyed, it always spreads beauty and luster.

If the Judaizers were then hot and heavy on the heels of Paul, dogging his footsteps through the latter part of his life, they could never say in truth he was against the Law, an antinomian. The ancient Judaizers accused him, however, exactly of this, and the modern legalists accuse anyone of this who dares to maintain on Scriptural ground that the Law was given to Israel, not to the Body of Christ "My kinsmen after the flesh. . . whose is the lawgiving" (Rom. 9:3,4). God gave it to Israel, not to the members of His beloved Son. God gave it not for salvation or justification or sanctification, but for the very end expressed in verse 13, "that sin by the commandment might become exceeding sinful." In 3:19 the Law stopped every mouth and threw all the world as guilty before God. In Galatians 3:19 he also says that the Law was "added because of transgressions," that is, the object of the Law was to make sin transgression, rebellion. The Law is good but this good became Israel's greatest enemy of God's best.

We know the law is spiritual - but I am carnal (7:14).

We seem to have here a contradiction to the statement of Hebrews 9:10 where the things of the Law are called "carnal ordinances." Yet here is no real conflict at all. The Law is spiritual inasmuch as it came from a spiritual source, God's holiness, and is essentially spiritual in character as the expression of His holy will. It is also spiritual in its holy design for Israel, to serve as the pedagogue or boy-leader until Christ should come. The Law was carnal not in the sense of the hostile flesh, which is at enmity against God, but in the sense of the bodily, material things of earth, for the earthly nation had its citizenship on the earth in Palestine, not in heaven as we do. All the dietary laws of eating and drinking were for the body of flesh. In that sense the legal enactments of Mt. Horeb were carnal ordinances, but for the rest they were spiritual; but here the apostle felt keenly the contrast to the spiritual, divine, and perfect Law in which he had a delight and his own carnality as a sinner before God. Evidently he has before his mind the tenth commandment forbidding even the secret lust of the flesh. He compares himself to a slave that is sold. "Carnal" is here *sarkikos,* fleshly in the ethical sense, in contrast to *sarkinos,* which is fleshly in the material sense, the flesh of the body. Paul means to bring out the utter futility of using the Law as a means of deliverance, as so many do.

The law is spiritual - I am carnal, sold under sin (7:14).

The Arminians and many others hit upon the last two declarations of this verse as their ground for the belief that Paul speaks here as an unsaved man or of another unregenerate person. As far as being carnal is concerned, we know the whole Corinthian church is called carnal in 1 Corinthians 3:3, 4, a clear proof carnality can exist in saints (1 Cor. 1:2), and in those who wait for the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ (1:7). It is certain Paul did not describe himself as carnal in the later years of his life, for he grew in grace, knowledge, and practical sanctity and spirituality. It is evident

we should think of Paul here in his early time after his conversion when he had as yet no clear concept of the great distinction between Law and grace, and when he like so many today tried to use the Law as a means to more holiness.

It is a most remarkable and noteworthy fact that this legal endeavor exerted exactly the same effect upon him as it does upon believers today. His autobiographical experience is here prophetic and typical of all the legalistic struggles of true believers. Note, however, that he does not say, I was carnal, but, "I am carnal," "sold under sin." This is another strong phrase which could not be said of him in the prison of Rome when he was ready to lay down his head on Nero's block, but it could be said of him once upon a time. The word *pepramenos* points to the traffic of humans in the slave market. He still has hovering before his mind the picture of sin as a harsh tyrant, who makes him, the unhappy slave, groan. When we know the human heart with all its sewage as mentioned by Christ in Matthew 15:18-20, and that even the thought of foolishness is sin (Prov. 24:9), then we can readily underscore this strong expression. Many seem to have only a faint concept of sin. They think sin consists only in deliberate choices of the will and in manifest deeds of evil. They acknowledge, in other words, sins, but no sin as an evil of the human heart, but Paul does know that inner corruption.

For what I would that I do not - but what I hate, that do I (7:15).

The first word "do" here should be rendered practice, for the word prasso is used and then poieo. There has been a theological question for centuries whether a regenerate or an unregenerate person speaks here, but believers who do not live shallow all know that we have here a Biblical psychology that is as true as it is profound. The whole chapter speaks of a believer who has not come to full clarity regarding the Law in his new life and who struggles to attain to sanctity with the help of the Law. It describes Paul in the first period of his new life and before the Lord gave him the full blaze of the Mystery truth. He had to learn by experience that the Law does not provide sanctity any more than salvation, and that we have Christ as the all-sufficient Savior for both.

For that which I do I allow not (7:15-17).

These words introduced by the reason "for" give the proof of his startling statement that he is sold under sin. The bungling translation goes to prove that the worthy translators did not understand the author. There are three words which all have been simply rendered "do," whereas the first verb means work out. "Allow" should be know, or acknowledge. The first phrase evidently means that he hardly recognized responsibility for his own doings. What he at heart yearns to do, he does not practice, thus the second word should be translated. The last verb, poio, is rightly rendered. His very struggle proves that he is not against the Law, but that on the other hand he takes it very seriously. Both his yearnings and his failures show clearly that he does not take the precepts of the Law lightly.

Now then it is no more I that do it - but sin that dwelleth in me (7:17).

Psychologically and ethically verse 17 is a most difficult verse, because it seems Paul hides behind a dual personality and that his wrongs do not come forth from his "I," but from indwelling sins. In other words, it seems that he throws his responsibility away.

Can a believer who has done wrong now say, "I have not done it, but my indwelling sin has?"

We can never grasp this terrible struggle of the apostle unless we recognize the fact of the believer's two natures. The old nature has seven scriptural names:

- Flesh
- Heart
- Sin
- Carnal mind
- The old man
- The outward man
- The natural man

Here he calls it sin that dwells in him. Evidently after his conversion he did not see what many still do not see, that the old man was crucified with Christ, and he started to wrestle against that old man with the help of the Law and Lawkeeping, exactly as so many do in this late day. In fact, the very object of this section seems to be to show from Paul's telling example the dire results that inevitably come when believers fail to see their old man was crucified with Christ and commence to improve themselves by means of Law-keeping. Negatively, it all strongly points to Christ and to Him alone.

Antinomians have abused this word as an excuse for sinning and to relinquish all individual responsibility. Paul simply means to say that this new "I," his new life, does not sin, but that "the old man" is bound by indwelling sin. This is exactly what John means when he says he who is born of God does not sin, or live in sin. The new man in Christ cannot sin, while the old Adamic nature cannot but sin. Note that he does not say sin is in us, but that it dwells, has its home in us.

For to will is present with me - but how to perform that which is good I find not (7:18).

The Savior's word in the garden, "the spirit is willing but the flesh is weak," is an appropriate commentary on this paradox. The "willing" comes from the good Spirit, the non performance is due to the weak flesh. The flesh is not only weak, but incapacitated. Here again is a more profound psychology than Sigmund Freud has put in his basic studies. The experience of the pious has always given its consent to this statement of Paul. If believers know anything at all, it is that they have a certain dualism of willing and failing in them, due to the Spirit and the flesh, and the old and the new nature. This strange duality is not found in the unsaved person and hence we have here a strong proof that a regenerate man is speaking and not an unrenewed man.

Christ judges men by their will. "Ye would not," he said in Luke 13:34. "We will not have this man to reign over us" (Luke 19:14). "Ye will not come to me" (John 5:40). "The lusts of your father ye will do"(8:44). That the good will is not found in the natural man is evinced by Philippians 2:13; he works in us both to will and to do. Even on the last page of His Book He says, "Whosoever will, let him take of the water of life." In all our

worship, prayer, praise, almsgiving, soul-winning, testifying, and in our defense of the truth, Christians daily prove to themselves the truth of this Bible psychology.

I know that in me (that is in my flesh) dwelleth no good thing (7:18-20).

According to Stifler, we have here three dirges :the first in verses 15-17; the second in verses 18-20; the third in verses 21-24. Flesh is only another name for the old nature; therein dwells no good thing. It is a silly subterfuge to say it is there but does not dwell there. No good thing is there. The flesh is always the same. It cannot grow better. Even before the flood it was "only evil continually," and since that day it has proven over and over the truth of this statement. It is as incorrigible as the Devil himself, but it can be refined by learning and culture, and be made religious by its proud will. All religions and ritualisms have their stronghold in the flesh. Man has been called a religious animal. The flesh is not opposed to religion. Rather, it favors religion, but it hates Christ as Lord and fights his Spirit.

We must be careful not to equate the body with the flesh. The body is God's creation and bought with a great price, a member of Christ, a temple of the Spirit and soon to be made like unto his glorious body. The body can be, and often is, an organ of the flesh. While it is temporarily a body of death, it *is per se* good, but the flesh in the Pauline sense, as used here, is always wrong. Flesh is also used, of course, to denote all mankind and to describe the tender parts of our body and then it has no ethical valuation. It seems Paul in verse 20 again throws the responsibility for any sin away from him upon the indwelling sin. His "I" in such cases stands for the new man in Christ Jesus. That new man does not sin and cannot sin. The indwelling sin does all the sinning. He does not mean, however, to dodge here personal accountability. If even the sinner is responsible, how much more is the saint accountable. The accountability of man as a rational, moral, and emotional being is silently presupposed in all God's dealings with man.

For the good that I would I do not - but the evil which I would not, that I do (7:19).

This paradox also makes it evident that a believer is speaking here. In fact, here are two proofs for the thesis that an unbeliever does not say this, as practically all Arminian theologians believe. In the first place, a soul dead in sins could never truly say he would do the good, i.e., that which is pleasing to God. Nor could he, in the second place, declare in truth that he would not do the evil. The sinner drinks in sin like water, but when God begins the good work in us, making us a new creature in Christ, then we in principle shun evil and love the good, the holy, and the true.

Now if I do that I would not, it is no more I that do it - but sin that dwelleth in me (7:20).

A false mysticism has sometimes abused this word. Antinomianism could hide behind it and shirk the responsibility. On the surface there seems to be a flat contradiction; "I do - no more I that do it." He means to say that it is not the new man that sins, but the old and hateful indwelling sin.

I delight in the law of God - after the inward man (7:22).

An unbeliever has no inward man in the Pauline sense, and neither can he say he has a delight in the Law of God. Paul uses the word "law" here in five different senses, and outside these verses in Romans, in four more places:

• In verse 21 law simply means a rule; its primary significance is a normative, regulating principle.

• The "law of God" is the Mosaic Law in its entirety, not simply the so-called moral Law or the decalogue.

• "Another law" is the ruling principle of the flesh with all its appetites and standing often in opposition to the Law of God.

• The "law of my mind" is the rule of his new nature. Not merely his better self, but the new man in Christ, called "law of mind," because he sees with his intellect the will of God by faith.

• The "law of sin" is the rule of sin through the infirmity of the flesh.

• The "law of faith" means the regulative, normative power of belief (3:27).

• He mentions the "law of the Spirit" (8:2), meaning thereby the Spirit's operation in him.

• In verse 2 he spoke of the "law of her husband."

• In 9:31 he speaks of the "law of righteousness" twice. In whatever sense he uses law, it is clear he always understands a power by it which rules and governs our lives, just as the Mosaic Law had to regulate the lives of Israel. Expositors have been much confused by these different uses of the word law, but there is no need of it if we simply remember that in whatever sense it appears it has as its basic thought a power that regulates our actions.

The "law of God" in this sweet confession should be taken in the sense of the whole Old Testament. Paul puts himself here in the class with David, the man after God's heart, who also could be enraptured at the wonder of the Law as we see in Psalm 19 and 119. This sweet testimony suffices alone to refute the idea that an unsaved man said this.

I delight in the law of God after the inward man - but I see another law - warring (7:23).

As a Hebrew believer, his delight was like that of David in the Law of God. The inward man is the same as the new man in Christ. Opposed to this is the flesh that will not subject itself to the Law of God.

Oh wretched man - and the thankful man (7:24,25).

No unsaved man could be vanquished as this man was, and no sinner could be victorious as this wrestler was. No sinner could be so self-condemnatory before God as this man is. He carried on an incessant war against indwelling sin, an irrefutable proof he was not a sinner dead in trespasses, for the dead do not engage in warfare, let alone spiritual warfare. Who shall deliver me? The sinner dead in sins does not ask for deliverance. It is also clear, on the other hand, that he could not yet celebrate the

victory and shout the paean of triumph as he does at the end of the next chapter. He is describing himself not as apart from Christ, like many think, but as a babe in Christ soon after his conversion, when he did not as a Jew have the full light on Law and grace. With the help of the Law he was still trying to down the old man and make himself better, and thereby be pleasing to God and have God pleased with him.

The "body of this death" is the human body viewed as dying and on the way to death and as an instrument of temptation and sin. He longs for the complete deliverance of the body (8:23; 1 Cor. 15:53-54; Phil. 3:21). Wretched as he may feel himself to be, he is not in despair, for he can yet praise God and his Deliverer, the Lord Jesus Christ.

His conclusion in the last verse is amazing when we realize that "serve" is serve as a slave. With his mind or new nature he is slaving for God and His Law, but with the flesh, or in the flesh, he slaves for the law of sin. We see here clearly the thought that the flesh of a saved person is slowly improving runs absolutely counter to the Word of God. It is impossible to grow out of the old nature as a viper is growing out of its old skin and a hen out of her old feathers. There is no eradication of the flesh either. No improvement and no eradication, but a counter-balancing of the two by the power of the Holy Spirit; better still, the suppression of the one.

CHAPTER 8

MORE THAN CONQUERORS

There is therefore now no condemnation (8:1).

Expositors have wondered over the "therefore" in this verse, asking themselves what conclusion upon prior grounds is given here. The word *katakrina is* the verdict of guilt and penalty thundered down from the judge in his judgment seat. The word is used in the New Testament only three times, and then only in this book (5:16,18). Here it unquestionably harps back to the former two passages where God judicially, through the offense of Adam, brought *katakrina* upon all men. God did not send His Son in the world to condemn the world. Reverently speaking He could not do this for the simple reason that He had condemned the world of mankind long ago because of Adam's one offense. The unbeliever is condemned already (John 3:17, 18).

In the fifth chapter he showed that the last Adam did far more than undo the mischief of the first. In the sixth chapter he showed that the old Adam of the believers has died with Christ, that the new man has risen with Christ and now our life and standing is judicially that of Christ in the sight of God. The first and last part of chapter 7 also points to Christ, and now with an eye upon Him, he says "therefore." Apart from Christ, the *katakrina,* or wrath of God, still rests upon the sinner (John 3:36). He that believes in Christ does not come into the future judgment, but is passed out of death into life (John 5:24).

Faith is God's act in us that incorporates us into Christ, the only refuge for the storm of God's judgment. The "no" comes here first to show that it is most emphatic; but just as certain that there is no judgment for the persons of believers, so sure it is that there is a fiery judgment waiting for all those who are out of Christ.

The ark is the picture here. Those who were in the ark were safe from the judgment waters, those who were out drowned like rats. Another flood is coming, a flood not of water but of fire, and the supreme necessity is that we are in Christ. On good manuscript authority the last clause is left out.

What the Law could not do (8:2, 3a).

The legalists had too exalted a notion, not so much of the Law, but of themselves. They did not realize their own flesh made the Law important. A king might be ever so clever and good, but he would be totally powerless if he reigned over a nation of drunks or idiots. His impotence in that case would not be dire to him, but to his subjects. The Law was a divine ruling force pointing out the duty of perfect obedience. This demand of the Law was not too high, but it was far more than the flesh could give. This is exactly the problem of all law and all moralizings based upon it. Law demands perfect obedience, but can never give it. It can never improve the flesh so as to give it capacity to obey and do all that is written. Pharisaism completely forgot this, and Galatianism, which is aware of it a little, wants the grace of God to help the flesh keep the Law. Christendom is full of this Galatianism.

It took God two thousand years to demonstrate the inability of man to keep the Law and the resultant impotence of the Law with such subjects. After that God did not improve the flesh but set aside the Law until the day He shall fill Israel with His Spirit and cause the restored nation to keep all His statutes.

There is no amount of philosophy, illumination and education that can make man a perfect Law-keeper. With his best intentions man always falls down headlong into disobedience, which is rebellion. When the Law revealed its impotence, because of the flesh, God did not look around for some other legal scheme, but He fell back upon His Son, if we may so say. God has no cure for any ill but His Son. He took from His bosom His own beloved Son and sent Him into the world for the purpose, not of improving the flesh, but to condemn sin in the flesh. A fork is good but if the meat is too tender and weak, the fork cannot hold it. A good anchor is worthless in a muddy bottom of the sea.

God sent his own Son in the likeness of sinful flesh (8:3b).

Here we must carefully guard the absolute sinlessness of the Savior, and at the same time maintain the real humanity of our Savior. He did not come merely in the likeness of flesh as the Docetics taught, but in "the likeness of sinful flesh." The Holy Spirit in this phrase has thus carefully avoided two errors; on the one hand of making Christ sinful, on the other of making Him unreal by denying His real humanity.

The word *homoioma is* used, and is found also in 1:23; 5:14; 6:5. In the little varied form of *homoios,* it is the word invariably used in the Gospels to denote the likeness of the parables. It denotes a general likeness, as the above texts prove, but not an identity. Perfect identity is expressed by the word isos. Christ made himself *isos* with God (John 5:18). Christ thought it not robbery to be isos with God (Phil. 2:6), but He was made in the likeness, *homoioma,* of men (Phil. 2:7). Someday we shall be *homoios,* like Christ, but not identical with Him (1 John 3:2). He is made like unto His brethren, not *isos*. He was in all points tempted like as we are (Heb. 4:15), not *isos*. He was made after the similitude of Melchisedec, clear proof, by the way, that Christ was not identical, *isos*, with Melchisedec, as many teach. The Greek positively forbids this thought (7:15).

Here we see then that our Lord did not become identical with us as sinful beings under the curse. On the other hand, He came in the likeness of sinful flesh, which means far more than that He possessed a real human nature of body and soul. It tells us clearly that Christ did not take a nature as Adam had before the fall but as He had after His sin, though sin itself excepted. Christ had a body that could hunger and thirst, fatigue and faint, suffer and die as His subsequent sufferings clearly proved. If Christ had possessed a sinful flesh, then He would have been judged and could not have been our surety and substitute, but God sent Him to the Cross that there He might condemn sin once for all.

Condemned sin in the flesh (8:3c, 4).

God can forgive sins, but not sin, the evil root of sins, the fount from which all the poisonous waters bubble up to flow throughout all the earth. God has never pardoned sin and neither has He ever forgiven sin. The Law could only condemn us. It asked a perfect righteousness but could not give it; but in the gospel the righteousness of God has been revealed (1:17). The Law was weak, for sinners are without strength to do

anything but sin (5:6). The first word of the Law is "thou," and there it breaks down since it lays all the weight of responsibility on man's weak shoulders. For sin, i.e., with a direct reference to sin, Christ gave Himself as an offering for us (1 John 2:2). Not by His holy life but by His death on the cross He totally condemned, as the verb *katakrina* denotes, the sin, i.e., the Adamic world-sin that had become the universal indwelling sin in the flesh.

In order to understand this by faith, we must realize that God as Judge treated Christ as the sinful old Adam. He was made sin for us that we might be made the righteousness of God in Him. God condemned sins homopathically with sin as seen in the story of the brazen serpent in the desert. Having nailed old Adam to the cross, He counts him judicially dead and He wants us to do likewise, to reckon him dead indeed. He now in no-wise ever reckons with the old Adam or sin. On this side of the Cross He would not write a book of kings or any book of the Old Testament. He is completely through with old Adam and reckons us as in the Son of all His pleasure.

What was the purpose of the Cross? To save us? Yes, but not primarily. The purpose was that the righteousness which the Law demanded in vain for two thousand years might be fulfilled, fully realized, in us, who now, after Calvary, walk no longer after the flesh, but after the Spirit. There are two sorts of walkers in life's highways; the flesh walkers and the Spirit walkers. In the first seventeen verses of this chapter the writer contrasts these two different kinds of walkers. To grasp this simplifies matters.

Walk after the flesh - walk after the Spirit (8:4).

Walk is the metaphor used for the life of the believer, since Enoch walked with God. Paul uses this telling figure time and again. We are not to associate our idea of walk with the Scriptural idea, for this is not merely a walk around the block to limber up after riding in a car, but the long and weary trek through the desert of life. It stands for the purpose, progress, point, perpetuity, and perspiration of life in all its manifestations. It includes both the inner and the outer life. This life can be activated by the flesh and governed by the unruly passions and appetites of the body, and then it is a walk after or in accordance with the flesh. When the Spirit motivates our life, then it is a walk governed by the Spirit.

Mind things of the flesh - mind things of the Spirit (8:5).

With "mind" Paul means the ruling intellect, the bubbling emotions, and also the lever of the will. Biblical psychology differs from modern psychology. With the apostle it includes the whole soul-life, hence to set the heart or the soul upon the appetites of the flesh, just as we see it all around us today in practical materialism! The wild flesh is here the master that leads the soul into perdition. How different it is when the whole heart and soul is set upon the things of the Spirit, upon Christ, upon the Word, upon His Body, the church, upon lost souls, and upon His reappearing.

They that are after the flesh (8:5).

The word flesh, *sarx*, is the great word in the first half of this chapter. It is found fourteen times in the first thirteen verses of this chapter. The flesh must not by any means be identified with the body as many sects have ignorantly done. The body is a beautiful creation of God. God loves it more than we ourselves could ever do. He not

only wonderfully made it, but he also paid a great price for it in the blood of His Son; He made it a member of Christ (1 Cor. 6:15); the temple of the Holy Ghost (19, 20), and soon He shall transform it into the image of His son. But the flesh, though this sometimes stands for the body, is in the Pauline sense a wicked thing, enmity to God, and striving against the Spirit.

Paul uses the word "flesh" ninety-eight times and often in the unfavorable sense of the evil organ of sin. The flesh is per *se* not unalterable, for it can be made moral, refined, religious, churchy, and even quasi-spiritual, but it is unimprovable towards God. God never tries to improve it. Regeneration and the new creation are not an improvement of the flesh. It always produces after its kind, for what is born of the flesh is flesh (John 3:6). A visit to Paradise does not ameliorate the flesh, for Paul had such a trip and then needed a prophylactic for the pride of the flesh. The Holy Spirit does not improve it, for the Spirit wars against the flesh, which puts up a hopeless fight against this divine indwelling Guest. The new nature of the believer does not make the flesh better, as the previous chapter goes to prove, because there is also a conflict between the two natures.

What must be the attitude of the saint toward the *sarx?* We should make no provision for it, but reckon it as condemned by Christ on the cross. Though the flesh is in us, we are no longer in the flesh. Those in the flesh cannot please God (verse 8). That is also true of the religious flesh. Millions are blinded by the churchianity and religiosity of the flesh, but no ritualistic form can ever please God who sent the Son to condemn sin in the flesh.

To be carnally minded is death - but to be spiritually minded is life and peace (8:6).

We have here the same contrast as above with the two inevitable results - death and life.

For to be carnally minded is death (8:6-8).

The walk after the flesh ends in death, yea, it is death. It literally speaks of the minding of the flesh. The flesh deals not always in smut and slime and slush, as popular thought often conceives of it. The phrase *phronema tou pneumatos* can teach us differently. The flesh loves to deal in mentalities and moralities, and is also adept in metaphysics. True, in its lower forms the flesh goes down, but it also loves to go up to the temple and worship in carnal forms. It favors greatly the seminary chairs and the lecture platforms and the church pulpit in order to roll down from these exalted places pious and pompous platitudes that mystify or please the thoughtless throngs. God rips off all its pious masks when He declares that the carnal mind is enmity against God. *Echthra is* also the word used for the enmity between Herod and Pilate (Luke 23:12). In Galatians 5:20 it is rendered hatred. The friendship of the world is enmity with God (Jas. 4:4). The word denotes a deadly and implacable hostility. Five things are here said of the *sarx:*

- The minding of the flesh is death; spiritual and eternal.
- The minding of the flesh is a deadly foeman of God.

• The minding of the flesh is not subject to God's law, or will. Here all the moralists and legalists suffer a complete shipwreck. "Going about to establish their own righteousness, have not submitted themselves unto the righteousness of God."

• The minding of the flesh can indeed in no wise be subject to the Word of God. In reference to divine things the mind is totally impotent.

• They that are in the flesh are not able to please God. God is through with the old man. He is now under condemnation and wrath (John 3:36). Those in the flesh, those who have no faith, are unsaved for without faith it is impossible to please God (Heb. 11:6).

In the flesh - in the Spirit (8:8-9).

Here the flesh and Spirit are the two contrasting spheres that envelop the personality. When flesh is contrasted to the Spirit, it invariably stands with Paul for the old and evil Adamic principle of the old nature.

In the spirit (8:9).

Romans 8 is the chapter of the Holy Spirit. Not less than twenty-one times is He mentioned in this chapter. This phrase is the perfect contrast to the "in the flesh." The Spirit is called the "Spirit of God" and the "Spirit of Christ." All through this grand chapter he is closely connected with Christ and the Christians. There is in fact a striking similarity between the Spirit's relation to Christ and to us:

• Christ was conceived by the Spirit. We are born of the Spirit, as John has it.

• The Spirit was the Father's promised gift to Christ (Matt. 12:18). He is also the Spirit of promise to us.

• At His baptism Christ was sealed with the Spirit (Mark 1:10). At our baptism into His death, we were sealed with the Spirit.

• He was full of the Spirit (Luke 4:1). We are to be filled with the Spirit (Eph. 5:18).

• The Spirit was the sphere in which Jesus moved (Luke 4:14). We are said to be in the Spirit.

• He was led by the Spirit into the desert. Often the Spirit leads us into howling deserts.

• The Spirit was the power of Christ's ministry (Luke 4:18). We cannot do real service for God except by the Spirit, the source of all power.

• He cast out devils by the energy of the Spirit (Matt. 12:28). When energized by the indwelling Spirit, we give no place to the devil, but rather cast him out.

• The Spirit was the anointing, enabling him to go about doing good (Acts 10:38). So the Spirit alone can enable us to do persistently good.

• Jesus rejoiced in the Spirit. The fruit of the Spirit for us is joy (Gal. 5:22).

• He offered Himself by the Spirit (Heb. 9:14). We can never lead a self-sacrificing life except by the Spirit of Christ.

• He was evidently raised by the Spirit's might. Our mortal bodies also shall be quickened by His Spirit (verse 11).

• The Spirit justified Christ (1 Tim. 3:16). We also are justified by the Spirit.

• He breathed the Spirit upon His disciples (John 20:22). We by the Spirit's power should lead others to Christ. The Spirit of God dwells in every believer, but He does not fill every believer.

If Christ be in you, the body is dead, because of sin (8:10).

The idea of this difficult verse may be paraphrased thus:

> Since then Christ dwells in you, your body is on the way to death on account of the Adamic sin, but your spirit, the inner man, is life on account of the righteousness of the cross.

Just as the flesh is used for the whole man as he has sprung from Adam, so also the body, *soma*, is used in the same sense. He has spoken in this context of:

• The body of sin (6:6).

• The body of this death (7:24).

• The deeds of the body (8:13).

Taken in this sense, the body must be regarded as dead, *nekros,* from which we get our necrology. The word is here perhaps dying on the way to death. In this sense the body of the flesh must be put off (Col. 2:11). Our existence on earth, the duration of our mundane life, is often expressed by the phrase "in the body" (2 Cor. 5:6, 8, 10; 12:2, 3; Heb. 13:3).

The word "righteousness" in the last clause shows that Paul does not forget for one moment the great theme of his epistle. He knows too well salvation does not rest upon the shifting sands of human thought and feelings. He realizes our everlasting consolation does not merely flow from the largeheartedness or tender mercies of God, but out of the satisfaction and merited righteousness of Christ. The blood declares God's righteousness (Rom. 3:23-26); the gospel manifests it (1:17); Christ's obedience made many righteous (5:18, 19). The sins are now not imputed to the believer, but to Christ (4:8; 2 Cor. 5:19, 21). It is not by works of righteousness which we have done (Tit. 3:5-7), for by the deeds of the Law shall no flesh be justified in His sight (Rom. 3:20). God is the efficient cause of our justification (Rom. 3:20). Christ's blood is the meritorious cause (Rom. 5:9). Faith is the apprehensive, appropriating cause (Rom. 5:1; 3:25). Good works are the experimental, evidential cause of our justification (Jas. 2:21).

He shall also quicken your mortal bodies - by his Spirit that dwelleth in you (8:11).

He has just shown that the basis of all holy living lies in God's righteousness as merited by Christ. The fundamental thought of this verse is that upon that basis God raised up Christ, a thought that appeared before in 4:25. Christ was raised not unto but because of our justification through His blood. He reasons further that if God raised up Jesus Christ upon that basis, He will surely, upon the same solid ground, raise those who have been justified, and all the more so since the Spirit of Christ has His home in

them. In the same manner as the Father raised up Christ by the Spirit, so He will also do this by His Spirit for His own.

This verse then is primarily eschatological, i.e., it looks forward to the glad resurrection day, when our mortal, deeply humiliated, and even corrupted bodies shall be made conformable to His glorious body.

The *dia* with the genitive case should not be translated as the margin has it, "because of." The meaning then would be that God cannot forsake those into whom He has poured out His Spirit, and in whom that Spirit has made His home. Though this thought is in itself blessedly true., yet that is not the grammatical idea. *Dia* with the genitive always means through, and in this sense it implies that the Holy Spirit who raised up Christ, will also be the agent effecting our resurrection from the graves. For the same thought see 2 Corinthians 1:22; Ephesians 1:13; 4:30.

Note his uses of the name Jesus in the first part and Christ alone in the middle of the verse. Six times in Romans he uses the historical name Jesus, carried by three others in the New Testament; Jesus or Joshua, Jesus Justus, and Bar-Jesus. This sixfold use of Jesus in Romans ought to keep us from harshly condemning those who use the name Jesus. The name Christ alone is used thirty-four times in Romans, Christ Jesus fourteen times, and Jesus Christ sixteen times. It is, however, not so easy to state the why and wherefore of such a particular use in each case.

If ye live after the flesh - ye shall die (8:12-13).

All through this section the writer has hovering before his mind sharp contrasts which he describes in five couplets:

• Two spheres in which to live and move; "in the flesh" and "in the spirit." Or simply in flesh and in spirit, which perhaps in this case should not be capitalized, since it seems to stand for the new nature.

• Two attracting magnets; after the flesh and after the Spirit.

• Two minds: of the flesh and of the Spirit. • Two results: death and life.

• Two classes of people: the carnal and the spiritual.

But who are the brethren? He says in the next verse, "if ye live after the flesh, ye shall die." Can brethren live after the flesh? And can brethren, i.e., true believers, "die?" Mauro and others declare that both are true of Christians, and many agree with him, but Paul never draws such deep lines of cleavage between the true saints. There are in the main six thoughts on this:

• We have here only a general warning for believers and unbelievers; but this is too general and too un-Pauline. Paul does not use truth as a bogey man!

• The unsaved are meant, but two things militate against this idea: Paul never turns aside to warn the unsaved; the unbelievers are not addressed as "brethren" (verse 12), unless it would be in a national sense.

• Mauro and others claim only true believers are addressed, but how can they die? And how can they walk after the flesh? This is the difficulty here.

• The believers are threatened here with the warning and death of the Corinthian church, where many had fallen asleep as the result of their unhallowed and indiscriminate use of the Lord's table (1 Cor. 11:30).

• The brethren are Jewish brethren, and this does per se not mean they were truly saved.

• Upon renewed thought on this difficult statement, it seems to us unavoidable that Paul, as generally, speaks here of true believers, but from the viewpoint of the reward and status in the Kingdom in connection with the adoption, or the special son-status. He says warningly to the carnal who walk in the flesh, "Ye are about to die." In verse 18 he says contrastively, "The glory about to be revealed unto us." At His appearing He will reward death to the carnal believers, like the Corinthians in that they will remain in the graves and not reign with Christ over all things. In that sense they have no part in the Kingdom of Christ.

"Ye shall live" cannot mean eternal or everlasting life for they have this as a gift. The life after the millennial kingdom is theirs as a sovereign gift. The life here is another name for the prize of their calling. In verse 17 he clearly refers to it conditionally, "If so be that we suffer with Him." Our Lord used life in this sense in Matthew 18:8; 19:17; Mark 9:43-47; and Luke 18:29, 30.

We must here not dogmatize but search for more light, because the truth of the reward of grace has never been fully worked out, though it is found throughout the Scriptures and also clearly in the prison epistles. The New Testament alone speaks over 200 times about it.

For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God (8:14).

Where he previously left it an open question whether they were truly saved, he now gives them a proof of true sonship. The leading of the Spirit is the proof. God's leadings are often wonderful. He led Israel of old through the deep waters and through the howling deserts, and later He led the little faithful remnant through the fire and through the lion's den. If now His leadings may not be so marvelous, they are just as sure and faithful. He does not lead by the pillar and the cloud and by the urim and thummim, but He does lead in reality from glory to glory, and all the time the path of sonship is the proof and privilege of sonship. Leading implies a path, and Christ is the Way; and a terminal, and heaven is the grand terminal. Mystics often abuse this leading of the Spirit in that they sever this leading from the Word, but seeing the blessed Spirit inspired God's Word, why should He turn around and neglect it in this leading? No, He holds the Word as a light upon our path when He leads the sons to glory. If the mystics ignore the Word, the Rationalists generally neglect the Spirit in this leading.

Both are lopsided, because God leads His own through the Spirit and the Word. But where lies the power of the proof of sonship in this leading? In the fact that strangers, aliens, and foes are not led, but only sons. If the Spirit leads us then this is a proof that we are sons and not aliens. However, while Israel's leadings were national, miraculous, terrestrial, and physical, our leading is personal, unmiraculous, heavenly, and spiritual. We should not forget that the leading of the Spirit demands on our part a leaning, trusting, and childlike docility. We must not run ahead nor lag behind. The coming

manifestation of the sons of God will be the end of the leading (verse 19). May we until that day lean hard upon His leading.

The Spirit of bondage (8:15a).

The definite article should be deleted, for the Greek does not have it. In contrast to the Holy Spirit the apostle speaks in his letters of the spirit of the world (1 Cor. 2:12), the spirit of fear (2 Tim. 1:7), seducing spirits (1 Tim. 4:1), and a spirit of bondage. All these stand in direct opposition to the Holy Spirit Who is here called the Spirit of adoption, or son-placing.

A contrast is here drawn between the Old Testament with its spirit of bondage and its many legal fears. The word *adair* is a hint that there should be no retrogression, no leap backward to the economy of the law, no going back. The word for adoption is *huothesia,* literally son-placing. The vulgar thought is generally that the ungodly have been adopted as God's babies, just as childless couples now go to a children's home to adopt a baby, but this thought is far from this term. This word belongs to Israel and to the believing Jews who had been born from above. In those days, however, when a boy reached twelve he was considered as a son who could help himself, and this fact was celebrated with a ceremony in the public market. The garments of a man and a little dagger with which to defend himself were given him. He was placed publicly as a son, and was henceforth not to be treated as a little child.

Without the metaphor, the Jews were the children. The types taught them as pictures teach little children. But the Spirit had now been given and He led them as sons (verse 14) to the future manifestation (verse 19). The whole beautiful contrast between the children under the Law and the adult sons in grace has most regrettably been lost in bungling translations that do not differentiate between the two different concepts of *tekna,* children, and *huios*, sons. The son-placing is found only five times in the New Testament (Gal. 4:5; Eph. 1:5; Rom. 9:4) and twice in this chapter (verses 14 and 23). In Romans alone it is used in three different senses:

• As a past fact (verse 15).

• As the future fact of the resurrection, when the bodies will also be publicly adopted (verse 23).

• As the national adoption of Israel as the firstborn son among the nations.

Abba Father (8:15b).

We meet this peculiar phrase three times:

• In the garden by our Lord (Mark 14:36).

• At this place where it is laid in the mouth of all believers.

• In Galatians 4:6 where it is the Holy Spirit who cries it in our hearts.

It is a double use of the word father, only the former is Aramaic and the latter Greek. It is the language of Jew and Greek, i.e., of the whole world. Abba is the first sound a suckling can utter.

The Spirit is the "Spirit of prayer and supplication," as we see here. Believers have three that pray for them:

• Christ intercedes in heaven where He ever liveth to make intercession for us.

• The Holy Spirit prays in our hearts with groanings that cannot be uttered.

• The believers generally have some Christian friends who pray for them.

The first two intercessors, however, pray always according to the will of God. If it is true what some say, that the slaves were not allowed to use the word abba and that it was confined only to sons, then this word is elevated into greater spiritual beauty.

This praying could not be prayed under the bondage of the Law. There God was never addressed as Father. God was Father of Israel in a theocratic sense but not in an individual sense. Our Savior was the first to pray this prayer in the garden. This prayer can further only be breathed in an atmosphere of liberty and absence from fear. Perfect love casts out fear, and fear also casts out perfect love. There are then three conditions of this lovely little prayer:

• We must not have the spirit of legal bondage.

• We must not have the Old Testament fear.

• We must have received the spirit of adoption in our heart.

The Spirit itself beareth witness (8:16).

Our fathers have either rendered the neuter *pneuma* literally or they have not possessed a clear sense of the personality of the Spirit of God. The mystics have often taken both the leading and the witness of the Spirit erroneously as a special voice from above in their heart entirely apart from the word of God, but it is a witness with our spirit in the closest connection with the Word. It is the Spirit speaking through the Word. Right here is a much used gateway of Satan and his host of evil spirits, for if the Word and Spirit do not fill our hearts, then his majesty likes to put in his still, small voice of seduction. As an angel of light he will whisper something religious, and religiously inclined people who are not subject to the Word and therefore not disciplined by it, will think it is from the Holy Spirit. Thus false revelations have come to Mohammed, Joseph Smith, and many minor heretical lights. The witness has nothing to do with new revelations but with the illuminating, consoling, assuring fact that we are the children of God.

As to the Spirit, the following things are said of Him:

• What the Law was for Israel is now in us the law of the governing power of the Spirit (verse 2).

• We walk after the Spirit (verse 4).

• The Spirit is a Person, but has things (verse 5).

• The mind of the Spirit is life and peace (verse 6).

• We dwell not in the flesh, but are in the sphere of the Spirit (verse 9).

• The Spirit has His home in us (verse 9), as an abiding Guest. If we have not the Spirit, we are not a Christian (verse 9).

• The Spirit raised up Jesus (verse 11).

• Our resurrection shall be by the agency of the Spirit (verse 11).

• Through the Spirit we mortify the deeds of the body (verse 13).

• We are led by the Spirit (verse 14).

• We have received the Spirit of adoption (verse 15).

• The Spirit bears witness with our spirit (verse 16).

• In verse 23 we have the firstfruits of the Spirit.

• He helps our infirmities in verse 26.

• The Spirit makes intercession for us with unutterable groanings (verse 26).

• The Spirit makes intercession for the saints according to the will of God (verse 27).

It is clear that the new life is completely regulated by the Spirit every step of the way.

If we suffer with Him -We may be also glorified together (8:17).

This "if' seems to be no if of argument but of condition, as in 2 Timothy 2:12. A fair exegesis makes the conclusion inescapable that our future reign as kings with Him is conditional upon our readiness to suffer with Him in the day of His rejection and reproach. Our native sense of justice says amen to this arrangement. It is an undeniable fact that there are millions of believers in Christ who stay on the popular side of things and manifest it in all their life that they refuse to go outside the camp to bear His reproach. God in grace and loving kindness does not compel them in this matter, but He has clearly warned them that their refusal to suffer with Him now will mean they cannot reign as Kings with Him during His thousand year reign. We may meet these believers again in Revelation 20:11-15, but we would not be dogmatic in this matter. One thing is sure, since He has clearly revealed it, the future reign with Him hinges upon the present willingness to suffer hardship for Him as a good soldier of Christ.

Heirs of God, and joint-heirs with Christ (8:17).

He gives here the prerogatives of the children.

• Heirs of God

• Joint-heirs with Christ

But there is a condition wrapped up with the second. The first is unconditional and true of all the children of God, but the second is plainly conditioned upon suffering with Christ. We might perhaps be a bit hesitant about this if this were the only passage to this effect, but there is also one in 2 Timothy 2:12, where we are told practically the same thing - "If we suffer, we shall also reign [as Kings] with him." It is an undeniable fact of every day life that many believers positively refuse to suffer with Christ. Perhaps they do not say this in word, but they show it in their walk all the more when they persistently cater to a popular Christianity and refuse to go outside the camp and bear His reproach. Now the strong particle of condition *eiper,* and the *ei* in 2 Timothy 2:12

clearly show that the popular Christians who want to be friendly with the carnal and worldly confessors and try to avoid all suffering with Christ, shall during His reign not reign as kings with Him. Christ emphatically warned His disciples that they would have tribulation in this world (John 16:33). Paul and Barnabas later warned about the same thing (Acts 14:22). These tribulations are our glory (Eph. 3:13; 2 Thess. 1:4-6) and a privilege, a gracious gift (Phil. 1:29). We may not be called to suffer for Christ, but we should be willing to suffer with Him, in mystical union with Him. These tribulations with Him are to be distinguished from the passing through the Great Tribulation, from which the members of His Body are exempt.

To be joint-heirs with Christ means we shall share all His power and dominion when He reigns as King of kings from pole to pole. This glorious prospect in itself ought to stimulate us to go joyfully with our precious Lord through every testing and trial, knowing that His grace upholds in every trial, and that the suffering is but for a moment, while the glories with Him last forever and ever. For other hints as to the relation of suffering and glory, see Mark 8:34; 10:38; John 12:24-26; Philippians 3:10.

The sufferings of this present time - the glory which shall be revealed in us (8:18).

The sufferings of this present time are manifold. There is mental, physical, spiritual, social, scholastic, and ecclesiastical suffering. Many a youth, as is evident from the many suicides among the young, has what the Germans call, *weltschmerz,* literally, world-smart. The chaos, confusion, and perils of our modern world are extremely hard upon young and sensitive nervous systems, and not so seldom they are crushed by it. Still, not one of these forms of woes is meant here by Paul. He is specifically thinking of the sufferings brought on by loyalty to Christ and His Word. Next to the deep valley of weeping we find the towering peak of the glory to be revealed to us and in us. This glory came at His first coming, but it will again come at His second appearing and will then be infinitely greater than in the fields near the city of David at His first coming. How easy it is to bear the sufferings of the present time when we look at the glories soon forthcoming from heaven. They are indeed a light affliction and cannot be compared but only contrasted to the eternal weight of glory.

For I reckon that the sufferings of this present time are not worthy to be compared with the glory (8:18).

After God's wonderful reckoning in chapters 4 and 5 comes man's reckoning in 6:11 and 8:18. Paul has carefully weighed the suffering and the glory, and now he counts up the two sides, stating his conclusion as to the loss and the profit. The phrase "present time" is literally the now nick of time. In 2 Corinthians 4:17 he also describes the present suffering as very brief; 1 Peter 1:6 does the same. Paul just showed that heirship goes with sonship, but here by implication shows that before the heritage of glory dawns there are sufferings for the sons. God has one Son without sin, but He has no son without suffering. He made His only Son perfect through suffering, and God plans also to make His little sons perfect through suffering. When we take the various lists of Paul's sufferings and add them all up, we get a sum-total of suffering as perhaps no mortal man before or after him has undergone. Viewed as merely from the hands of men, he suffered far more than even Christ. Only our Lord suffered incomparably more from God

as Judge, who forsook Him Who was made sin for us. Whereas God turned His face from Christ and poured His wrath upon Him, He smiled all the time upon Paul in his sufferings. When we realize the greatest human sufferer wrote these words, then this enhances the value of this unique comparison. The sufferings are not worthy to be compared to the glory about to be unveiled unto us.

The "glory" is *doxa* and is found 168 times in the New Testament, 76 by Paul. Moses longed to see it and said, "Show me thy glory" (Ex. 33:18). This glory is above the heavens (Ps. 8:1). Christ is the Lord of glory (1 Cor. 2:8). With Christ's ascension the glory departed from Israel for this age (I Sam. 4:21).The sinner comes short of this glory (Rom.3:23).He gives us grace and glory (Ps. 84:11).Israel changed their glory into shame (Hos. 4:7). There is a glory celestial and a glory terrestrial, and the latter belongs to Israel (1 Cor. 15:40; Rom. 9:4), The earth some day will be filled with glory (Num. 14:21; Ps. 72:19; Isa. 6:3). Christ will then be on earth the King of glory, and the terrestrial glory will dwell in Israel's land (Ps. 85:9), and the talk of the world will be the glory of His Kingdom (Ps. 145:11). Christ in us is now our hope of glory (Col. 1:27). We shall appear with Him in glory (3:4) and then the celestial glory shall dwell in the church forever (Eph. 3:21).

For the earnest expectation of the creation waiteth for the revealing of the sons of God (8:19-22).

"Earnest expectation" is literally a yearning with head and neck stretched out in eager anticipation. With "creation" he means the whole creation on earth apart from man. Unconsciously it is looking for the future revealing of the sons. Creation was subjected to vanity, not of its own will, but by the will of another.

Who is he that subjected creation to vanity? Three answers are given; Satan, man, and God. The last is the best when we realize God's decree on creation in Genesis 3:17-19. The word "vanity," *mataioteti*, occurs only here, Ephesians 4:17, and 2 Peter 2:18. It expresses utter futility and abortiveness, something which does not reach its proper goal. Creation never attains its proper end until the liberty of the glory dawns for the sons at the appearing of Christ. As the first Adam dragged creation with him under the curse and vanity, so the last Adam shall uplift it into the realms of the terrestrial glory. He shall fully mend what man has marred. Sinful man and the slimy trail of the old serpent have marred the whole beautiful creation; but the wicked shall be slain, the serpent bound in the pit, while the Spirit shall be poured out upon all flesh. Note, God does not improve the flesh, but He will cover it up with the fullness of the Spirit. There will come a restitution of all things, but not of all beings. We enjoy now the liberty of grace, then we shall enjoy the liberty of the glory of God.

He describes further the creatures as groaning together with one another and in travail-throes, as Way has it. It was so in Paul's day and it is so still in our day. In fact, creation now groans louder than ever before; but it is a happy thought that it lasts only until Christ comes and reveals the glory in us and on all creation. Paul gives here four culminating, climactic focus-points of final redemption:

- Our glory (verse 18).
- The unveiling of the sons of God (verse 19),

• The liberty of the glory (verse 21).

• Our future adoption, or the resurrection (verse 23).

We can add two from Ephesians 1:14 and 4:30. In dark days like ours, we can be filled with the sky-blue optimism when we look at these glories to come.

The whole creation groaneth - but we ourselves also groan (8:22, 23).

All the facts of nature and all the findings of science verify this statement. Scientists have more than once remarked that life must have been poisoned at the very fountain or that at least some great calamity must have struck the whole brute creation. However, God's children also groan. This is not the groaning or murmuring of dissatisfaction, which we find so much among the laboring classes of today. It is the groaning of the results of sin in the body on the one hand and of the longing for the future redemption or resurrection of the body in the future on the other. It is the longing of the patient in the lonely dark night for the nurse and help in the morning. It is the longing groan of the prisoner for the glad day of his liberation. It is the longing of the storm-tossed sailor for the desired haven and the meeting of his dear ones at home sweet home. It is the longing of the desert traveler in a dry-parched land for the refreshing oasis with its wells and palms. It is the longing of the weary soldier for the final victory when he can return to his fatherland and freedom, kith and kin, hearth and home. Paul is clearly thinking of life's manifold troubles in contrast to the glorious and cloudless resurrection day and the final conformity to Christ at His reappearing.

Which have the firstfruits of the Spirit (8:23a).

The word "firstfruits" appears eight times in the New Testament, thrice in Romans 8:23; 11:16; and 16:5. We have the firstfruits of the Spirit, i.e., the Spirit Himself is here compared to the handful of ears, which was offered to God, and which guaranteed that soon the harvest would be coming in. The indwelling Spirit is proof that full salvation will soon burst upon the believers. In the second passage Israel's fathers, the patriarchs, are compared to the first sheaf, typifying the full salvation of all Israel. The third passage applies this Hebrew figure to the first convert in Achaia as a harbinger of a full harvest of souls. In 1 Corinthians 15:20, Christ and the many saints that rose with Him are the typical sheaf emblematizing the harvest to come. In verse 23 the same idea prevails. In 16:15 it is used again of a first convert in Achaia, whereas in James 1:18 the Jewish believers in the Messiah Jesus are said to be the firstfruits of God's creatures. These Jewish believers foreshadow the harvest of Israel's future territorial and spiritual restoration. These should evidently be identified with the firstfruits mentioned in Revelation 14:4. This rich historical figure is applied:

• To the Spirit indwelling the believers.

• To the patriarchs.

• To the first converts twice.

• To Christ twice.

• Twice to the first Hebrew saints.

The first sheaf was part of the harvest, and so the Spirit is part of our great salvation. The first sheaf was a herald of the full yield of the field, and the indwelling Spirit adumbrates and prophesies the many glories to come. When the firstfruit sheaf was offered to God, the harvest was fast ripening and sure to follow.

Thus the blessed Spirit assures to us the glorious fact that full salvation can never escape us. Viewed in this light, the *aparche,* firstfruit sheaf, is a Pauline figure of great beauty and force. Meanwhile God has not purposed that this present pledge of future glory should remove our groanings.

Even we ourselves groan (8:23b).

In the deep valley between the two mountain-peaks of no condemnation and no separation we have three kinds of groaning:

• Of the whole creation.

• Of the believers.

• Of the Holy Spirit in the hearts of the believers.

Here we have the second kind of groans. That believers should groan is all the more remarkable, since they have the firstfruits of the Spirit, which is a Paulinism for saying that the indwelling Spirit is the firstfruit. The word is singular, *aparche,* and found eight times in the New Testament.

The patriarchs as firstfruits are holy (11:16). The first convert was the firstfruits of Achaia (16:5). Christ is the firstfruits of them that slept (1 Cor. 15:20). The firstfruits of Achaia (1 Cor. 16:15). Christ the firstfruits (1 Cor. 15:23).

Believing Jews are a kind of firstfruit of His creation (Jas. 1:18). The 144,000 are the firstfruits unto God (Rev. 14:3,4). Hence the word is used in five different senses:

• Of Christ.

• The Spirit indwelling.

• The patriarchs.

• The first converts.

• The believing Jews of the Apostolic time.

The underlying thought in each case, however, is a pledge and prophecy of a rich harvest. The Spirit is not only our anointing, our seal, our guest, our earnest, but also our firstfruit of the abundant and glorious harvest to come. Yet with this blessed assurance and the personal indwelling of the good Spirit, the believers groan.

What sort of groaning is this? There is a groaning of dissatisfaction, of pain, of grief, loss, and sorrow, but this is not meant here. Here is meant the groaning of longing as a patient in the night for the blessed light, as of a prisoner for his liberty, as of a slave for his emancipation, as of a mariner for the desired haven, as of a watchman for the morning. In 2 Corinthians 5 Paul has reference to the same groaning. It is the groaning of intense hope and sure expectation of what has been promised. God promised the glory to us but misery in many forms is often our present portion. When he adopts our humbled bodies from the grave all this will end.

Of all writers, secular or sacred, Paul alone gives us the correct view of nature. He does not exult in the song of the birds and the fragrance of the flowers, but he sees five things dead wrong with nature:

• He sees it subject to vanity, futility or as Way rendered it in his inimitable manner, "All created things have had to submit to a seeming purposeless existence," precisely what scientists find apart from the Book and redemption.

• Paul sees the whole realm of nature in bondage, or slavery. Nature is not free, but unconsciously longs for the freedom of the children of God. The apostle finds nature's trouble at the very dawn of history. Not nature's Creator but nature's federal head, Adam, has drawn creation with him in bondage.

• Nature is now in the bondage of corruption. Every carcass you see on the highway speaks of the bondage of corruption. This is not the purpose of the Creator, but the result of sin, and not the sin of nature but of nature's head, who dragged everything with him in the vortex of corruption, death and decay.

• Paul hears not the glorying but the groaning of creation. He hears the threefold groaning of creation, of the believers, and of the Spirit. The groaning and the moaning of creation bespeaks great suffering.

• Paul sees the whole creation travailing in birth pangs. When there are such throes, something is to be born, and thus it is here. The present travail assures us that soon the happy birth of a new world will be a glorious reality. The most marvelous quintuplets will be born: a new Israel; a new Palestine; a new creation; new nations that are saved; even a new universe with new heavens and a new earth.

Our apostle has here then a backward look to Adam, a present look of pity at nature's sad plight, and a future look of hope at nature's redemption. And it is not a calamity-howling old preacher, but the foremost atomic scientists who warned in 1945 when the atom bombs dropped on Nagasaki and Hiroshima, that the world's time was eight minutes before midnight. When Russia exploded the atom they moved the clock to five minutes to twelve, and in 1951, when the trouble started in Korea, they moved it to three minutes before midnight.

The redemption of our body (8:23c).

"The *apolutrosis* of our body." This rich word occurs only ten times in the New Testament, twice in our letter (3:24; 8:23). *Lutron* was a price paid for a slave. *Apolutrosis* is the price paid so that it can nevermore be followed by slavery of sin or Satan. We were kidnapped and held in abject slavery to sin and the devil. The price of Christ's blood was not paid to the devil, as many church fathers thought, but to God as Judge. This word occurs ten times in the following passages:

• Your redemption draweth nigh (Luke 21:28).

• The redemption that is in Christ Jesus (Rom. 3:24).

• The redemption of our body (8:23).

• Christ our wisdom, righteousness, sanctification, redemption (1 Cor. 1:30).

• In whom we have redemption (Eph. 1:7).

• Until the redemption of the purchased possession (1:14).

• Sealed unto the day of redemption (4:30).

• In whom we have redemption (Col. 1:14).

• For the redemption of the transgressions (Heb. 9:15).

• Tortured, not accepting deliverance (11:35).

• Four times we read that it is in Christ. For Israel it is the future deliverance of the whole nation (Luke 21:28).

There is a special day of redemption (Eph. 4:30) when that which has been purchased with His blood will be fully redeemed. Then the earth, and our bodies, which lie in the earth, will be fully redeemed in the resurrection and public presentation. We can say then that though the *apolutrosis* is a present possession in Christ, through His death on the cross (Rom. 3:24; Eph. 1:7; Col. 1:14; Heb. 9:15), yet it also has a future aspect with a reference to Israel, the earth, and our bodies. Some think here of the mystical Body of Christ, and this thought is true and beautiful in itself, but the apostle evidently has reference to our humbled bodies of clay. He is thinking of the bodily resurrection.

For we are saved by hope - but hope that is seen is not hope (8:24).

This does not mean hope saves us, for Christ saves us. We are, he means to say, finally saved as to our body and from all the results of sin in the secret hope of His reappearing from heaven. The latter clause means to say that hope is not centered upon the present visible things of earth, but upon the future and as yet invisible things of heaven. Though hope is not an instrument of our past and present salvation, it is instrumental in reference to our future and final salvation. The word hope stands here, as so often with Paul, for the thing hoped for, as in Acts 23:6; 26:6, 7; Galatians 5:5; Ephesians 1:18; 2:12; 4:4; Colossians 1:5, 23; 1 Timothy 1: l; and Titus 2:13. The assurance of the coming of our Lord brings a wondrous spiritual joy to the believing, hoping soul. Hope is simply faith directed to the coming of Christ with great certainty and joy. Faith works by love and hope. It lights up our pathway and shines like a beacon to show us the traps of the way. It keeps us when we would stumble.

Rejoicing in hope of the glory which we with Him shall share,

When we're dwelling forever in the home He's gone to prepare,

Where nothing defiling shall enter, but all that is pure shall come,

Where love, joy, and beauty awaits us in that celestial home;

Our thoughts are too feeble to grasp it, our words are too poor

To express all the rapture and bliss, but we know they are sure,

We shall reign as His co-heirs forever, beholding forever His face;

He will show forever His kindness, His wonders of glory and grace.

Hence, though darkness around us befalling, and heavy our trials each day;

What matters our suffering and sorrows? the morrow will bring to us light;

The night may be dark, but the night is far spent, and the day is at hand,

With our glorious Captain on celestial strands we shall safely land.

For we are saved by hope (8:24, 25).

Hope is an almost exclusively Pauline concept. We never find the word *elpis*, hope, in the four Gospels. James and Jude never use it, John just once in 1 John 3:3, Peter has it once in Acts 2:26 and three times in his first letter (1:3, 21; 3:15). Seven times it is used in Paul's speeches in Acts. In Romans he uses it twelve times (4:18; 5:2, 4,5; 8:20,24,25;12:12;15:4, 13). It further occurs in 1 Corinthians 9:10; 13:13; 2 Corinthians 1:7; 3:12;10:15; Galatians 5:5; Ephesians 1:18; 2:12; 4:4; Philippians 1:20; Colossians 1:5,23,27; 1 Thessalonians 1:3; 2:19; 4:13; 5:8; 2 Thessalonians 2:16; 1 Timothy 1:1; Titus 1:2; 2:13; 3:7; Hebrews 3:6; 6:11,18; 7:19. Hebrews included, Paul uses it forty-nine times, and all the others together only five times.

The root of *elpis* is the same as the word *pistereo*, faith. Hope then is essentially faith in reference to the future, and except when used in a psychological sense, it generally has reference to the things connected with the appearance of our Savior. Hope is faith in full assurance, full joy, and full longing for the promised glories. Hope does not focus on things seen but on things not yet seen but believed. In the trio of graces faith looks back to Calvary, love looks up to Christ, hope looks forward to His appearing and the concomitant things. In the phrase, "we are saved in hope," the look is not backward, beneathward, inward, but forward and upward.

The "saved" must be taken here contextually as including the *apolutrosis* of our body (verse 23). In that sense are we saved in hope. Hope dwells subjectively in our soul, objectively on God's Word and God's Son. Our hope is not a vague and vain wish that can be bitterly disappointed. It is a hope "that maketh not ashamed," since it rests upon the unshakable foundation of His infallible Word. This hope leads to a patient waiting, and a passionate working to please Him. This blessed hope is the greatest incentive for Christian service.

For what a man seeth, what doth he yet hope for? --- but if we hope for that we see not, then do we with patience wait for it (8:25).

Patience always suggests the present existence of adverse circumstances. Patience is essentially the same word as passion, suffering. It is to have its perfect work in us, and strange there is hardly a Christian virtue that is more neglected than this one. We can find the loveliest Christian characters who have many shining Christian virtues but are still entirely devoid of patience. Our Lord alone was perfect in this patience, too. He bore with all the needling provocations of His disciples. The most patient father or mother was never as tender and longsuffering as Christ was to His erring disciples. He did not break the bruised reed or quench the smoking flax. As a father pitieth his children, so He pitied His weak and wayward followers, and as one whom his mother comforted, so He comforted His own circle.

On the very dark night of His betrayal and arrest they grieved Him by an altercation as to whom should be the greatest. Three of His intimates could not even watch one hour with Him in the garden. Three times during His awful struggle he came to them for sympathy, but each time He found them asleep. He did not upbraid them but

condoningly apologized, "The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak." Remember His patience with Peter. More like the Master we should ever be, and it ought to be easy for us in these dark days to wait with patience for the great and manifold glories that are waiting us at His appearing. We should gird anew our lives and go forth to meet our Friend and the sweet Lover of our souls.

We know not what we should pray for as we ought - but the spirit makes intercession for us (8:26).

The "we" includes all Christians, hence there is not one believer that prays perfectly and exactly to the point; not even the best prayer warriors and wrestlers with God. But what we do not know, the Spirit praying in us does know how to do, for He prays after the will of God. Saints have generally three intercessors that pray for them:

• The Son in heaven.

• The Spirit in them.

• Their dear ones around them.

When the Spirit enters into the wheels of our prayer life, then the prayers contact God and things do happen. Then the prayers are not refinedly selfish, but in sweet harmony with God's will.

Likewise the Spirit helpeth our infirmities (8:26, 27).

Five blessed things are here said of the Holy Spirit to show that his compassion "matches our yearning."

• He helps our infirmities. The word is far stronger than merely help. The verb *sunantilambanomai is* found only here and in Luke 10:4Q, where Martha says to Christ, "bid her that she help me." Martha meant, of course, that Mary should rise and get next to her to work, and this is expressed in the *sun,* with. The Spirit helps in the sense of cooperating with us. Another thought lies in the *anti.* An enemy is presupposed, and the Spirit helps us against the deadly foe of our souls. The verb *lambano is* to take, receive, take hold. The Spirit takes hold of us in our weaknesses, not our sins.

• He pleads for us. The verb *tunchano* means obtain, get, and also fall out, happen. This verb is here strengthened with the two prefixes *huper,* over, above and *en,* in. It is used here alone. The idea of this difficult and compound verb is that the Spirit comes over and in us to take our part.

• The Spirit groans with and in us in heartfelt sympathy and with groans that cannot be uttered. The adjective *laletos is* also found only here. The noun means dumb. This shows that even spiritual prayers do not grow eloquent and mellifluous, for they issue in unutterable groanings. Satanic tongue speaking is the absolute antithesis to this prayer-life of the Spirit.

• God the heart-searcher alone knows the mind of the Spirit, just as the Spirit alone knows the deep things of God. The idea is that if humans do not understand the unutterable groanings, God knows the mind of the Spirit.

• The Spirit prays according to God, literally, and the thought is that he prays fully in harmony with God's will. Of true repentance the same expression is used in 2

Corinthians 7:9. We often mean well but pray against God's will; the Spirit never does. He knows it is God's will that we should be holy (1 Thess. 4:7: Eph. 1:4, 5). We can make it a safe rule that if we pray in the Spirit, we pray after God's will. But one thing is impossible, we cannot pray in the Spirit and walk in the flesh.

We do not know - we know (8:26b - 28).

We have here a double confession, a confession of ignorance and a confession of knowledge. We do not know how to pray as we ought. Paul means to say that in our prayer life we do not know exactly what is good for us and what is the sweet will of God for us. Hence we should say with our Lord, "Not my will but Thine be done!" In contrast to our imperfect knowledge stands the praying of the Holy Spirit, who ever prays according to the perfect will of God. He searches all things, even the deep things of God. He fully knows God's plan and will concerning us, and this makes it so imperative that we pray in the Spirit. But we cannot walk in the flesh and pray in the Spirit. A confession of knowledge and full assurance follows the confession of ignorance. Both confessions are equally humble and true. It is a most blessed knowledge to know that the universe turns around for our good.

And we know that all things work together for good (8:28).

This is one of the most favorite texts of the saints in our day, but perhaps better believed than understood. It is not a matter of vision, feeling, experience, intelligence, but of faith, and of knowledge based thereon. Nevertheless saints know a few things. John is especially a master in knowledge:

• We know Christ no more after the flesh (2 Cor. 5:16).

• We know it is the last time (1 John 2:18).

• We know we shall be like Him (1 John 3:2).

• We know whosoever is born of God does not practice sin (1 John 3:9). We know we have passed from death unto life (1 John 3:14).

• We know we are of God and the whole world lieth in the wicked one (1 John 5:19).

"All things" excludes nothing. The expression occurs twenty-two times in the Bible. Further on in verse 32 he says God freely gives us all things with Christ (Rom. 8:32). This comprehensiveness is truly amazing.

The verb *sunergi* points to a harmonious working together of all things. Only the Creator who made all things and the God of providence who supports all things could set things to work in such a way. It may be all clash, crash, and smash in this evil world, as in our day, but God runs the machinery of the universe. He overturns, overturns, overturns `till He comes whose right it is to reign. Nations talk of collaboration, yet they never fully trust one another, but God uses the hardest trials and troubles to work for His own.

The beneficence of this universal cooperation is expressed in the word "good," *agathon.* Note well, all things do not work for our sweetness, for our ease, our riches, our name, fame, power, wisdom, but for our good. That good may be hard for the flesh, tough on the purse, crushing for our spirit, destructive of our health, but it is for our

spiritual and enduring good. If it brings us to our knees, if it makes us more contrite, more humble, more meek, more dependent, more prayerful, more a pilgrim longing for heaven and home, that is the good. The limitation of this working of all things lies in its design. It is only for those who love God, and who have been called according to His purpose; not for the ungodly.

For whom he did foreknow, he did predestinate (8:29,30).

This chain of expressions needs careful attention. It is a chain from heaven to earth and from earth to heaven, and it has six links with the conformation to the Son as the seventh special link in the middle. Many make a mistake by commencing this chain with foreknowledge. In fact, all Arminians do, and reason with Miller in his outline on Romans thus:

> Foreknowledge precedes predetermination; it knows beforehand what man's free agency will do. Predestination is founded upon foreknowledge as to the proper subjects.

This is wrong since man thus determines God and His plans. This puts man's will above God's will, and puts man's agency and planning outside the purpose of God. It deifies man and humanizes God. We must not start this golden chain with a foreknowledge swayed by man, but with God.

• *Purpose* (literally prearrangement), foredisposing. His knowledge follows his prearranged plan, the act of his will.

• *Foreknowledge is* the second, not the first link. God's foreknowledge is not merely knowing beforehand, but decreed beforehand. In Romans 9:11 it is made clear that God's decree was not because of man's foreseen goodness or faith.

• *Predestinate,* prehorizoned, blueprinted, predetermined.

• *Foreordained* to be molded in likeness to His Son. As the middle shaft of the golden candlestick pointed to Christ, and just like the sevenfold unity of Eph. 4:1-5 points to Him, so it is here also that the middle in the seven points to the Son and is somewhat different from the other six. The central place is always His. We have here not mere predestination to heaven, but to holiness, to Christ. Predestination is not a cold doctrine, but is Christocentric; it glows with Him. He is in the center and He must have the honor and authority of the firstborn.

• *Called is* the fifth link. He calls the dead sinner to life.

• *Justified.* Justification is not from eternity for it follows the call. The call was irresistible. The called accept the call.

• *Glorified.* This includes sanctification and the final glory. He views it as past, because God's plan cannot fail. It's a fact with God.

We are dealing here with wonderful divine facts. Through the influence of the modernistic philosophy of relativism many in our day do not even realize the value of facts which can never be reasoned or sneered away. Facts are divine deeds of the past, present, and future. Many, just like the tots, take fancies and fairy tales for facts. Wild tribes take medicine men with their mumbo jumbo for facts. In the second world war

many were fed and fattened on fancies, fictions, and folk-lore instead of facts. Here are a few of the calamitous fancies:

• All nations were peace-loving except one - a fancy and a falsehood contrary to fact.

• Communism was a real friend of the West--contrary to fact.

• Stalin was a good old Joe, who said, God bless you, when we gave him eleven billion and enthroned him - contrary to fact.

• Russian entry in the war against Japan was necessary - a falsehood.

Not only does man often take fogs, fancies, fictions, and folklore above facts, but even positive falsehoods. But God gives us here facts, divine realities. Oh that we may not prefer the fancies and falsehoods of this world above these divine facts! In truth and salvation there are always five f's that must be taken in their right order:

• The fact of Christ dying and rising for us (verse 32).

• The fact of faith; "By grace are ye saved through faith" (Eph. 2:8.9).

• The fruit of salvation; "Herein is my Father glorified that ye bear much fruit."

• The feeling of salvation; "Now the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace in believing."

• The future of salvation. "That in the ages to come He might show the exceeding riches of His grace" (Eph. 2:7). Feeling should never be put upon the foreground, for it logically and psychologically comes only in the fourth place.

What shall we then say to these things? (8:31-33).

The final shout of victory at the end of this chapter stands in striking contrast to the threefold groans. Paul was a poet as well as a prophet by the grace of God. After he has given us the seven links of the chain stretching from heaven to earth and from earth to heaven, showing that salvation proceeds from God's sovereign will, plan, and work, and that predestination does not only deal with nations and privileges, but positively with individual salvation, he now tosses forth seven questions, each of which is a bold declaration in itself:

• What shall we say then to these things (v. 31)? What is our reaction?

• If God be for us, who can be against us (v. 31)?

• How shall he not with him also freely give us all things (v. 32)?

• Who shall lay anything to the charge of God's elect (v. 33)?

• Who is he that condemneth (v. 34)?

• Who shall separate us from the love of Christ (v. 35)?

• Shall tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or peril, or sword (v.35)?

Whenever there is a heptad, a seven, there is always one that is outstanding from the rest, just as with the sevenfold surrounding of Jericho and with the seven-armed candlestick. It is a law of Scripture numerology that this predominant seventh points

typically to Christ in some way or other. So it is here, the seventh question holds seven questions. It is equal to the seven times around Jericho on the seventh day. The steps of Solomon's throne were six, but he sat on the seventh! Six and one! His paean of victory is at the same time a bold challenge to all the powers of hell to successfully fight those whom God has justified. It now stands this way with the justified:

• God has spoken, and what can we now say against it?

• God is for them, hence no power can be successfully against them.

• God gave His Son for us, how shall He withhold any good thing from us?

• The legal charge was settled in justification, who now can impugn rightly the justified?

• God justified, who now can do the opposite, and condemn?

• God put us in Christ, who shall now separate us from Him?

• Is there any power on earth or hell who can down us? The love of God was just as real to Joseph in the dungeon as on the throne, just as real to Daniel in the lion's den as in his palace, just as real to the three youths in the fiery oven as in the halls of the wise.

He spared not His own Son - but delivered Him up for us all (8:32).

If He had spared His own Son, it would have meant our eternal woe, but glory to the Father, He did not spare the Son of His love who played in His bosom, and in Whom He had all His delight. He delivered Him up to this rebellious world. He delivered Him up to Israel that had persecuted and stoned many great prophets. He delivered Him up to the cruel Roman state that had drenched the nations in blood. He delivered him up to a Judas and a Pilate. He delivered Him up to the shameful and ignominious death of the cross. He delivered Him up to all the billows of wrath, so that He cried, "My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?" He delivered Him up to *sheol,* though His soul was not left in *sheol.* He delivered Him up into the prison of death and the grave on account of our sins, but praise God, He raised Him on account of our justification through His blood.

God justifies - Who is he that condemns? (8:33, 34).

This contrast, interestingly, shows that not pardon but justification is the opposite of condemnation. The latter is giving the guilty person his due penalty, whereas justification is the placing him in the relation of innocence though he is guilty, and this can only be done because Christ bore his punishment.

It is Christ that died - yea rather that is risen (8:34).

Paul never went back to the virgin birth, except once in passing, but he always harped back to the Cross and the resurrection. Not His birth but His death with the resurrection was the line of cleavage between the old regime of the Law and the new regime of grace, except that in pursuance to the prayer of Christ on the cross an extension of thirty-three years was given to Israel in the Acts period. He has stated that God is for us, and he proceeds to prove this also with seven glorious facts:

• He spared not his own Son (v. 32).

• He freely gives us all things (v. 32).

• He justifies us (v. 33).

• Christ died for us (v. 34).

• Christ rose for us (v. 34).

• Christ intercedes for us (v. 34).

• The love of God is for us in Christ, where we are, and hence nothing can separate us from the love of God (v. 39).

-The death of Christ on the cross fully and finally met all the claims of a holy and just God and all our needs as guilty sinners.

-The resurrection of Christ proves the satisfaction to God's justice and our justification, since He arose on account of our justification as an accomplished fact. Pragmatically His resurrection means that we worship not a dead god as the nations do, but a living Lord who can hear our cry in the night, sympathize with our sorrows, help us in all our troubles. If He had not risen we would still be in our sins (1 Cor. 15:14-17).

-He is even at the right hand of God the highest place of honor, privilege, majesty, and might. He is far above all principality and power, and in Him we are set there as far as our standing is concerned.

-He also makes intercession for us. We pray to live, He lives to pray; He always prays and He is always heard. Those who deny His heavenly priesthood for the members of the Body ought to be consistent and deny also His death, resurrection, and session at God's right hand for us.

More than conquerors (8:35-39).

With our apostle the pendulum always swung between sighs and shouts. He is the prayer and praise leader of the Body of Christ. The Lord's work in the past, present, and future has been rightly called the fulcrum for the lever of our prayer and praise. He sets the tune for the chorus of the church, and when many saints cannot jubilate with him then it is because of inattention to his church doctrines. Alas, so many skim the surface of his words as a bird skims the surface of the sea. So many saints are sunk down under the cares of this life, because they believe not (8:28). Many lack peace, because they do not accept his teaching as to the only ground of peace. Many lack joy, because they miss his ground of joy, the mystical union, the being in Christ. Many wrestle with the old man, because they do not reckon with him that he is dead indeed. Many strive for sanctification as a second work of grace, because they do not accept his teaching as given in chapter 6. Many live in fear and dread, because they do not grasp what he so clearly teaches, that the sin question is settled. Many grope in darkness, because they neglect the light he has revealed from heaven. Many do not walk in love, because they fail to grasp what he teaches, that the love of God has been poured out into our hearts by the Spirit and that we meet the love of God, which is in Christ Jesus. The love of God is there and we are there. The quotation from Psalm 44:22 has been the theme of many a martyr's song. We are more than conquerors, and this means far more than to have a decisive victory and smash the foe. It means:

- To suffer no loss.
- To enjoy all the spoils.
- To glorify the great Captain.
- To receive a glorious reward of grace and celestial decorations.

CHAPTER 9

IS GOD UNRIGHTEOUS?

Nothing shall be able to separate us from the love of God - I have great heaviness and continual sorrow in my heart (8:29; 9:2)

What paradox this triumph, greatest gain

From greatest loss, the Son of God to die

Despised, upon a felon's tree; His cry,

By God unheard, and unrelieved His pain,

As if some vile imposter, far from sane.

Though God, He bore the hate and scorn of time;

In His humiliation, more sublime

Was He, than in Creator's role.

What gain For lost mankind flows from Golgotha's tree!

The Sinless One, He took our guilt and sin,

Endured God's wrath, from wrath to set us free;

Bore Eden's curse, its promise now to win.

So great a need-so great a sacrifice!

The death of God's own Son, the fearful price.

After our Lord made such a self-sacrifice, we can depend on it that He will never be separated from His own, He will never let them slip into perdition, and He will never allow us to be severed from the love of God which centers in Him. God sent Him to the cross, shed His love into our hearts through the Spirit, and He accepted us in the Beloved. The Father's love rests in Him and in all His members. No wonder Paul is on shouting ground with such a great and unbreakable salvation.

Nevertheless, Paul suddenly speaks of a constant heartache. The connection between the paean of victory and the pang in his heart must be thought of in this wise. Men might object and say to him: "Your song of no separation sounds hollow and rings not true in regard to Israel, God's covenant people who are daily separating from God's love." It is a similar objection that causes man to plunge into theodicy in regard to Israel's sin, guilt, and salvation.

In Christ Jesus our Lord - I could wish that myself were accursed from Christ *(8:39; 9:3).*

This paradox is far too high to scale and too deep to fathom by our puny mind, for Paul knew himself to be in Christ forever, but he could wish he were accursed from Christ forever, if by virtue of that fact Israel might as a nation be saved. We find

something similar in Moses who was willing to be blotted out of the book of life (Ex. 32:32), if Israel thereby might be saved. These men were both faith-pictures of Him who in reality was made a curse for Israel.

I have great heaviness and continual sorrow in my heart (9:1, 2).

After the elevated mountain top we again descend into a valley. It is a valley of tears, great sorrow, and constant heartache. The great chorister stands here before us a heartbroken man. Expositors have always wondered what the connection, if any, might be between the preceding and this. There is a connection, and a most intimate one at that. When Paul sang so lustily, there was one who could not, and would not, sing with him-Israel. Yet, Israel's God of old inhabited the praises of Israel (Ps. 22:3). The people of praise, the people of the Psalms, the people who had a God that gives Psalms in the night could not and would not sing with Paul upon the high peaks of praise. He now turns aside from his song and victory to explain why Israel cannot and will not sing with him the wonders of grace and glory. He gives a five-fold assurance of his truthfullness in dealing with the problem of Israel, so that no one should ever accuse him of anti-semitism, though many modern Jews do so nevertheless.

• "I say the truth." He always does, but here such an assurance is needed in view of the bitter enmity of the Jews against Paul.

• "I say the truth in Christ." Israel should know that in all the five trials head before Annas, Caiphas, Pilate, Herod, and the second time before Pilate, no one could find anything against Him.

• "I lie not." Even his Jewish fellow-believers suspected him, and hence these reiterated affirmations of his veracity.

• "My conscience." Three times in Romans he refers to conscience. The heathen had a conscience (2:15); Christians should be conscientious in regard to the state (13:5), and he is conscientious in regard to his poor people Israel.

• "My conscience bearing me witness in the Holy Ghost." He is in Christ and also in the Spirit. He in this word gives the highest degree of the assurance of truthfullness in the inner parts.

For I could wish that myself were accursed from Christ for my brethren (9:3).

The word *anathema is* used seven times.

- The Jews anathemized themselves with an anathema, we read literally in Acts 23:14.
- No one can call Jesus accursed (1 Cor. 12:3).
- He who loves not Christ is anathema (1 Cor. 16:22).
- He that preaches another gospel, let him be accursed (Gal. 1:8).
- This solemn threat is repeated in the next verse (9).

This list shows that we may not weaken Paul's statement to anything less than the curse of being lost forever. Many try in vain to limit it to a ban or banishment from Israel or the church but it is an eternal banishment from Christ which is meant. We will not

trouble the reader with the various renderings and interpretations given. We have in Paul not merely a fervid patriotism and love for his kinsmen, nor a passion and compassion for souls, but a unique Christ-like character fully in line with the mediator of the Old Testament and of the New.

Moses desired in Exodus 32:32 practically the same thing, and what that great leader could not do, Paul could not do, and did not need to do. Paul does not throw himself away in humility, he rather shows here, if anywhere, his great worth and the consciousness of it, since he measures himself with a whole nation. If by virtue of his becoming voluntarily an anathema for his people that the nation would be saved, then he was ready to give himself, otherwise not. Thank God, another greater than Moses and Paul combined has voluntarily been made a curse for Israel. He was made sin and a curse and hence forsaken by God, but as God he emerged from under the curse. Note well that Paul speaks here of Israel as his kinsmen, after the flesh.

God's righteousness - their own righteousness (9:3).

The Jews were ignorant of God's righteousness. This is an amazing statement when we realize that even the Old Testament was full of the righteousness of God, and two thousand years of Law experience could have convinced them of the fact the Law could not give righteousness. Nevertheless, they were ignorant of the merited righteousness of God by the Lord Jesus, who by the way of the Cross is our righteousness. From an ethical point of view there are two kinds of ignorance: an ignorance as of a dear child about many things because of lack of intelligence and training. Adults can also be ignorant of every science and yet daily bask themselves in the sunlight of God's smile. Their ignorance is fully justifiable and excusable. There is, on the other hand, a culpable ignorance, when we have had full opportunity to know divine truth and we do not know it, and as a result run actively counter to God's Word and will; such was the ignorance of Israel in regard to Christ and His merited righteousness.

We have three infallible witnesses - Christ, Peter and Paul - who solemnly declare the Jews ignorantly crucified the Lord of glory, but that this was a culpable, blameworthy ignorance. They could and should have known. Not knowing Christ was really the promised Messiah, they did not know His meritorious work on Calvary and the righteousness of God there established, and so they earnestly sought their own righteousness.

The two kinds of righteousness are set in direct contrast. They are mutually exclusive. Both cannot dwell in the same heart at the same time. Dressed in the mantle of God's righteousness, we cast aside our own righteousness as filthy rags; but Israel made a wedding robe of it (Matt. 22:11-13). The heathen are unacquainted with the righteousness of God, the Jews were acquainted with it but ignorant of it through their unbelief, pride, and self-righteousness, and hence their guilt is infinitely greater than that of the heathen. After nearly two millenniums the Jews still go about to establishing their own righteousness.

Christ the end of the law (9:4).

The Cross is the establishment of God's righteousness. The Jews did not recognize this divine establishment. It would in fact have been self-condemnatory. The

fundamental reason for not acknowledging God's establishment is that they have their own establishment or at least seek to establish their own self-righteousness. Christ is said to be the *telos* of the Law. We get our teleology, the science of design, from this word. It means termination, but also aim. The expositors are not in agreement. It is best to combine the two as the German commentator Tholuck has done, for both thoughts lie imbedded in the one little word. The question can only be which thought predominates, and it seems to us the primary thought is end, termination. The Law-economy ran out, ran dead into Grand Terminal Station-Christ. But of course, when once the end of the trip is reached, the purpose of the trip is also attained. Though in different ways, the Law and the prophets both pointed to Christ. The Grand Terminal, Christ, runs at once into the Cross, and this runs for every believer into the righteousness of God. Blinded by unbelief, prejudice, and pride Israel did not see this and ever so many do not see this today. This little verse plays havoc with the nationalistic Hebrew Christians who think they should keep the Law. A man who smugly remains in his train after the Grand Terminal Station has been reached is so foolish at such an attempt to keep the Law.

Here is one problem, however. Christ is the end of the Law for every Hebrew believer. What about the unbelievers? Is not the silent implication that for such there is still the Law to keep, and also the curse to reap for non-observance? The Gentiles never received the Law, and they are not held responsible for the observance of the Mosaic Law; but will the Jewish unbelievers not be consumed by the fiery curse of the Law? It is hard to get away from this conclusion.

Dispensationally this may well be called the greatest verse of the Bible. It states the seven great prerogatives of Paul's kinsmen after the flesh of whom he says they *are* Israelites and not, *were* Israelites. The ancient theocratic name has never been transferred to any but Paul's kinsmen. The name "Israel" is used twelve times in Matthew, also twelve times by Luke, and by Mark and John together six times; Acts has it sixteen times; Romans twelve times; all the other books together twelve times. The very numbers show the nation of Israel is meant in each case. In not one single reference is this name transferred to the church which is His Body collectively or to the members individually. The national privileges of Israel are given as follows:

• They have an nontransferable name; Paul's kinsmen are still "Israelites."

• *Adoption.* This is not the same adoption as that of 8:15, nor that of 8:23, and neither that of Gal. 4:5 and Eph. 1:5. It is the national adoption of Israel as the firstborn son of the nations.

• *Glory.* Not the celestial but the terrestrial glory of the *shekinah* is meant.

• *Covenants.* These also belong not to the Body, but to Paul's kinsmen after the flesh. What a confusion would have been avoided if this truth had always been believed.

• *Law-giving.* The word *nomothesia is* formed the same way as *huiothesia.* This word cuts off all legalism and all sabbatarianism by the roots. The Law belonged to just one nation-Paul's kinsmen after the flesh.

• *Service (latreia) is* the ordered worship of God. Israel alone had this in the tabernacle and temple.

• *Promises.* Israel was the only nation that had the promise of a Deliverer and deliverance, of the Spirit and the Kingdom, and this is what Paul refers to.

• *Fathers.* Israel had fathers and founders of the nation, whom they could revere as the ancient worthies, whereas our fathers walked in bear hides and clubbed one another to death while the women did the work. This seventh prerogative is outstanding and points to Christ who came from the fathers of this highly privileged nation.

Christ who is over all, God blessed forever (9:5).

Christ is of Israel but Israel is not of Christ. This does not detract from the glory of God's anointed Son. It has been vehemently denied that Christ is here called God, but great critics like Clericus, Wetstein, DeWette, Muntinghe, Ruckert, Doedes, Sanday, Grey, Veldhuizen, and a host of others have admitted this doxology refers not to the Father but to Christ. The R.V. seems to be uncertain; at least it has put three different translations in the margin. The punctuation of the A.V. is the best. It would have no special significance in the context to give here a doxology on the Father, but this praise on Christ gives point to the passage.

In contrast to the nation that rejected Him as God, Paul calls Him God, *eulogetos,* forever, or literally into the ages, which here stands for eternity. Where Israel speaks evil of Him Paul speaks well of Him, which is the literal meaning of the Greek word blessed. He uses this word twice in Romans; the first time it refers to the Son as the Creator (1:25) and here as the Messiah, Who is God blessed forever.

The Deity of Christ is the crucial point for both Israel and the nations. Either will admit now that Jesus was a great man and a wonderful teacher, but that He really is God blessed forever is believed by neither, though the Bible clearly ascribes to Him divine names, attributes, works, and honors. It is exactly this point which He shall demonstrate in the august day of His coming. After He has brought down all militarism and war we hear Him say in Psalm 46:10, "Be still, and know that I am God." He evidently will say this to Israel and the nations. The universe with genuflections shall confess that He is Lord to the praise of God the Father. Satan loves to cover up or betray His Godhead Judas-like, with many kisses for Him as man. The schools of Knoch and of Russell have in our day fallen for this chicanery of Satan. True believers say with Thomas to the risen Lord; "My Lord and my God!"

Not as though the word of God hath taken none effect (9:6).

If Israel denies Christ's Deity, that does not take away His blessedness, and so if Israel rejects the Word about the Messiah that does not prove the Word of God is ineffectual. A celebrated and truly talented preacher spoke by radio on the superscription of the cross, "this is Jesus, the King of the Jews," in which he said that since the King of Israel hung there as a crucified criminal, all the future of Israel was taken away in one stroke. The Jews had the most roseate expectations of a glorious King and kingdom, but the Jewish unbelief upset everything, and the unuttered conclusion was that the promises had failed and were now transferred to the church. It is this infidel view that Paul contradicts. Man's unfaithfullness cannot change God's faithfullness. This is an axiom of truth even a child can grasp, but it seems to be hidden from the wise and prudent. This preacher was a born logician, and yet he uttered the

most illogical and inconsistent thing, which if true would upset the Word of God and the whole scheme of salvation from start to finish.

Not all the natural descendants from Israel are true Israelites. Throughout Israel's sacred history there was always only a remnant in the nation who truly took God at His Word (2 Kings 19:10, 18; Isa. 65:13-16; John 10:4; Gal. 3:7, 9, 29; 6:16; Rom. 2:29). So there was only a numerically small remnant in Paul's day, and so it is exactly today in Israel and in Christendom. Many Jews who bore the beautiful name of Israel, meaning wrestlers with and conquerors of God, were unworthy of this beautiful name and had actually turned out to be fighters against God. This made no difference, however, in regard to the Word of God. The Word of God cannot be broken, praise His name forever. Heaven and earth shall pass away, but not God's Words.

The seed of Abraham - but in Isaac shall thy seed be called (9:7).

Prophetically it was said that Abraham was to have a threefold seed:

• As the dust of the earth, or better, land of Canaan.

• As the sand on the seashore.

• As the stars of heaven.

The first points to Israel, the second to the Mohammedan world as offspring from Abraham and Hagar, and the third to all that believe (Gal. 3:7), and all that are of Christ are Abraham's seed (v. 29). The particular seed of Abraham is Christ (v. 16). He is the seed. The seed did not come through Ishmael but through Isaac. On the surface there does not seem to be much difference between Ishmael and Isaac. They were both sons of Abraham. Sarah, in nobility of character, was not superior to Hagar. What then is the great difference that God should point to Isaac so emphatically?

In order to fully appreciate this we are to remember that in Isaac a threefold divine miracle was wrapped up; the parents were both too old for child bearing and on top of this Sarah was barren. Hence God in causing Isaac to be born of this couple revealed Himself as the God who quickens the dead. It was prophetic of the fact God would keep Israel through a chain of miracles during the long ages of its history and that He would finally restore Israel by another series of wonders. Hence there is a series of wonders at the commencement, the continuation, and the culmination of Israel's marvelous history. Israel is a nation of wonders and cannot be understood by the common laws of history.

"Isaac" means laughter, and not a laughter of derision but of joy, prophetically indicating the joy of our Lord and of His people through the Savior and His great salvation. At His right hand there are pleasures forever more.

The main idea of these verses is that God elects. All Israel is not really wrestling with God and conquering God. All the seed of Abraham are not all children of God. The son of Hagar and the sons of Keturah were also the seed of Abraham, but the line of promise ran through Isaac. The children of the promise alone are counted for the seed. He gives here several names to his people:

• *Israel.* We have shown this ancient theocratic name is never transferred from Israel, and that holds true in this case. The name could be replaced by Jews if taken

literally as Israel, and then it would mean, they are not all praisers of Jehovah that are of the Jews; the name means, praise Jehovah.

• *The seed of Abraham.* God said he would make Israel's name great, and this has literally come true, for his name is great among 300,000,000 Mohammedans and of course also among Jews and Christians. The Jews have sprung from him and all believers are his spiritual seed.

• *Thy seed.* God did not acknowledge all of Abraham's seed but He did acknowledge as His seed what He Himself had caused to spring forth from a threefold miracle: a too old father; a too old mother; a barren mother.

• *The children of the flesh* are the unbelieving Jews and Arabs.

• *The children of God* are those who follow in the footsteps of faithful Abraham.

• *The children of the promise* consist of the Jews whose faith is in God.

In verses 9 and 10 he refers to the Old Testament history of Sarah and Rebecca, where we find illustrated the truth that the natural went before the spiritual. Where there is no earthly birth there can be no birth from above. But it all clearly illustrates the truth of God's elect remnant all through its checkered history.

The children of the flesh are not the children of God - but the children of the promise are counted for the seed (9:8).

The previous note has hinted at this. The Savior used a word freighted with meaning when He said, "the flesh profits nothing." The whole barren Mohammedan world is there to substantiate this word; and the energy of the flesh can cause great conflagrations, but it is always unholy fire and not the sacred fire of the Lord. Note, He does not say the children of the promise are the seed, but that they are "counted" for the seed. It was God's omnipotent and sovereign count that made them so. Over against the unholy fire of the flesh God revealed Himself as the God of all grace. It was grace that brought forth the Savior (Tit. 2:11-14).

Not of works - but of Him that calls (9:11).

Paul has in Romans and Galatians well-nigh a perpetual contrast between human works, carnal energies of man, and the marvelous grace of God. The call is here not the external call by means of the word of preaching (by Barth called the Word of God) but the inner, efficacious and creative call of God. God called Abraham, Sarah, and Isaac into life. How marvelous is this creative call of our God. It happened before Jacob saw the light in this world and while he was still resting under the heart of his mother. It was an elective call, for Esau was rejected though he too rested under the same heart. Reprobation was here as well as election. It was an antithetic call. Indeed the antithesis between the two seeds promised by Eden were here present.

It was an unmerited call for no good or evil had been committed, hence it was predictive of the fact that man is called and saved by grace and grace alone. It was a call of God's original purpose to save man by the woman's seed which includes that man was not to save himself.

As we are taught in 1 Corinthians 1:26-31, God called here the worst, not because Jacob was less noble of character as many think, but because Jacob was the younger and as such did not possess the right of primogeniture. The illustration of Isaac is an advance over that of Jacob, seeing God rejected one twin and called the other in love. Hence this elective call was absolutely independent of parentage.

The elder shall serve the younger (9:12).

God's absolute sovereign election is here illustrated by the example of Jacob and Esau. God's election is not influenced by man, because God's word came to Rebecca when her twins were not yet born. There was a threefold miracle here, too, as with Sarah, because:

• God knew she bore twins under her heart.

• God knew they would both be boys, which is something all medical science is unable to predict with certainty.

• God knew and predisposed the elder would serve the younger.

But note well, the unborn twins could not influence God's purpose. It was not of works, but all according to God's purpose, call, and Word. This word has always been an offence to man and to Arminianism in particular, and curious and many have been the ways to reason this away. Two interpretations especially are very general.

• It is claimed we have here not a personal election, but only an election of nations, Jacob standing for the Jewish nation and Esau for the Edomite nations and all wicked nations. But the language clearly points to individuals and not to nations. Yet, if for the sake of argument we would take this of nations, this would not solve the difficulty but only aggravate it.

• Others make God's choice here to privilege only. Although it must be admitted verse 12 certainly points to privilege, this interpretation will not stand the test of Esau, Pharaoh, and the potter's vessel to dishonor.

Whether we like or not, Paul goes back to the absolute sovereignty of God in this matter of Israel's unbelief and rejection. It is not for us to try to penetrate with our finite minds God's will and ways, but it is our solemn duty to take God at His Word, and that clearly tells us here that man's will is not the decisive factor in salvation, but rather God's sovereign will.

Jacob have I loved - but Esau have I hated (9:13).

Much has been written on this twofold declaration of God and curious are the attempts throughout history to get rid of this sharp antithesis. Many have softened the word hate into a lesser love, but then God should have said He loved both. Others have applied it only nationally to Edom and Israel, though this in reality would broaden and sharpen the absolute antithesis and would not alter the facts in the least, since a nation is composed of the aggregate of its individual members. Then, if applied nationally, Jacob and Esau would not be excluded but included in this divine love and hate. It is as clear as a sunbeam that the context here refers not to nations but to persons, and we may freely say there is no turning or twisting, no exegesis or sophistry of any sort whatsoever that can succeed in eliminating from this text the absolute sovereignty of

God in the personal election and reprobation of man. Both rest exclusively in His own good pleasure, by which is meant that both His love for the elect and His hate for the reprobate rest exclusively in Himself and in His own good pleasure. The Arminian election of works is also eliminated by the roots, for God elected and reprobated before they had done any good or evil.

Is there unrighteousness with God? (9:14-16).

With a reference to the love for Jacob and the hate for Esau, this question is put forth, and Paul throws this suggestion aside with nothing less than holy horror, while he further reduces everything to the four times repeated I will of God. The underlying reason here is this: God is good, hence His will is good, and therefore His will in regard to election and rejection is good. This was not anew doctrine of Paul, for they could read it even in Moses. After the fourfold I will, man's will is ruled out most emphatically, and also his running, which stands for activity and zeal. To say God foresaw the good character of Jacob and on that ground elected him is utterly absurd, and yet this is exactly the Arminian stand. Human merits do not in any shape or manner enter into God's free choice.

The reason of election is clearly not in man but in God, "that the purpose of God according to election might stand." It will stand no matter how men hate it. It stands in spite of Israel's widespread unbelief. God chose Jacob for no good in him and rejected Esau for no bad in him. When man is willing and running this indicates the possession of grace, but not the originating cause of election; the fruit but not the root of election. The apostle has now clearly shown man's willing and working have absolutely nothing to do with election, and that God's sovereign will lies at the bottom of it. If man thinks this is unrighteousness with God, then the burden of proof rests on him to show that God's will is wrong and that a being with a wrong will is a wrong being and that such a wrong being cannot be God. However, God is always the Judge and will never be a defendant. Paul insists God's will is supreme, unaccountable, holy, just, and good. The just God cannot possibly be unjust.

Not of him that wills or of him that runs - but of God who shows mercy (9:16).

The quotation is from Exodus 33:19, showing we have here the rule of faith of the whole Scripture. Contextually, it referred first of all to those who died and were spared in Israel after the base idolatry at the foot of Sinai with the golden calf, but Paul makes this here of universal application. Not man's will decides, nor his energy, expressed by running, but God's mercy. The rock bottom fact is that all the time man does absolutely nothing to his own salvation, but that beginning, middle, and end are all of God and of God alone, and that means all glory should be given to God for our salvation. God is not ever planning to share His honor with man. It is for the same reason that all through the course of Israel's history He hated idolatry with a perfect hatred. Idolatry ever attempted to share the honor due to God with idols. Election upon the basis of man's good works and faith deifies man and detracts from God's glory. And salvation by works is fundamentally idolatry, detracting from the glory of God of Whom, through Whom, and to Whom are all things.

Therefore hath he mercy on whom he will have mercy - and whom he will he hardeneth (9:17-18).

In Exodus it is said ten times that Pharaoh hardened himself, and that God hardened him especially after he first hardened himself. This gives a wonderful story from the point of man's sin, guilt, and responsibility. Paul does not ever allude to this fact, for his objective in giving this example is to show God's free and holy purpose. He has introduced Esau as the first example of God's sovereign rejection, and now he gives Pharaoh as the second example for the same purpose.

• God's purpose lay at the bottom of this whole tragic story, though Egypt's king was fully responsible and freely hardened himself against God. However, at the very call of Moses God said twice He would harden Pharaoh. God's purpose and act stood clearly upon the foreground.

• "I raised thee up" as the result and outworking of the secret divine purpose, which Pharaoh did not know.

• "That I might show my power in thee." God wanted to show His power in the ten plagues and in the destruction of Pharaoh and his hosts. His glory is promoted in the powerful overthrow of His and His people's foes as much as in the salvation of a sinner.

• "That my name might be declared throughout all the earth." My power and my name! God has said several times He had this end in view with Pharaoh. He put the three youths in the hot furnace and Daniel in the lion's den for the same purpose, and in each case He showed His wrath to His foes; His power, His name, His wrath.

Note how we read four times the singular "whom" in verses 15 and 18, supporting clearly the view that God's choice is not of nations or churches, but of individuals. If one thing is needed in our decadent times, it is a clear grasp of the sovereign will of our God. Man must be dethroned, God enthroned.

He has mercy on whom He will have mercy - whom he will he hardens (9:18).

The whole doctrine of hardening has been definitely limited to Israel under Law and not to the Gentile believers under the present regime of grace.

Why does He yet find fault? - Nay but, O man who art thou that repliest against God? (9:19, 20).

Man has not even the right to reason against God. He may not even apply his human wisdom and logic to God. The question of the objector is, "Why does God find fault with man, if He hardens whom He wills?" God's answer throws the sinner into the dust before Him, and He points man to the Potter and the clay, as He had done in Jeremiah 18:1-10, but what is there used of Israel is here applied to individuals. In pointing to the Potter God spoke a volume of truth in regard to His sovereignty. We have here:

• The power of the Potter and the powerlessness of the lump of clay.

• The right of the Potter and the rightlessness of the mud. • The authority of the Potter and absence of authority on the part of the clay.

• The sovereignty of the Potter and the helplessness of the clay.

• The marked difference between the vessels of honor and the vessels unto dishonor.

We should notice the lump of clay is in every case the same. The difference which comes from it is all of God. There is absolutely nothing in the clay that could induce the Potter to make entirely different vessels. The Potter has the indisputable right to make opposite vessels. We have no right to say with the infralapsarians that the clay represents fallen humanity, for there was clay before man fell as we see in Adam's creation. The whole supposition regarding the clay is that even if it has no power, might, or right in regard to the Potter, it is at least potentially appropriate material for making vessels of honor as well as of dishonor.

O man who art thou? (9:19-21).

The logical dilemma of man's reasoning is here abruptly stated. This objection goes much farther than the one in verse 14. Here God is accused of inconsistency if He finds fault with the man who sins. If it is His will and purpose that man sin, who then can ever resist His will? It is a remarkable fact that Paul neither in 3:5-8 nor here even attempts to give a logical explanation to the objectors. Philosophers and theologians after him have never found any rational solution to his problem, so we may freely affirm this perplexing problem is insoluble. So far from giving a satisfactory solution, Paul abruptly turns on the objector and reminds him sharply he is only man, that God is God, and that the creature has no right to reply against God or criticize his Maker.

After Esau and Pharaoh he uses the third example to show God's sovereignty when he represents man in his metaphor as a lump of clay, which is exactly what man originally was. He is just as helpless, rightless, lifeless, and dependent as a lump of clay. Paul has in this connection no desire to expatiate on man's responsibility, a word, by the way, not found in the Bible, while the thing itself is not so pronounced in the Word as in popular theology.

The writer uses here two words for will. In verse 18 the verb *thelo is* used twice, and in verse 19 the word *boulema.* From a careful comparison of these two words we must conclude the former will can be and often is withstood, but the latter denotes His irrevocable, unchangeable will, the will of His purpose which is ever realized without fail. That Christ was crucified was God's unchangeable will (Acts 2:23). God works everything after the counsel of His will (Eph. 1:11). The former word denotes the irresistible will of God, the latter the will which is often withstood.

Has not the potter power over the clay - to make one vessel unto honor? - And another unto dishonor? (9:21).

The underlying picture is of earthen pots in the eastern tents and homes. The vessel unto honor denotes a beautiful receptacle, while the vessel unto dishonor denotes a pot used for more menial tasks. He speaks also of vessels of wrath and vessels of mercy. In consistency with Paul's reasoning this can be nothing else than the elect and the reprobate, the woman's seed and the serpent's seed. Strenuously, the apostle contends for God's absolute right and sovereignty to such an extent that man has not even the right to open his mouth against His Maker.

Vessels of wrath - Vessels of mercy (9:22,23).

The expression "vessels of wrath" does not merely mean these reprobates are the object of God's wrath as we see in John 3:36. The wrath of God is upon them, and

through unbelief the wrath of God remains upon them. This pregnant phrase undoubtedly means they have been appointed by God's holy wrath unto eternal wrath. The entire context indubitably shuts us up to this view. They are vessels fitted, i.e., instituted, constituted, appointed, equipped, made ready for destruction. Things here, as in the other vessels, do not depend on man's will or work, but entirely upon God's sovereign work. What is true of the vessels of mercy is equally true of the vessels of wrath. Man's will is excluded and it is all of God. The phrase "children of wrath" does not merely mean they are under wrath and on the way to wrath but that they have been brought forth in wrath as of a mother wrath.

Fitted to destruction - afore prepared unto glory (9:22, 23).

It would be unwarranted sophistry if we would stress the latter to give God the glory, and not equally the former.

God willing to show his wrath (9:22-24).

This is a continuation of the answer to the second objection which was an attempt to disavow all responsibility for sin and to cast the blame upon God. It is sheer presumption for the lump of clay to speak against the divine Potter. The sovereignty of the Creator postulates that no creature of the clay can successfully challenge and dispute His right to determine and accomplish all His good pleasure with man. God has a right to sit as critic over man, but man has no right to sit as critic over God. He goes here again back to God's will. If God is willing to show His wrath, show it publicly as a warning example for others, and also His power, who can deny Him this prerogative? Twice it has been asserted that in the case of Pharaoh God wished to show His power, and that He wished to show His name, and once that He wished to show His wrath the same as He shows His grace and mercy in the saints. The vessels of wrath and the vessels of mercy stand opposed, but both are rooted in one holy will. The vessels of mercy are identical with the vessels unto honor. Both were predestined with equal sovereignty. Both were formed, fitted, perfected, by the great Potter. Their various uses are by Him predetermined. It is said God endures, forbears, tolerates the vessels of wrath with much longsuffering.

God was always reluctant to punish (Genesis 11:5; 15:16; 18:21-32; 19:21; Exodus 32; 34:6, 7; 2 Chronicles 36:15; Jonah 4:2, 11). After much longsuffering, the thunderbolts of judgment finally crack down upon the guilty. The "fitted to destruction" is an exact parallel to the afore "prepared unto glory." It is inconsistency, if not impudence and presumption on man's part to accept the one and not the other. We tremble here before His will and Word.

In verse 24 he explains who the vessels of honor and glory are. They are the called both from among Jew and Gentile.

The author now refers to the story of Hosea and his unhappy family. There were three children in the family and they all had typical names:

• *Jezreel* meant God would soon sow Israel in all the earth for their sins.

• *Lo-ruhamah* was a daughter, and her name also betokened calamity for the sinful nation. Her name meant: No mercy!

• The third baby was a boy and his name was *Lo-ammi,* meaning not-my-people.

The three names together prophesied that Israel would be scattered, without mercy, and not regarded as God's people. Yet in the very place where God said, Lo-ammi, you are not my people, there it could be said unto them, You are sons of the living God. When Paul quotes freely this word of Hosea, he does not mean to say the terminal fulfillment of this word has come, but only the germinal realization for the Jews who believe in Palestine, the very same place where the judgment had been spoken. That the final realization of Hosea's prophecy has not come appears from the following:

• Judah and Israel are not yet gathered together to appoint themselves one head (Hos. 1:11).

• The valley of Achor has not yet become a door of hope (2:15).

• Israel has never called the Lord *Ishi,* i.e., my husband.

• The covenant of Hosea 2:18 has not been made (2:18).

• War has not been destroyed from the earth (2:18).

• The great fruitfullness of the earth has not yet come (2:20-22).

• Nationally Israel has not obtained mercy (2:23).

This quotation of Hosea has to illustrate how God for a time rejects the nation and selects only a few. The believing Israelites even then had obtained mercy, but the rest were hardened. He further illustrates the fact that while Israel is in unbelief he calls the Gentiles. While Israel nationally is a vessel unto dishonor, the believing Gentiles are vessels unto honor. Only the Jewish believers must have been able to grasp this from Hosea.

A remnant shall be saved (9:27-29).

Further proof is derived from Israel that God would reprobate the nation and elect only a remnant of the people as His own. The first quotation is from Isaiah 10:22, 23. The Assyrian king would come and destroy Israel, yet God would preserve Himself a remnant, which was partly fulfilled after the Babylonian captivity under Zerubbabel and all through history. The second quotation is from Isaiah 1:9 where the word "seed" is a prophetic Hebraism, meaning something for a fresh planting. The general stock of plants had become as corrupt as Sodom and Gomorrha except for this elect seed from which was to spring anew stock. Verse 28 should be read as the R.V.; "For the Lord will execute his Word upon the earth, finishing it and cutting it short." The idea is that God will visit Israel and the world with terrible judgments.

The cutting is an allusion to the *shearith* or remnant, which literally means a portion cut off by judgment. The cutting it short means that when the Lord begins to judge He will work very swiftly.

The idea of the remnant is one of the leading ideas of Isaiah's prophecy. It includes the ideas of guilt, wrath, judgment, election, faith, grace, mercy, and divine purpose, according to which He gives His promises not to an entirely different people, or group, or even churches, but to the believing remnant of Israel. It is this latter idea of divine sovereignty that Paul emphasizes in the face of his unbelieving kinsmen and carping

critics. He shows herewith at the same time that he does not come with some new-fangled ideas of his own, but with the continuous teaching of the prophets of the Old Testament Scriptures. He is in succession with Isaiah, Hosea, and all the prophets.

What shall we say then? (9:30-33).

Paul means "say" in regard to these Old Testament passages which all Jews respected. He answers his own question with a twofold answer in which he shows that these prophesies are realized before their eyes in the general unbelief of Israel and the faith of the Gentiles. The Gentiles, who never pursued righteousness, overtake the very righteousness of God by faith, whereas Israel who always fervently sought it by means of the Law, did not get it, because they sought it by the law of works, and not by faith. The Jews were running hotly after righteousness, but God said it is not of him that runneth or willeth but entirely of God's mercy, and in His mercy lie has made the way of salvation not a way of good deeds but of one good deed done once for all. The watchword is not do but done. It is not feeble man's doing, but His finished work on Calvary. It is now not trying but trusting in Christ's finished work.

Paul has now given eleven quotations from six books, perhaps seven. He has laid the Old Testament under tribute to show God's sovereignty. From Genesis he showed the story of Jacob and Esau as a vessel to honor and the other to dishonor. From Exodus he used the story of Moses as a vessel to honor and Pharaoh as a vessel of wrath. From Jeremiah 18:1-10 he showed the sovereignty of the divine Potter over the lump of clay, Who can make, knead, form, and fashion the clay after His will. From Hosea he has illustrated the rejection of the nation and the acceptance of those who were Lo-ammi or not God's people. From Isaiah he has illustrated the doctrine of the remnant and its rich teaching. In the last two verses he makes an appeal to the mysterious stumblingstone as found in Psalm 118 and Isaiah 8 and 28. Israel's misery is due to just one thing. They stumbled over God's precious stone as a stone of stumbling, and once more does he emphasize God's sovereignty in the rejection of Israel, when he says, "Behold I lay a stumblingstone." God laid this rock of offence squarely in Israel's path.

CHAPTER 10

ISRAEL OUT OF FAVOR

Paul reiterates his great love for Israel and his yearning for their salvation. The word *eudokia,* desire, is elsewhere only used of God. He has God's attitude toward Israel. It means good pleasure (Matt. 11:26; Luke 2:14; Eph. 1:5, 9; Phil. 1:15; 2:13; 2 Thess. 1:11). Though Israel as a nation hardened itself, Paul earnestly implored God for them, proof by the way that we can freely pray for those who hate the crucified One as a rock of offence. The desire was in his heart, the prayer expressed.

From the following chapter we know Paul knew God's program about Israel's future salvation. In his supplication he must have then been thinking in individual and national terms of the present and future salvation. When he says, "I bear them witness" he means to say he grants, admits, concedes they have a zeal toward God. They are very religious, in other words. If religion saved them, they surely would go to heaven. They had a zeal without knowledge. In our day there are ever so many who have a knowledge without zeal, and that is also bad. The Jews were in earnest and sincere, but they were sincerely wrong. They thought their way was a path of life, but it was the way of death, and could anything be more tragic?

Paul does not mean to say the Jews have no religious knowledge. They have the *gnosis,* but not the *epignosis,* the thorough knowledge of divine truth. This is also true of many in our day. They know much about God and Jesus, and they know many facts of sacred history. Early Christian training has done its work; but they have not the deep knowledge about the work of Christ. They still have a do religion, and a hope-so religion, but not a clear grasp of the wonderful grace of God in Christ. *Gnosis* puffs up, *epignosis* builds up.

Moses describeth the righteousness of the law (10:5)

We have here a contrast between Law and grace. It is the antithesis between Moses and Christ, between the man who does and the man who believes, between the righteousness which is of the Law and the righteousness which is of faith. We must grasp well the statement "The man which doeth those things shall live by them," by which he means:

• A Jewish man, for Moses wrote to Jews only.

• The man who does all the things of the Law.

• The man shall then live long in Palestine and die as a saved Jew, because his doing was the outflow of his faith and obedience toward God.

To turn this into present legal Gentile salvation upon obedience is absurd. Paul personifies faith-righteousness and has it paraphrased in Deuteronomy 30:11-16, which is really a warning:

Do not the impossible, for what you by the law try to do, has in grace been done for you. In all your legal zeal, you need not climb into the sky to bring Messiah down, for He has in grace come down unto us. Neither do you need to descend into the abyss to bring Him up, for He has arisen from the dead.

"Abyss" is used only in Luke 8:31 of the swine and demons who went into it and here, where it is used of Christ's resurrection from it. The "pit" is used seven times in Revelation where it is in each case fitly rendered bottomless pit, (9: l, 2, 11; 11:7; 17:8; 20:1, 3). Plainly the lowest part of *sheol is* meant, where Christ has been, as appears from Psalm 116 quoted in Peter's Pentecostal sermon, "Thou wilt not leave my soul in *sheol."* Apart from all poetic figure we can say Paul means the Jews with all their religious, legalistic zeal did not need to bring the Savior down from heaven or up from *sheol,* for in wondrous grace God had brought the word of salvation, the word of faith, in the very mouth and heart of His servants, and it was all free and unconditional, to be had by simple faith.

Paul's allusions to Deuteronomy 30:6 have caused expositors much trouble. Various views have been set forth. Some today use it as an argument for their unscriptural thought that Romans is all Jewish and only Law, but with the same argument from quotations of the Old Testament we could prove Ephesians is all Jewish, since this Epistle has seven quotations from the Old Testament and also seven allusions. Many think we have here the mere contrast between Law and grace, but we have here more than this.

A contextual reading of this quotation will show that Moses in his last address speaks of Israel restored from their age-long exile.

• They received the blessing and the curse; they were driven among all nations (Deut.30:1).

• Their captivity is turned and the Messiah has returned to gather those whom He scattered (v. 3).

• He will do them good and multiply them above the fathers (v. 5).

• God will circumcise their heart, so that they love God with all their heart (v. 6).

Paul means to say Israel under the returned Messiah and with a circumcised heart will no longer go about to establish her own righteousness, but will get the righteousness of faith. The contrast here, therefore, is not merely of Moses and Paul, of Law and grace, of works and faith, but the contextual idea is clearly that Moses speaks not only of the righteousness of the Law for present sinful Israel, but also of the righteousness of faith for the future restored Israel. In that post-exilian day Israel will not need to bring Christ down from heaven, for He will have come down from heaven. They need not bring Him up from the abyss of *sheol,* for He will be in their midst as the risen Christ.

The righteousness which is of the law - the righteousness which is of faith speaketh (10:5, 6).

The former spoke in the past of a thing impossible for man to do, namely, keep the whole Law. The Law was weak through the flesh. It was a heavy yoke which neither the

fathers nor Peter and his contemporaries could bear. It was a shadow which glided past to make room for the Body. The righteousness of faith is speaking in the present and during the whole age of grace. It cries loud and clear not to go about like Israel to establish a righteousness. It loudly cries not to seek in the heights for a righteousness nor to descend in the deep abyss for it, since it was brought near and even in the heart and mouth of the preachers of grace.

Confess with thy mouth the Lord Jesus (10:9-11).

The word *homologeo* occurs twenty-three times in the New Testament. In Matthew 14:7 it is rendered promised; in Hebrews 13:15 it is translated giving thanks, while in Matthew 7:23, 1 Timothy 6:12, and Titus 1:16 it has been translated profess. It should have been consistently translated confess, and even that word does not do justice to the beautiful Greek term, which literally means to speak the same thing with someone else. The beautiful idea is that we should fully agree with God and then speak the same thing of His Son as He does. Profess, from *pro* + *fari*, to speak before or in favor of, is an entirely different word. The distinction between these two terms is beautifully drawn in 1 Timothy 6:12, 13, where Timothy's profession is heard by witnesses, while Christ, speaking as a witness, makes confession before Pilate. He agreed fully with the Father and spoke the same thing as the Father. We confess the truth by saying just what the truth says, while we profess it by practicing. Confession is with the mouth, with the lips, profession with the life (Matt. 7:23; Rom. 1:22; 2 Cor. 9:13; 6:21; Tit. 1:16; Heb. 3:1; 4:14; 10:23).

A false distinction is often made in this connection between belief in the heart and belief in the head, but this distinction was far from the holy writer. Would to God people would believe more with their head. In a scriptural sense the heart includes the head. Strictly speaking, it is here emphasized that we should confess Him with all our intellectual as well as our emotional life. The faith must be centered in the great miracle of the risen Christ, including as it does the Cross and the Deity of Christ. The distinction of verse 10 seems to be that faith as such gives a man justification or the first stage of salvation, and the working through of that faith issues in a confession with the mouth, and a living confession after a living faith brings full salvation in our personal life.

No difference between the Jew and the Greek (10:12,13).

The same word is here used as in 3:22. There it is used to signify all are sinners, here, as in other places, it stands for the Gentile nations. Up to Calvary there was a great difference which God placed between the two, a difference so great that the Jews could not eat or drink with the Gentiles, nor work or marry with them. Then at Calvary the veil was rent and officially, *de jure,* the wall of separation between the two was removed, though *de facto*, it stood all during the Acts period. Since Acts 28, when Israel was officially expelled and set aside, there is no difference in regard to God's grace. All alike may look to the crucified Christ and be saved. Christ went to the cross and arose that He might be Lord of all. Paul gives Him here not His name as minister of the circumcision, but the name of the risen Redeemer; Lord over all. He is Lord over Jew and Greek, Lord over all, even over the dead as well as the living (14:9). When Joseph was taken from the pit he became lord of all Egypt, and so the whole house of Israel and all the world must know the risen Savior is Lord over all and Lord indeed. So many

are satisfied with loving Jesus instead of obeying Him as Lord. The Lord over all is rich unto all. He was rich, became poor, and then at His ascension became rich again, richer than ever before, for now He is rich as God and man and that in one adorable personality.

He does not stint His riches, for He is rich unto all, i.e., to the Greek as well as to the Jews. The grain fell into the earth, and He was lifted up, and now He draws all men unto Him. How can He give His riches away, and to whom? To all those that call upon Him. The risen Lord has eyes to see, ears to hear, a heart to love, a mighty arm to help, but as a rule He manifests Its riches unto those who call upon Him in prayer. Joel and Paul speak of the remnant.

How then shall they call on him in whom they have not believed? (10:14-15)!

The main thought of these verses is that the Gentiles ought to be evangelized. In a beautiful string of a fivefold "how" he brings this out. Joel had of old said whoever would call upon the name of the Lord would be saved, but:

- How can they call without belief?
- How can they believe without hearing?
- How can they hear without a preacher?
- How can they preach except they be sent?
- How beautiful are the feet of the preacher of peace!

The last "how" is not a question but an exclamation found in Isaiah and Nahum. This beautiful chain teaches us how prayer is dependent upon faith, faith upon the hearing of the gospel, the hearing upon the preaching and preachers, and the preacher upon his divine mission, for he must be sent. All is linked to all in the spiritual realm as well as in the natural world. It is all dependent and interdependent, twined and intertwined, and all things consist, cohere in Him. Christ is the so-called law of coherence. The Gentiles can never call upon the Lord, unless they first be evangelized, and they can never be evangelized unless preachers go to them, and preachers can never go to them unless they have been sent by God and by the church (Acts 13:1-4).

God now calls His servants through His people and in no other way. The argument is surpassingly beautiful, and the omniscient God alone knows for how much mission work it has been responsible, especially in the last century. It clearly excludes all immediate regeneration apart from the Word. It also excludes all true seekers after God among the heathen. They cannot believe and pray unless they have first heard the gospel.

But they have not all obeyed the gospel (10:16-21).

After the exclamation, "how beautiful," this is a sad "but." There he dealt with the problem of getting preachers to make others pray to the Lord Jesus, here with the knottiest problem of all, the unbelief of men, especially of Israel, for this nation is not for one moment out of his thoughts. Israel's unbelief fills his noble heart with indescribable pathos. Hence this pathos, or anticlimax. The gospel must be obeyed with the obedience of faith, and here Israel broke down completely.

In verse 12 he draws the conclusion of the logical argument from verse 13 on. Since faith comes by hearing, it is of paramount interest the unsaved come under the hearing of the Word of God. We must not think, of course, that the hearing naturally, or mechanically, or even mysteriously develops into faith, but it pleases God to call the dead sinner effectively into life by the Spirit through the hearing of the Word, just as Lazarus came forth from the grave upon the call of our Lord. Lydia is another example. While Paul preached, she heard, and the Spirit opened her heart so that she attentively listened, and then and there she believed in Christ and was saved and showed at once her faith by her works. Did Israel not hear then? Paul answers with a quotation from Psalm 19:4. As the celestial bodies bring an effective message of God's grandeur in nature, so the Word had gone forth unto the ends of the inhabited and then known world, giving a message of God's grace and glory in Christ. Men might as well make an excuse of not having seen the sun, moon and stars as that they had not heard the gospel. Israel had heard and known the gospel message. They knew about the Lord, but they did not really know Him whom to know is life eternal (John 17:3).

He answers the question, did Israel not know? with three quotations. In Deuteronomy 32:21, God threatens Israel who provokes Him to jealousy that He will in turn provoke them to jealousy by calling the heathen. The second quotation is from Isaiah 65:1, 2 which is a sublime paradox. The third follows the above. Like the repeated phrase in Jeremiah of rising early, the stretching forth of His hands, is an anthropomorphic expression. Yet, it was literally true upon the cross.

I was found of them that sought me not - But to Israel He says, all day long I have stretched forth my hands (10:21).

A marvelous paradox! Of the heathen, according to Romans 3, there was not one that sought God, and yet in grace many found God in the face of Christ as their Lord and Redeemer, but God had sought Israel for two thousand years and this people rejected Him. They sought not God, but they sought to establish their own righteousness. Hence the heathen sought not God and in mercy found Him, while Israel in her self-righteous way sought God and found Him not. In longsuffering kindness He stretched forth His hands all day, or as Jeremiah said, from early rising till late at night. God did not have short work hours, but rather long days in His pleadings of love that would not let go. He finally stretched out His hands in a stark, literal way on the cross for Israel, but Israel has until this day not found Him.

CHAPTER 11

ISRAEL SET ASIDE

We now come to the grand chapter of Israel's restoration, by which we in reality mean a double restoration; spiritual and territorial. The apostle puts the question on the foreground, "Hath God cast away His people?" and He answers it with his usual and vehement, God forbid *(me genoito).* Horror fills his righteous soul at the very thought. How different this apostolic attitude is from our modern Christianity.

There are three different attitudes to Israel's restoration:

• Many bluntly deny any future restoration of Israel, claiming the church has inherited all the blessings of Israel, thereby necessitating the denial of Israel's restoration.

• There is a great number of Christians who doubtfully ask whether God has any future for Israel.

• There is a growing multitude, who with full assurance based upon the prophetic Scriptures, know there will be a glorious restoration of His ancient covenant people.

This restoration will not be brought about by the church in the church age. Jewish missions - and God bless them! - will not be able to accomplish this. As Isaiah said in the first chapter of his prophecy, "Zion shall be redeemed by judgment." Terrible judgments upon the nations will be needed for the final deliverance of Israel. Is it not a remarkable fact that even with the partial and merely national restoration of Israel in our day the Gentile nations are even now thrown in chaos, perplexity, and despair? What are these but harbingers of the great and terrible day of Jacob's final deliverance. Israel's full and final restoration has received a larger bulk of proof than any other truth of Scripture. It is just as sure as the crucifixion and the resurrection of Christ, and there is a far larger bulk and voluminous proof of Israel's restoration than even of these rock-bottom unalterable facts of Scripture. This ought to be a well-known fact by all believers, but because Israel's covenants and promises have been expropriated from Israel and appropriated by the church, it is well-nigh an unknown truth. Therefore we will give some attention to the rich volume of proof.

Moses must be here regarded as a star witness. Before Israel had ever made its first entrance into the land, God assured them He would waste their land and its cities and sanctuaries and scatter them among the heathen (Lev. 26:3133). No one in the course of history has ever dared to spiritualize these judgments. All admit they have become frightful realities. But in the same chapter God assures them Israel will some day confess their sins in deep contrition, and that God will not break His covenant with them, but will remember His covenants with the patriarchs and He will remember the land, clearly implying that all nations will call themselves blessed in Abraham and his God (Lev. 26:40-46). In Deuteronomy 28 God gives many predictions which have all been realized in the course of history. God's words have become undeniable facts. But now notice, God assures Israel when all these curses have been realized, and we quote:

> That then the Lord will turn thy captivity, and have compassion upon thee, and will return and gather thee from all the nations, whither the Lord hath scattered thee. If any of thine be driven out unto the outmost parts of heaven, from thence will the Lord gather thee, and from thence will he fetch thee. And the Lord thy God will bring thee into the land which thy fathers possessed, and thou shalt possess it, and he will do thee good, and multiply thee above thy fathers. And the Lord thy God will circumcise thine heart and the heart of thy seed, to love the Lord thy God with all thine heart with all thy soul that thou mayest live (Deut. 30:3-6).

If this is not national and spiritual restoration, what is it then? Let us now take David as a star witness of proof for Israel's restoration. The volume of proof is so bulky we select only the Messianic Psalm 69.

- Here the floods of divine wrath swirl over Him (v. 2).
- We find Him here hated without a cause (v. 4).
- He is an alien to His mother's children (v. 8) (see also John 7).
- The zeal of thine house hath eaten me up (9).
- Reproach has broken my heart (v. 20).
- There was none to take pity on Him or to comfort Him (v. 20).
- They gave him gall and vinegar to drink (v. 21).
- The table of His foes becomes to them a snare (v. 22).
- The habitation of Judas was to be desolate (v. 25).

After these nine facts were minutely fulfilled in His first coming and especially in His suffering, we find this Psalm suddenly ends with this triumphant note:

> Let the heaven and earth praise Him, the seas and everything that moveth therein. For God will save Zion, and will build the cities of Judah, that they may dwell there, and have it in possession. The seed also of His servants shall inherit it; and they that love His name shall dwell therein.

Why are all the universe, heaven, earth, and sea called to praise the once rejected Christ if not for the literal, national, and spiritual restoration of Israel? How could words ever be more plain. There is a celestial Zion, but there is no Zion that is the church, the Body of Christ.

Isaiah is our next star witness. The words of the Lord as used in the synagogue of Nazareth (Luke 4:18,19) are familiar to every reader of the Bible. He came for five classes:

- Poor
- Broken-hearted
- Bound
- Blind
- Bruised

It is not so well-known, however, that He stopped reading in the middle of a sentence. In Isaiah 61:2 we read in one breath of "the acceptable year of the Lord" and "the day of vengeance of our God." He took the former phrase and left out the latter, since in His first coming He did not come to take revenge but to save. He also omitted the comfort of verse 3. He will give to restored Israel beauty for the ashes of present Israel, the holy oil of joy for their present mourning, and the garment of praise for their present spirit of heaviness. All this is the spiritual rejuvenation of the ancient people, while verse 4 gives the territorial renewal. They shall build the old wastes; they shall raise up the former de solations, and they shall repair the waste cities, the desolations of many generations. To apply this to the church as some do runs into absurdity. Israel shall then be called *hephzi-bah,* i.e., My delight is in her, and the land will be called *beulah,* married.

Let Jeremiah be the next star witness!

> Behold, the days come, saith Jehovah, that I will raise unto David a righteous Branch, and a King shall reign and prosper, and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth. In his days shall Judah be saved and Israel shall dwell safely: and this is His name whereby He shall be called, The Lord our Righteousness (23:5,6).

Here is a just King who brings justice in all the earth. He is a Davidic King and therefore a Jew from Judah. He shall have days of prosperous reign, and in His days the northern and southern tribes will be saved and reunited. Restored Israel especially shall call that great and good King Jehovah *Zidkenu.* With the words of confession on their lips, they will acknowledge that He by the way of Calvary's cross justified them freely forever. This, too, shows a glorious restoration of Israel in the land.

In 31:8,9 the weeping prophet sees Israel come back from the north, Russia, where now even half of Israel may be found, and from the coasts of the earth, America, the man of God sees them come; the blind, the lame, the pregnant woman, the one in birth-pangs, a great company. He sees them come with penitent weeping, but Jehovah leads them as a shepherd does His flock. If this means the church, who then are the blind, the lame, the pregnant, etc? Of course historical Christendom has appropriated Israel's covenants, blessings and promises, and even its very position as the covenant people of God, and it is never an easy thing to give up the stolen prey. Traditionalism has unquestionably been the greatest power in Satan's hand to lead Christendom astray.

Ezekiel is our next witness! After speaking of Israel's sin and shame and judgments, God says in 36:24-28:

> For I will take you from among the heathen, and gather you out of all countries, and will bring you into your own land.

This is undeniably a territorial restoration! Now follows equally clear the spiritual renewal:

> Then will I sprinkle clean water upon you, and ye shall be clean: from all your filth and from all your idols will I cleanse you. A new heart also will I give you and a new Spirit will I put within you, and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh. And I will put my Spirit within you, and cause you to walk in my statutes, and ye shall keep my judgments and do them.

Here Israel gets the real cleansing and not the ritual; the real baptism of the Spirit. For the Body of Christ there is now only one baptism by which we are incorporated into Christ forever.

In the next chapter the prophet sees Israel's restoration take shape in two successive phases. First the dead bones rattle together into a human skeleton and this becomes a corpse. This phase of Israel's restoration is now going on before our eyes. Soon there will be two million Jews back in the holy land. Some nations have been emptied of the last Jew. Marvelous as it is, many Christians do not even believe God's work any more than His Word, a blindness as amazing as it is deplorable. In 37:11 God explains these dead bones by saying, "These bones are the whole house of Israel," forbidding all expositors to explain them of the church.

Has God castaway His people? –I am an Israelite (11:1).

If I would ask, "Has God cast away the people of Holland?" and I would answer it by saying, "No, for I am a Hollander," then we would have about the same reasoning and presentation of facts as Paul here presents; still it would be totally different. This appears to be the weakest argument of the Bible, when in very fact it is one of the strongest. In order to appreciate it and properly evaluate it, we must consider that Paul did not mean to merely say he was a Jew and that he as a saved individual Jew would prove the nation has not been rejected. He alone as a single person would merely prove that a Jew could be saved, but would prove nothing for the nation as a whole. Things will at once take on a different hue when we remember Paul was a type, or as he says, a prototype, a preadumbration or foreshadowing of the nation as a whole. He was the prefiguration in His conversion of the conversion of the whole Jewish nation in a day. Paul saw and heard the Lord and talked with Him, and so shall the nation see the Lord of glory and be born from above in a day. Paul here means to say that if the prototype was saved, then this sufficiently proves the real antitype in due time must also be saved. Viewed in this light, his argument is marvelous.

I am left alone - I have preserved to myself seven thousand men (11:3, 4).

Elijah's sad and plaintive cry represents man's overhasty, prejudicial conclusion sprung from pride and pique and pity of self. He did not even consider a noble young man like Obadiah. God puts His big I over against the big ego of Elijah. Against the prophet's "left," Jehovah places his "preserved." In opposition to the sad "alone," the Lord puts His "seven thousand men." Elijah's pathetic statement sounds a good deal like Jacob's, "All these things are against me." Man reasons upon the basis of his feelings, God states facts as they are. The emotions have films over the eyes. Tears and sorrow dim the vision of man, but God states the unalterable facts as they are. Facts versus feelings! God had seven thousand men and then an equal number of women and four times as many children, which proves the prophet was by no means a man of the people. God did not say these men were heroes. They belonged to the quiet in the land who had not testified against Baal. But then Elijah was no hero either, for he fled before a woman.

If by grace - then it is no more of works (11:6).

Paul says this first of all with an eye on the elect remnant of grace, the seven thousand men. These men had done nothing that God should preserve them. He preserved the nations for their sake, but that He did this was all of grace and of grace alone, and this grace excluded all works on their part. Works proceed from the energy of the flesh, grace springs from the heart of God. Works are human, grace is divine. Works are meritorious, grace is the result of Christ's merit of Calvary. We feel then that grace excludes man's works. Grace springs mediately from the finished work of the God-man, the man Christ Jesus. The Pauline antithesis between grace and works has all too soon been lost in the young church, and there are but precious few today who grasp this exclusive contrast in the economy of God's present dealings. Formerly He had the economy of Law, now the economy of grace which excludes works as the root, but not as the fruit of salvation.

If it be of works - then it is no more grace (11:6).

This is essentially the same antithesis as the preceding, only in the reverse. If man wants to work to earn His salvation then he cannot also have grace. Man's works radically exclude grace, just as the grace of God has positively no room for man's works of whatever character they may be. God has room for good works in His plan of salvation but as the fruit and not the root of salvation. When those who exalt the grace of God speak against works as God does in His Word, then many accuse them of antinomianism, even of licentiousness and libertinism, and of ruling out works in every sense. Hence it should be well understood that all works are rigidly and radically ruled out of the attainment of salvation, but not out of the evidence and manifestation of salvation. There could be none in the former, since the work was finished on Calvary and since man cannot enrich God, but there could not be but good works of gratitude after that great salvation has been graciously bestowed upon the sinner. After Christ gave Himself upon the cross for us it is most reasonable that we give ourselves in gratitude of heart to Him.

Israel has not obtained what she seeks - but the election has obtained it (11:7).

Israel has been seeking for two thousand, yes, now even nearly four thousand years, and has not found what it seeks; a righteousness of the Law. Israel still looks at the Law as the *sumum bonum,* the highest good. But even Israel would admit no doubt that the Lawgiver Himself is greater than His Law, and the very Lawgiver has in Christ come down to Israel, but because He had no beauty, Israel did not desire or recognize Him as their great Lawgiver. They chose a cutthroat above their mighty Giver of the Law on Horeb.

Did God's plan thereby fall into the water? Not at all, for it was not God's hidden plan and purpose to work at His first coming through the nation as a whole. It was His secret plan of election to give salvation full and free to the elect remnant, and they did not attain to it by their works but obtained it as a free gift from God's hand. It is through the elect remnant He clings to the nation as a whole.

Through their fall - salvation is come unto the Gentiles (11:11).

God's wondrous election eyed the whole world of Gentiles. We have here a contrast between "fall" and "salvation." Israel fell over the stumblingblock and the rock of offence

that God in His sovereign will put in the path of blind Israel. God of old forbade this in mercy to Israel, but in judgment and mercy He has done this to blind Israel; in judgment for Israel's sins, in mercy to the Gentiles.

God has in His sovereign power so constituted His ancient people that every movement they make contains some curse or some blessing. When the brothers sold Joseph they were the blind tools to keep Israel and the world alive through Joseph's grain storage; the choosing of a killer above Christ was the world's salvation; and so Israel's fall through unbelief meant salvation to the Gentile dogs. Even the crimes of the blackest hue in Israel invariably are overruled by the all-wise God of Israel for something great and glorious. God often uses a crooked stick to deal a right blow, and He certainly has done this with the murder of the Messiah and with Israel's fall.

If the casting away be the reconciling of the world - what shall the receiving of them be but life from the dead? (11:15).

This is one of the highest, deepest, profoundest statements in the whole Book of God. Those who grasp its divine philosophy hold the key to unlock practically all the treasures of His wonderful Word. The strange thing is, however, scholars find no difficulty at all to grasp the first half of this passage, which holds the divine hermeneutics for the right understanding of the second clause. The first is in the form of a declaration, the second in the form of a question.

The word "them" means Israel, about whose fall and restoration he is speaking in the whole chapter. The "casting away" points to Israel's temporal and partial fall (11:25). The "receiving" means Israel's re-acceptance, which will be just as literal and real as the casting away. This logic is inescapable. The phrase "reconciling of the world" stands for the gospel of reconciliation for the whole world, and the words "of the world" are to be understood after "life from the dead." Hence the re-acceptance of Israel will mean a resurrection of the whole world of mankind now dead in sins. It will mean the regeneration of which our Lord spoke in Matthew 19:28. It will mean the Messianic Kingdom of peace on the earth, when the knowledge and glory of Christ shall cover the earth even as the waters cover the ocean. This hurts the postmillennial pride that wants to bring all this to pass through its Christian activity. They find it absurd that this should come through the Jews.

Behold the goodness and severity of God, on them which fell severity - but toward thee goodness (11:22).

Israel received first the goodness and then the severity of God. God was severe with them in the destruction of Samaria and in the two overthrows of Jerusalem, but prior to these lay a long history of the goodness of God. Toward the Gentiles, so far nothing but goodness has come, but even with the solemn warnings of God's severity before them, they have followed all too much in the steps of Israel.

A wild olive tree - a good olive tree (11:24).

The uses of the olive were numerous. It was anciently exported to Egypt (Hos. 12:1) and Phoenicia (Ezk. 27:17; 1 Kgs. 5:11). Besides food it served to dress the hair (Ps. 23:5) and as an anointing for festivities (104:15). It was used to heal sores and bruises (Isa. 1:6); it was mixed with the sacrifices (Lev. 2:1; Num. 15:4-9); it was used in

anointing kings and priests (Ex. 29:7; 1 Sam. 10:1; 1 Kgs. 19:16; Ps. 133:2, 3). It was used to anoint the tabernacle and its furniture (Ex. 40:911). Stores of olive oil were safely kept in fortified cities (2 Chron. 11:11). It was always used for the perpetual light in the tabernacle (Ex. 27:20), made after a special and divine prescription (Ex. 30:23-25). Counterfeiting the holy ointment meant inevitable death, because it typified the Holy Spirit, and there are no substitutes for His divine work.

The tame olive tree represents Israel. This nation is represented by three trees: the fig tree, the olive, and the vine; the first denoting its nationality, the second the nation from the viewpoint of its spirituality; the third, or red wine, from the vine which is the blood of Christ, also richly symbolized and typified by the blood of bulls and goats. The wild olive emblematizes the Gentile nations.

As concerning the gospel they are enemies - as touching the election they are the beloved (11:28).

The Jews in general were even then hostile to the gospel, and were regarded as enemies by those who clung to the gospel of grace. The Jews are the objects of God's love, because of His covenants with them (Gen. 15:18; Deut. 9:5; 10:15; 16:3). The brief phrase "for the fathers' sake" signifies "on account of God's covenant, oaths, and promises to the fathers" (Deut. 4:37; 7:6-8; 10:15). We often hear it said that the Jews are God's people and His beloved nation, but this is not true in this dispensation of grace, for the ancient word first spoken in Hosea 1 - Israel is *Lo-ammi, i.e.,* not my people, and *Lo-ruhamah,* not having any mercy - still stands till this day. It was because of this judgment Israel did not accept Him in His first coming as a nation. Ever since Hosea, Israel has not been God's people and has as a whole not enjoyed God's mercy. It is clear as the light that this double judgment will not be taken away in the day of grace, but in the day of the Lord, when the Lord shall return in mercy to His people. From the ideal elective viewpoint they are, however, the beloved for the father's sake, even though they have not been, as we have been, "accepted in the beloved."

CHAPTER 12

RENEW YOUR MIND

I beseech you therefore, brethren (12:1).

This "therefore" and these "mercies" go back to the preceding paragraph. A God so merciful that He can have mercy upon all Israel is a God to Whom we can entrust our beings. The word "present' 'is translated five rimes "yield" in chapter 6. It is a priestly term for presenting an offering to God, used in Luke 2 of the presentation of the babe Christ in the temple, while in Acts it occurs as the presentation of the raised Dorcas to the sorrowing ones. "Bodies" stands here for the whole man, soul and spirit. Note that Paul does not command, but prays.

The word *parakaleo is* often translated "pray" (Mark 5:17, 18; Acts 16:9; 24:4; 27:34). It is also used of the centurion, the leper, and even the devils beseeching Christ (Matt. 8:5, 31; Mark 1:40). Paul uses it four times in this book (12:1, 8; 15:30; 16:17). In the more than sixty times he uses this word, it is only fourteen times rendered "I beseech." It has about ten different translations, which is perhaps nine too many. The word literally means calling someone to your side in order to have a heart to heart talk with him.

The sacrifice to be rendered is the "body," that bundle of proud flesh, that net of nerves, that hotbed of passions, that caustic tongue, that ferocious temper, and the talent latent in them all. God does not want in the first place your silver and your gold but you. Marvel at the grace that we poor worms of earth can give something to God. He gave His Son, His Son gave Himself, now in gratitude of heart we are to give ourselves. This is called our logical service. After Calvary there is nothing more logical and consistent than to present ourselves as a priestly offering. Such a sacrifice has three qualities:

• It is "living," in contrast to the ancient sacrifices that were all dead. After Christ's death we can bring living sacrifices in giving ourselves to God.

• This sacrifice is called "holy." Our bodies are members of Christ and therefore holy (1 Cor. 6:15-20).

• This offering is described as well-pleasing to God, for that is the meaning of "acceptable." The ancient offerings, brought perfunctorily, were not well-pleasing to God.

Not conformed, but transformed (12:2).

The warning is to not become conformed to this eon. This is an evil age and transitory, hence the justified and sanctified should be non-conformists in regard to it. Demas loved this present age, and as a result left Paul in the lurch. According to the ancient Rabbis, there were two ages, the present evil age and the coming Messianic age, which was to be as good as the present is bad. They saw this truth better than the average Christian theologian.

There is one thing which makes this age bad at heart - Satan is the god of this age, blinding the minds so men do not see the gospel of glory, and seducing all the nations of the earth, while Christ in His luminous, radiant personality is absent. God's grace changes men, not the age. In a beautiful contrast, he says we should be "transformed," where he uses the same word as our metamorphosis, now used in many sciences, and which in Matthew 17:2 and Mark 9:2 is used for the transfiguration of Christ. In 2 Corinthians 3:18 it is rendered "changed" into the same image. God wills, then, that even while we are in this humiliated body our form is to be changed. Just like the transfigured Savior looked surpassingly beautiful and very white, so His own should become. The saints may not be ugly, mean, sordid, contemptible, filthy, crooked. Well may they pray, "In this world dark as night, keep me pure keep me white, Lord keep me shining for thee." By constantly looking at the glory of the Lord we shall be metamorphosed by His Spirit.

In these two verses we have then:

• Presentation of our being to God.

• Separation from this evil age.

• Transformation, by the daily renewing of our minds; including our yearnings, plans, and intents.

• Renovation or renewal, day by day.

• Approbation of God's sweet will. We see by the first four, a saint may fully know the pleasant and perfect will of God.

Be not conformed - but be ye transformed (12:2).

The word *suschematizomai*, elsewhere only in 1 Peter 1:14, means to be fashioned externally together with the world or age, signifying this evil age since the rejection of Christ. The word "transformed" is the verb rendered transfigured in Matt. 17:2; Mark 9:2; 2 Cor. 3:18. The former word is used in an unfavorable, the latter in a favorable sense. Men glory in being abreast of the age, a man of fashion, a man of the world, but all those men as a rule are completely conformed to this present evil age, and they look not for the Savior's coming to usher in the age of glory. The Lord dissuades all His own from conformation to this present evil age, and He persuades His children to be transfigured and made like unto His Son. He predestinated us for the very purpose that we should be like unto His Son, and this thought perfected in the future must begin even now in us. By presenting, yielding, ourselves unto Him, we shall be proving experimentally what is the sweet will of God for our lives. In fact this is the only way to find God's will in His Word and then apply it to the minute circumstances of our life.

Not to think of himself highly - but to think of himself soberly (12:3).

Paul often warned against pride:

• "Boast not against the branches."

• "Be not high-minded but fear."

• "Lest ye should be wise in your own conceit."

World aspirations are the operations of the proud flesh. Pride is the sin of Satan. He fell by it into a fall that is irretrievable, irrevocable, incurable. Paul's thorn was given to keep him from pride. No wonder then that he feared this satanic sin more than any other evil in the lives of the saints. There is race pride, place pride, face pride, and grace pride or spiritual pride, and it is plain Paul is thinking of this last subtle and most dangerous of all forms of pride. He wants believers to be sober-minded and to give themselves, just as God has given to them the measure of faith. Note, God does not only give us faith but also the particular measure of faith.

The grace given unto me (12:3).

The phrase, "the grace given unto me," is very important. He uses it three times, in Romans 12:3, 6; and 15:15. He uses it also thrice in 1 Corinthians 3:10 and 15:10 (twice). See also Galatians 1:15; 2:9; Eph. 3:2,7,8; 1 Tim. 1:14. Did Paul mean to say he was saved when he used this phrase? Certainly not. Did he mean God had miraculously saved him? Not exactly. Did he perhaps mean that by grace he had been made an apostle? Or did he perhaps mean he was very holy, or that much grace was given to him? Though this was true enough in itself, that is not the exact idea. This is a unique phrase; in this sense Paul alone uses it of all the holy authors. He wants to purvey this thought-that by God's grace he has received a unique and wonderful position as the apostle of the Gentiles, and the apostle of the Body of Christ, and as such the members of the Body must sit up, take heed, and regulate their lives according to his infallible words. By neglect of this, and by following Peter instead of Paul, the historic church has become Romanism, a mixture of Judaism, Christianity, and Paganism.

Even in our thinking we should be Pauline. In the Greek he uses in one form or another the word "think" four times *(phronein).* He thereby has a lovely play upon words, which must have made a humorous effect for his readers and may have caused a smile.

• He plainly says we ought to think. Many have lost their thinking cap completely.

• No one should think too highly of himself, as man is ever so prone to do.

• The saints ought to think soberly.

• In our thinking we should ever be ruled and humbled by the thought that God has given the gifts in accordance with the measure of men's faith. Oh that men might be Pauline in their thinking!

We are - one Body in Christ (12:4, 5).

He speaks of two bodies, the natural and the mystical; of two formations, the deformation and the transformation; two kinds of thinking, self-exalted and sober thinking; and the measure of faith and the proportion of faith. In verse 4 he uses the metaphor of the human body in order to illustrate the unity of the mystical Body, just as he does in 1 Corinthians 12. Nevertheless, it would be extremely lopsided and even contrary to fact to say, as some do, that we have here only a metaphor, seeing he applies the figure to the one Body in Christ.

The glorified Lord had been nearly thirty years in heaven. His redeemed on earth have been justified, sanctified, and incorporated in Him (Rom. 8:1, 39); they have been

baptized into Him, into His death, planted in the likeness of His resurrection, and they have the life in Christ Jesus (6:11, 23). In Greek the "through Christ" is literally "in Christ." Nothing can ever separate them from Christ. They are safe and secure in Him forever. These believers dwelling in the Lord of glory nearly thirty years after His ascension are said to be "one body in Christ." Anyone who wants to make this a different body from the one in Ephesians 4:3-6 simply stultifies himself and insults the sanctified common sense of every believer.

The doctrine of the two mystical bodies of Christ, taught by some extreme dispensationalists in England and here, is peculiarly monstrous, since it entails several absurdities and gives us of necessity a cluster of errors. God's Word has spoken and this is clear enough. This word is not only a clear statement of the actuality and unity of the mystical Body of the heavenly Lord, but at the same time a strange statement of the unity of the members. If all are in Christ, and if all form the one Body in Christ, then the unity, which is a sanctified union, has thereby been clearly established. The members never fight one another, but daily and momentarily help one another; thus it should be with the members of Christ's Body. The Bodytruth is a glorious truth.

The word for gift is *charisma,* which literally means grace-gift. For a brief period there were miraculous grace-gifts in the Body, and of those the apostle said in 1 Corinthians 13:8 that they would fail, cease, vanish away, but he did not say the Body itself would vanish away. The grace-gifts differed according to the measure of faith (verse 3), and according to grace bestowed. "Proportion of faith" is norm of faith, rule of faith. In those days there was still prophecy both as to prediction and fulfillment, and a few years later these did cease. "Ministry" is *diaconate* which stands for loving service in general. He further mentions teaching, exhortation, giving, ruling, and a showing of mercy.

The gifts in Corinthians differ from these, and the list there is also larger and has far more of a miraculous character. As to these gifts in the church, there are various views. Some think the miraculous gifts have continued all through the centuries until our day. This is the Roman view, and cannot stand the test of history in Scripture. Many Protestants think they have ceased as a result of the unbelief of the church, and if we only had enough faith they still would be with us, but this impugns the whole church as filled with unbelief. The Corinthian church came behind in no gift and yet they were worldly and only carnal babes. The Pentecostalists claim they have been fully restored through their movement, but the dead are not raised, and all the sick are not healed by shadows, belts, and handkerchiefs, and angels do not visit any from heaven as in the day of Acts, nor are the tongues interpreted. The sound Scriptural view is that these gifts and miracles continued as long as God dealt with Israel as a nation, and they ceased after Paul expelled the Jews from his meeting with them at Rome. The God of Israel alone does wondrous things (Ps. 72:18), which means wonders happen only when He works as the God of Israel. In this age of grace when Israel is blinded and put on the side track God does not work miraculously as the God of Israel, but as the God of all grace, all comfort, all peace, able to do exceeding abundantly above all we ask or think.

Let love be without dissimulation (12:9).

The idea is love should not bear the mask of the hypocrite, it should not play false. The word for dissimulation is simply hypocrite with the *alpha privaus,* the negative "a," put before it. This word appears six times and could in each case be rendered unhypocritical:

- Let love be unhypocritical (12:9).
- By love unhypocritical (2 Cor. 6:6).
- Of faith unhypocritical (1 Tim. 1:5).
- The unhypocritical faith that is in thee (2 Tim. 1:5).
- Unto unhypocritical love of the brethren (1 Pet. 1:22).
- Without hypocrisy (Jas. 3:17).

"Abhor that which is evil." All these rich admonitions show that the justified, with their perfect standing in Christ, should lead an inner life of holiness. These words do not thunder down from Horeb's heights as law, but flow from a loving heart as sparkling waters of grace into loving hearts. Saints should hate evil always and in every form.

"Cleave to that which is good." The verb *kollao* denotes a cleaving as of dust to the feet (Luke 10:11). The prodigal joined himself to a citizen (Luke 15:15). In the Pentecostal period "durst no man join himself" (Acts 5:13). Philip had to "join himself" to the Eunuch's chariot (Acts 8:29). Saul assayed to "join himself" to the disciples (Acts 9:26). It was for Peter as a Jew unlawful to "keep company" (Acts 10:28). Certain men "clave" unto Paul (Acts 17:34). 1 Corinthians 6:16 speaks of one who is "joined" to an harlot; verse 17 of one that is "joined" to the Lord. Hence we should cleave to the good with holy passion as a whoremonger cleaves to an harlot with unholy passion; cleave to the good as we cleave to the Lord Jesus our Savior. He does not mean the worldly good, which is so often an enemy of God's best, but the positive good of God's grace. It is not sufficient to admire it, advance it, advocate it or aspire after it, but we are to cleave to it. We should be identified with God's good things.

Be kindly affectioned one to another (12:10).

Way has here, "In mutual to the brethren be as members of one family," which gives the original thought splendidly. Brotherly love is Philadelphia. Kindly affectioned is *philostorgoi.* Our stork, the bird of love and mercy for its young, has been derived from the second part of this word. The tenderest love is in God's sight the fundamental of all fundamentals (1 Cor. 13). In the realm of grace, what is not done in love is done wrong. Love is greater than faith and hope combined. God is love. "He who does not love our Lord Jesus Christ, let him be anathema, maranatha." "The true morality, O Lamb of God, is love for thee."

In honor preferring one another (12:10).

Way has, "Give respectful precedence to one another," and that is the idea well expressed. We call it today promotion, and the meaning is we should promote others above ourselves. This is not according to the nature of the proud flesh. Man cannot and will not do this, unless grace has subdued his heart. The perfect example of this is our Lord who was willing to be made sin and a scapegoat for His own in order that they

might have eternal glory and honor. Our great paragon saint and apostle to the Gentiles had caught the spirit and the mind of Christ when he gave himself as the offscouring of all in order that we might have the gospel of fragrance.

Oh to be nothing, nothing;

Only to lie at his feet,

A broken and emptied vessel

For the Master's use made meet.

Honor has been compared to a shadow, because it flies from those who follow it, it follows those who flee it, and it varies in its position. Though man can see from a long history the paths of glory and honor lead but to the grave, yet he always madly seeks honor, while he is oblivious of this apostolic injunction:

Not slothful in business, fervent in spirit - serving the Lord (12;11).

The first part is as much misunderstood as quoted. It has nothing to do with our modern business. What we know as such is not in the Bible at all, unless we identify it with the Tyrean commercialism of Ezekiel or that of Babylon (Rev. 17, 18). The word *sporide is* the same as our speed and the Dutch *spoed.* Outward zeal is meant, as "fervent spirit" has reference to the inner zeal.

Fervent in spirit (12:11).

Literally, boiling in spirit. This is a dissuasion from the coldness as of icebergs. In the cold, the divine planting will not grow and bear fruit, far less much fruit to the glory of the Father. Negatively, this is also a warning against the Laodicean spirit of lukewarmness - "Oh that ye were hot!" The Lord wants His own to be filled with enthusiasm. No great thing has ever been accomplished in the world or in church history without this fervency of spirit. Death is cold, but we were dead in sins and are now alive unto God (6:11; Col. 3:14). To be now as cold as death is an anomaly. God wants the glow of love, of zeal, of beauty, of gratitude, and of joy in the Lord. Paul wants to connect fervency of spirit with sobriety of mind. He wants real enthusiasm for the Lord. Fervent means boiling, bubbling over like boiling water. Paul detested the cold, calculating spirit of compromise as the Pharisees of all ages have manifested it. In every great spiritual awakening the flames of enthusiasm blazed forth over the icebergs of the frozen church life. When the vision is blurred by the things of earth, when the consciences are dulled, the double-edged sword of the Word seems blunted, and the glory of Christian life and church life are sadly dimmed. Then alone the fire of the Lord's Spirit can illumine the lives and set them aflame for the Lord of hosts. There is no doubt Paul has also the Holy Spirit, the perpetual fire of the Lord before his mind.

Serving the Lord (12:11).

Some manuscripts have time or opportunity, but this reading is better supported. The words *kurios* and *kairos* are very similar and some scribes seem to have gotten the two mixed. Then we are not to serve time, but use it (Eph. 5:16,6:7; Col. 3:17, 23). The Lord Jesus so filled the vision of Paul that He would not easily say anything should be served, except the Lord, because we have been saved to serve Him. It is heartsickening to see how few of the redeemed of the Lord really serve Him. They serve the church,

perhaps, as elder or deacon or they serve their club or lodge, their school, or union or country, but they do not serve the Lord, Who washed them from their sins in His own heart-blood.

Rejoicing in hope (12:12).

The verbs do not stand in the imperative, for here is no law but grace, but they do stand here as participles to show they should persistently and always be boiling in spirit and rejoicing in hope. Hope, *elpis,* is faith joyfully and expectantly looking for the Lord and the future glory. Peter uses it only four times and John only once, it being almost exclusively a Pauline concept. He uses it twelve times in our letter, whereas it never occurs even once in the four Gospels. To call Peter, not Paul, the apostle of hope is manifestly absurd, for where Peter has it only three times in his first epistle and once in Acts 2:26, Paul has it about fifty times. We can rejoice in the hope of seeing Christ and sharing all His glory and riches and dominion.

Patient in tribulation (12:12).

The very word for patience shows it is not a virtue which can easily be acquired or brought into practice, because it means to remain under; evidently under the cross of suffering of some kind. This word also occurs only twice in the Gospels (Luke 8:15; 21:19), six times in this letter, and twelve times in his other writings, whereas all the others have it only twelve times. Patience is to have its perfect work.

Continuing instant in prayer (12:12).

The word should be rendered as in Acts 2:42, where we read "continued steadfastly." Of the state it is said in 13:6 that it is "attending continually upon" this very thing, and there the same word *proskartereo* is used. Christ spoke two parables to the end that we should always pray and not faint. He remained whole nights in prayer, and in many places in Paul's epistles we are urged to pray without ceasing. This is one of the most disobeyed injunctions.

Distributing to the necessity of saints (12:13).

"Distributing" is communicating, fellowshipping. In the practice of vital piety, not one thing is forgotten. Believers can sometimes be adorned with many virtues, whilst this exhortation of love stands still flagrantly disregarded and disobeyed. Some Greek scholars have averred the original word had reference to the most intimate union and communion between man and wife. However this may be, the word is certainly far more intimate than the cold business-like distributing.

Given to hospitality (12:13).

"Hospitality" is literally love of strangers and given to is *diokontes,* far stronger than the expression given to. In the next verse it is translated persecute, and that is the meaning; go hot and heavy after it. In the Gospels and Acts it is practically always so translated, and also nearly always in the Epistles. It is always used of Saul's persecution. In Romans 9:30 the Jews followed not after righteousness but followed after the Law (verse 31). Follow after the things which make for peace (14:19).

This exhortation is also sadly neglected. Many hardly know what hospitality is to friends, let alone to strangers. Generally speaking the saints of our day are not hotly

pursuing this virtue; they rather abhor it, sad to say, but true nevertheless. Look at the Word, however:

- Pursue hospitality (12:13).
- Be not forgetful to entertain strangers (Heb. 13:2).
- Given to hospitality (1 Tim. 3:2).
- A lover of hospitality (Tit. 1:8).
- Use hospitality without grudging (1 Pet. 4:9).

The Word of God is plain in this matter. No one will by and by have any excuse when account must be rendered for the disobedience to this Word of the Lord.

Given to hospitality (12:13) - Bless them which persecute you (12:14).

In this intense way we are to follow after peace. It is perhaps unnecessary to note Paul says this with a view to the two sets of saints relative to the foods and feastings of which he spoke. When he says they should follow things wherewith to edify one another, he employs the much used figure of the building art, *oikodomeo,* a word used twenty-seven times in the Gospels of literally building an edifice. Also in Acts it is thus used three times, and just once figuratively of the churches (9:31). Paul uses it in Romans as a verb in 15:20, and as a noun in 14:19 and 15:2. In addition to this he utilizes this telling figure twenty-one times of the building up of the saints individually and of the church collectively. The other writers of the New Testament never avail themselves of this great figure of spiritual edification. In this sense it is exclusively a Pauline term. With him all the ministry in the church had this as its definite object in view.

Rejoice with them that do rejoice (12:15).

On what is said in verse 15, he comes back in verses 19 and 20. It is often not easy for the flesh to rejoice with those who are glad. Contrariwise it is often easier for the old nature to get jealous at the joy of others. Remembering, however, the apostle said we are one Body in Christ (verse 5), it should be relatively easy for members of the same Body to rejoice in the prosperity and joy of the other members (1 Cor. 12:26; 13:6; Eph. 4:25; Gal. 6:2).

Weep with them that weep (12:15).

Not as the ancient official lamentors did, nor as present custom demands, but from heartfelt sympathy as members of the same Body of Christ. Even if the mourners are unsaved, our loving sympathy can perhaps win them for Christ. He Himself wept at Lazarus' grave. An old Puritan once prayed to God for the grace of tears. In our age of coarse materialism, we need badly this grace of tears. The princely Isaiah wept over Moab, the enemy of his people. Jeremiah sobbed his heart out for his people. Paul often wept over the wayward and the enemies of the Cross of Christ. Is it cold indifference or purely masculine pride that even the preachers of our day weep so little? These practical exhortations make clear that our Christian life should not be coldly intellectualistic and rationalistic, but in the sound sense of the term mystical, emotional, empathetic, enthusiastic. Whenever apostasy creeps over the church like a creeping

paralysis, and whenever the siren songs allure the hearts with worldliness, these practical and much neglected warnings should be reread and restudied, and they would revive the barren lives.

Mind not high things, but condescend to men of low estate (12:16).

Here is another warning against pride. He wants exactly the opposite of pride and high-mindedness, namely a lowliness such as our Lord has shown when He condescended in peerless grace from the heights of heaven to men of low estate such as we are, and even to the very depths of hell. Satan has fallen through pride and ever since man continues to fall by pride; the warning has been sounded against this satanic sin.

"Mind not high things;" and here most believers stop, not considering that we have to condescend to men of low estate. We find both these opposite poles in the self-humiliation of our Lord. He thought it not robbery to be equal with God, like Satan and Adam before Him, but He emptied Himself of all the glory of Deity in order to become the Man of sorrows. He condescended, for though being rich He became poor. He condescended, climbed down, to men of low estate. Being holy, harmless, and undefiled, He cast in His lot with poor sinners by becoming conformed to them in everything, sin excepted. He set the pace in self-effacement that we should walk in His steps. In the last chapter he exhorts again to the strict unity and like-mindedness of believers, while the last clause of verse 16 has already been treated in connection with 11:25.

Mind not high things (12:16).

Way has, as usual, a striking translation, "Be not exclusive." The word "high things," *hupsela,* means high things. The meaning is that we should not set our minds, our thinking upon high things under the sun, but rather upon the high things above the sun, as we are admonished in Colossians 3:1-4.

But condescend to men of low estate (12:16).

This is the exact opposite of the preceding. The verb *sunapagomenoi* occurs only here and in Galatians 2:13, where it is translated of Barnabas that he was carried away with the hypocrisy of Peter in Antioch. It is found once more in 2 Peter 3:17, where it is said of the errorists they were being led away with the error. The verb literally means to be led away with someone else. Hence the word "condescend" is altogether too weak, unless we take it in its original sense of going down with some one, and then it is a correct rendering of the Greek, and perhaps the translators had this in mind. Way has, "Walk hand in hand with the lowly," which is striking and picturesque, but it would be better still if we would put it thus, "Walk hand in hand away with the lowly." Away from the high things. Away to where they dwell and need you. The popularity of the rich in the churches and clubs is proverbial. Oliver Goldsmith said, "The jokes of the rich are always successful." If there is one practical admonition in the Bible more disregarded than this, we do not know of it. Oh the abominable pride of the human heart that systematically passes the hut of the humble to feast at the castle of the wealthy.

If it be possible (12:18, 19).

The apostle gives two hints in regard to peace with our neighbors. The first is the implication that it is not always possible; daily experience teaches us so. The second implication is that it takes two to make a quarrel or a war, and hence he says, "as much as lieth in you." The emphasis is on you. If there is to be a war, let the other party start it, but see there be no *casus belli* on your side (see 1 Cor. 6:1-7; Luke 12:51-53; Heb. 12:14; 1 Pet. 3:9-13).

He further most affectionately appeals to them not to avenge themselves, but to give place to the wrath, i.e., the wrath of God, as appears also from the following. The quotation is from Deuteronomy 32:35. Vengeance is not satanic, nor human, but divine.

"I will repay." When man takes revenge, he tries to take God's prerogative to himself, to take God's holy work out of His hands. If Israel of old had to take vengeance, it was only as an instrument of God's holy vengeance. God's vengeance, like His wrath, is His holy reaction against all sin of man covered by the blood of His lamb. God's vengeance, we note here, is not singly an Old Testament doctrine. The abrogation of the legal system did not affect God's holy wrath against sin. We read in the New Testament even more of His blazing wrath against sin than in the Old. The ogre, or wrath of God, is found only five times in the Gospels, but twelve times in Romans and eleven times in his other writings. James has it only twice and Revelation six times. In a day like ours when the love of God is lopsidedly put in the foreground, it is necessary that the balancing truth of God's holy wrath and vengeance against all unforgiven sin be re-emphasized. The doctrine of the universal fatherhood of God and the brotherhood of man have put the sterner truths way in the background.

Thou shalt heap coals of fire on his head (12:20).

He now reveals how a Christian should take vengeance. With a quotation from Proverbs 25:21, 22 he shows they are to feed their hungry foe and give the thirsty to drink, and the result will be coals of fire heaped on his head. There is no unanimity among expositors as to the exact meaning of this phrase. A very general thought is that the benefactions to a malefactor would make him burn with shame, but this is a far fetched and strangely un-oriental thought. The heaping of coals of fire on the foe is a Biblical thought, and it is this thought Paul has before his mind. When we compare what is said of the hot coals of fire in Psalm 11:6; 18:13, and 140:10, then we see in each case there is:

- Retribution.
- Divine retribution.
- Divine retribution upon the ungodly.

In the future day of wrath God says, I shall heap literal coals of fire upon the heads of the guilty; but our coals of fire are benefactions of food to the hungry and drink to the thirsty. God makes these noble deeds to the ungodly at the same time a token, a foretoken and prophecy of His day of vengeance. There is undoubtedly here a touch of holy irony. We live in the day of grace and have to work with figurative coals of fire, but God in the succeeding day of vengeance shall throw real coals of fire upon the wicked. Thus taken, this expression is a lovely contrast between man's doings and God's, between the age of grace and the day of vengeance of our God. The last verse of this

chapter is a word of wondrously deep and divine psychology. We must not be defeatists who go down under the seductions or hammer blows of evil, but we must smite the evil hip and thigh. How? With the good to which we must be passionately joined.

Be not overcome of evil -overcome evil with good (12:21).

Many misunderstand the former phrase, since they take evil in the sense of sin, and then take it as a warning against sin or too much sin. However, if we take the good things of life in immoderate measure such as eating, drinking, dressing, resting, and sleeping, then these things become evil, and in this sense we can say many believers are overcome with evil. Evil should be vanquished with good. Against every weakness the saint should set a good, positive virtue. If he is over penurious, he should give a most generous offering of love to the Lord. If he is over indulgent in his eating, he better fast and pray. If he loves to stay at home from the assembling of the saints, he should go prayerfully to every meeting of the saints. If he loves to sleep long, he should arise at early dawn to spend an hour in prayer and Scripture reading.

CHAPTER 13

OBEDIENCE TO RULERS

Let every soul be subject unto the higher powers (13:1-7).

So far the writer has in this portion of his letter spoken of our duty to God (12:1-3) and our duty to the members of the Body of Christ (12:4-21). Now he speaks of the duty to the state (13:1-7), the duty to all men (8-14), and in chapter 14 he writes of the duty of the strong to the weak, continuing with this subject to 15:1-3.

The fundamental thought is that there is no power but of God. In Noah's day God instituted the power of state. Pilate had the Roman power, but according to our Lord it was of God. According to the Anabaptists, the unbelieving state was not of God and was not to be obeyed. Otis Q. Sellers claims that spiritual powers are meant, but these do not bear a battle sword, cause no dread, are not a dreadful revenger to execute wrath upon the evil doer, and neither do we need pay tribute to them. It is the continuous teaching of the Scriptures that the power of state has to be obeyed implicitly, and there is but one single exception; we must obey God more than men.

Several kings excited God's wrath for not obeying a foreign conqueror. Christ said, "Give unto Caesar what is Caesar's." The teaching of 1 Timothy 2:1, 2; Titus 3:1; and 1 Peter 2:13 is virtually the same as we have in this classic passage. The government is here called "minister," or literally deacon. Many think with this word only of the holy office and then say God certainly would not appoint ungodly state officials as His ministers, but they forget God has made the winds, the clouds, and even the devils His ministers. He has not only holy but unholy ministers, like Cyrus, Nebuchadnezzar, and others.

"Damnation" in verse 2 is altogether too strong for the Greek *krima*, which simply means a verdict of guilty by the judge. If in Paul's day, when the monster Nero sat upon the world throne, the state had to be obeyed and honored as God's deacon, how much more should we in these days obey the governments and all in authority over us. In anarchy we would value protection.

He that loveth another hath fulfilled the law (13:8-10).

The duty to all men is here stressed. The fivefold repetition of the word "love," *agape,* the unchanging divine love, shows that to be the main thought of the Law and of all duty to men. No debt but the debt of love! By quoting the second table of the Law, with the exception of honoring the parents (seeing this was included in the honoring of the powers that be), he shows the gospel has swallowed up the Law and metamorphosed it, so to say, in a gospel of love and gratitude. As Christ before him, Paul condenses the whole Law in the word love to the neighbor, implying thereby that this cannot exist without real love for God. Love is the fulfillment of the Law. He understands by fulfillment a filling full, as appears from the word *pleroma.* Love is not a Scriptural fulfillment in the usual sense of the term but the complement, the satisfying of the demands of the Law. The verb *pleroo* in fact often means a filling full, as appears from:

- Matthew 13:48 - the new was full.
- Matthew 23:32 - fill up the measure of your fathers.
- Luke 2:40 - filled with wisdom.
- Every valley shall be filled.
- The house was filled with fragrance.
- Filled Jerusalem.
- Filled thy heart.

Christ did not come merely to obey, and in that sense fulfilled the Law, but he filled it up and so ended it. If a student completes a course, he has ended that course. By truly loving Christ and His members and all men, we are all through with the course of the Law, and we cannot afford to repristinate two thousand years and go back to the system of Law; a hard yoke, by the way, which Peter's fathers could not bear.

Love is not a substitute for true obedience, however, but the motive for the highest obedience. The grace of God is no cloak for license, but a call to humble and faithful service. Paul never tells us the essence of love, for God is love, but he tells us all the more of the activity of love.

Now is our salvation nearer than when we believed (13:11-14).

The argument is love with a view to Christ's soon coming. These verses were used by the convicting power of the Spirit to lead St. Augustine to the Lord as a poor lost sinner. The word "salvation" *(soteria) is* used here in an eschatalogical sense, as Dr. Grosheide has broadly shown in his dissertation on "The Expectation of Christ's Coming." Salvation has a threefold tense and aspect. In the past we were delivered from the penalty of sin, in the present we are being delivered from the power of sin, and as to the future we shall be delivered from the very presence and all the effects of sin in our bodies as well as in our souls.

The night is far spent (13:12).

Man's day is night in God's sight, and it certainly has been a long, cold, dark, dreary, and dismal night while our Lord has been personally absent from this world. Believers do not belong to this night. They are children of the day. Sometime they were darkness, but now are they light in the Lord. At night the wild beasts go forth to prey, we therefore find the world filled with beasts of prey. Night is also the desirable time for the criminals, who love the darkness more than light. The day of Christ is at hand, and this is for the author the reason and motive why believers should cast off the works of darkness and put on the armor of light.

Believers are to walk honorably as in the day. They are to shun the glamor of the night life. They are dissuaded from six works of the flesh. "Chambering" means spending the night with wrong companions in rooming houses. The night clothes cast off, Christ should be put on as the garment of life. The word *endusasthe is* a metaphor taken from the putting on of a garment (see also Eph. 4:24; 6:11; Col. 3:12). It is a telling figure, for Christ hides our nakedness and deformity before God, covering us from the cold and heat and from our shame. He covers us with the sackcloth of sorrow

for sin, but also with the rich mantle of righteousness, praise, joy, and glory. Garments often denote riches in the Bible. The flesh has positively no rights, when taken in the usually bad ethical sense, for we are not to pamper its cravings or make provision for it.

CHAPTER 14

WE ARE THE LORD'S

Him that is weak in the faith receive ye (14:1-4).

The writer now goes on to prescribe the duty of the believers to those who are weak in faith. Note well that he does not describe weak faith. Strictly speaking, there can be no weak faith, for it is a gift of God and God does not give weak things. Even the faith that feebly touches the hem of Christ's garment receives healing. Simply the look of faith saves. Faith in its simplest manifestation is an indissoluble bond that binds us to Christ. The reference is to the human exercise of faith, which is often weak. He is thinking here of weak brethren who breathe in an atmosphere of legalism, are tainted with it, and manifest it in overscrupulosity.

Receive is *proslambano,* a verb meaning taking into one's intimacy (Matt. 21:22; Acts 28:2; Rom. 14:1, 3; 15:7; Philem. 12, 17). The idea conveyed is to take to one's heart, one's bosom. Here it evidently means to take into the bosom of the church, but they were not to receive him in a spirit of doubt and debate. Casuistry is Judaistic and Romanistic but not scriptural.

The brethren in those days were divided in the broad and strait, the flexible and inflexible. Some rightly believed they might eat all things, but they arrogantly seem to have despised the weaker folk. The overscrupulous ate herbs only, they were vegetarians. Between the carnivorous and gramnivorous was a bit of wrangling. The eaters despised the abstainers. How human! Paul warns against the condemning of one another. It is an arrogant assumption of divine right when man sits in judgment upon his brother. The phrase "to his own Master he standeth or falleth" expresses the individual responsibility of a household slave. Each slave has to serve his own Master. The verb "standeth" points to good service, "falleth" to a falling down as to one's responsibility. So there is perfect liberty to eat, but no liberty to offend or judge the overconscientious brother. The history of the church would have been different if His broad and loving spirit had always prevailed.

One man esteemeth one day above another (14:5-8).

We can sense the Jewish brethren had many scrupulosities about the Sabbath and festive days. Paul does not side with the broad nor with the narrow party, but in an elevated, sacred individualism he writes, "let every man be fully persuaded in his own mind." It is thought the verb he uses here *(plerophoreo)* is derived from the picture of a ship whose sails are filled with a favorable wind. It is found only in Luke l: l; Romans 4:21; 14:5; 2 Timothy 4:5,17. The noun occurs four times (Col. 2:2; 1 Thess. 1:5; Heb. 6:11; 10:22), in each case rendered "full assurance." It literally means "full carrying." In a sweet, loving spirit that thinketh no evil, he regards the legalistic daykeepers as doing it unto the glory of the Lord, and the nonkeepers as doing this in their way to God's glory in the same manner as he does with the eaters and abstainers. He lovingly assumes the saints do everything in loving regard for the Lord who bought them. We may safely conclude the Roman believers of that day gave thanks unto God at their meals. This is

an ancient custom going back to apostolic example and precept. It is a grand principle which he states in verses 7 and 8 when he, assuming we are not our own and never really live for ourselves, maintains in life and death we are the Lord's.

As to being the Lord's property in body and soul, it makes no difference whether we are alive or dead, for He is Lord of the living as well as of the dead. Clear proof, by the way, that the dead exist, for it would give no sense to say the Lord is Lord of the non-existent. The body may have completely decayed and disappeared in the grave, but the spirit exists nevertheless with the Lord. The mystical union between the Lord and the saint is in no wise affected by death and the grave. What a comfort this truth is for the aged and dying saint, whose connection with this earth must soon be severed. He can rest assured the Lord then too keeps His blood-bought property.

Christ both died and rose and revived - that he might be Lord both of the dead and living (14;9).

A most remarkable and instructive verse. Whenever believers like to lord it over one another in respect to dieting and day-observances, it is well for them to remember Christ alone is Lord of all. Four times the Lord is mentioned in verse 6, thrice in verse 8. A remarkable light is here shed upon the cross of Calvary and the very purpose of the Cross. The popular view is that Christ went to the Cross merely to save us. Glory to His name, He certainly came to shed His blood for our sins. This surely was one of the great objectives of His death (Gal. 1:4; Tit. 2:14; 2 Cor. 5:15; John 10:10). Many other objectives of His death are taught in the Scriptures, but here we have one that stands unique in its clarity and object, yet oft forgotten. In view of a11 the sentimental love for a historical Jesus, it is of paramount interest to see that the Son left the bosom of the Father in order to die on the cross, and His definite end in view was that He would, like Joseph of old, go to the deepest pit of ignominy and shame in order to become the Lord of all the Egypt of this world and of the dead in the underworld.

The reading of the text is much contested in this verse. Why is it said Christ "revived" after He "rose?" Was the latter or even the former word alone not enough? Evidently the word "revive" underscores the fact that the life of the risen one was a resurrection-life which could never die again. The raised in the Old Testament all died again, the three of the Gospel period also had two funerals, and those of Acts as well, but not so our Lord. All the agonies of our suffering and dying Lord were definitely, though not solely, to this end, namely, that He might be Lord of the dead and living. We cannot fully appreciate this word until we look across the page in 15:8, where we read Jesus Christ was "the minister of circumcision," the deacon of the Jews, in other words. In an incredibly small nook of the world he lived and labored for 33 years, exclusively confining his labors to the one little people who hated him without a cause. He did not even go to any city which had heathen in it. He never was in Tyre and Sidon but only in its parts, never in Joppa, where there were heathen sailors, and not even in Tiberias, which had a Roman garrison. In life he was Israel's servant, but He died to be Lord of all.

We shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ (14:10-12).

Paul now addresses the two sets - the overscrupulous and the free who judged and despised one another - proving unconsciously that adults are often all but foolish big children. "Set at nought" is despise. While they did this they forgot three things:

• The common Lordship of Christ, who alone had the authority and the sovereignty, the might and right, to judge and set at nought.

• They were one Body in Christ (12:5), and therefore members of one another in particular.

• They soon would all have to appear before the *bema,* the judgment seat of Christ.

As I live, saith the Lord (14:11).

The "as" is not in the Greek. The quotation is from Isaiah 45:23, and there the sentence begins with the phrase, "By myself have I sworn." This led the translators to the notion we must have here also an oath, but we have here simply the solemn declaration that the end of the Cross has been reached, and He now lives as Lord of the dead and living, though the final fulfillment of this word waits for Christ's second coming. The general genuflection and confession as a token of complete subjection is waiting for the Lord's coming also.

To impress us with its importance three times this solemn truth has been emphasized; in Isaiah, in Philippians 2:10, and here. Modern Universalists use this solemn declaration as proof of their belief all the world will some day humbly confess Christ as Lord and every one will be saved, but we have no right to take this statement in such a sense. We see in Christ's first coming to earth how even the demons had to confess Him as the holy Son of God. This was no proof of the salvation of these demons. Thus this general confession of Christ in His coming will be no proof of the salvation of these confessors, but it will prove conclusively the greatness of our Lord. Paul has then not sanctioned any food nor supported any particular day, but he has with the finest tact reminded both parties of their subjection to the Lord.

Let us not judge one another any more (14:13-16).

The judgment of the Lord over all the works of a believer is sufficient cause why believers should not judge one another. They had been doing this wicked thing in Rome and hence he uses the expression *meketi,* any more, no longer. "Stumblingblock" is *proskomma,* used five times in this book (9:32, 33; 14:13, 21). It is only twice beside this in 1 Corinthians 8:9 and 1 Peter 2:7, 8. The word *skandalon* occurs also five times in Romans 9:33; 11:9; 14:13, 21. It is here rightly rendered occasion to fall, for it originally was the little peg on which the bait for the rat in a trap was fastened. If the caught rodent could talk it would have said, "this peg caused my downfall," and thus our scandal originated. Saints are called to be steppingstones and not stumblingstones, though they are altogether too often the latter. They seem to be trappers and fowlers that snare other saints.

"By the Lord Jesus," should be, in the Lord Jesus. He is of the persuasion Christians are all in Christ, and this should rule and regulate all their intercourse with their brethren. Paul's life, theology, and ethics always oscillate between the two poles of the mystical union and Christ's appearing. He here also lets the light of both fall upon the question of dieting and day-observance. The apostle is fully persuaded the blood of the

Cross has washed away all the distinction between clean and unclean, so there is now actually nothing unclean of itself. In Paul's day, meat was the apple of discord, with us it is drink. In nineteen centuries we have made no advance in enlightenment upon this problem. Puritan practice sways us far more than Pauline doctrine. Verse 15 shows unmistakably clear that the man who believes in the fullest liberty believes also in the fullest application of the law of love, and that he does not want to needlessly hurt the weak brethren. According to Paul's teaching, the law of liberty must always be balanced by the law of brotherly love, which is higher and more edifying.

For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink (14:17,18).

The sharp antithesis some have drawn between the kingdom of heaven and the kingdom of God does not exist, for these two terms are used several times interchangeably. And neither is there such a deep, broad gulf between the Kingdom and grace as some imagine, because the apostle of the grace of God speaks time and again of the kingdom (1 Cor. 4:20; 6:9, 10;15:50; Gal. 5:21; Eph. 5:5; Col. 4:11; 1 Thess. 2:12; 2 Thess. 1:5). In general, we can say that by it he means the realm of grace, which the crucified Christ had harbored in. He tells us first negatively what this Kingdom of grace is not. It is not meat and drink. This may at first sound or seem to be a platitude, and yet it is not a superfluous saying, because the Pharisees of his day, and many legalists and vegetarians in our day, have never fully realized this simple truth; neither have the prohibitionists or antiprohibitionists of our time. With a little ironic smile Paul must have said the alliterative and euphonious words, "The Kingdom is not *brosis kai posis."*

- "Righteousness." There's no reason whatsoever why we should take the *dikaiosune* here in any other sense than Paul has used it in this letter-the merited righteousness of God on the cross-and this stands here as the basis of the other two.

- "Peace," *irene,* is the same peace as the peace with God in 5:1. The word literally means to make of two one. Christ has removed the enmity and has made of God and man one.

- "Joy in the Holy Spirit." Joy is the fruit of the Spirit and it is also experienced in the sphere of the Spirit. Paul has given classic examples of this joy in chapters five and eight. He does not mean the carnal, worldly joy which flows from the muddy stream of the heart, but the limpid, pellucid joy that flows from the throne of God.

Let us therefore follow after the things which make for peace (14:19).

Three times in this section he uses the exhortation beginning with "let" (verses 13, 16, 19). Solomon said of old the way of the wicked is an abomination to the Lord, but he who follows righteousness is loved by the Lord. This word may have been before the author's mind in 18 and 19. After Christ merited righteousness, peace, and joy on Calvary we are to acceptably serve the Lord in these things. Especially "peace" must be followed after. Solomon spoke already of following after righteousness, saying the Lord loves such as do that, and now we read of following after peace. The word *dioko* is used in Acts 9:4, 5; 22:4, 7, 8; 26:11, 14, 15; 1 Corinthians 15:9; Galatians 1:13,23; Philippians 3:6 of Paul's persecution of the church of God. As hotly and zealously as he

dogged the footsteps of the saints, so sedulously should the saints follow after peace. The Jews did not follow after righteousness (9:30). Israel followed after Law (9:31).

All things indeed are pure (14:20, 21).

Two things are said in verse 20:

• The work of God should not be destroyed for meat. The word destroy is overthrow; *kataluo* means dissolve, throw down. It is exactly the antonym of edify. When we tear down a weak brother, we are practically throwing down the work of God in that brother.

• When Paul says all things are pure, he simply reiterates what he said in verse 14, "There is nothing unclean of itself."

In both cases he naturally is not thinking of sin, which is morally unclean, but of God's creation as food, drink, and days. Paul would say the same thing of grape juice. Nothing God ever made can be inherently unclean. To abstain from anything God made can never be a virtue. On the other hand, it is a sign of the apostates of the latter day that they command to abstain from meats which God has created (1 Tim. 4:1-5). Nevertheless, even if God's creation is good, it is also often "good," (*kalos* is ethical beauty) if a saint abstains voluntarily from flesh or wine or from anything which might cause a weak brother to stumble. This word is addressed to the strong. To do nothing embraces the whole ethical realm. It goes much further than eating and drinking, though one version gives the impression that only eating and drinking are involved.

It is important to understand well the ethical teaching of the apostle. He says all creatures are good and therefore good to use. No one has, therefore, a right to command us to abstain from it. Notwithstanding this, it can be noble to abstain of free will if we otherwise would offend a weak brother. The law of love limits the law of liberty. Love alone can rightly interpret and apply the law of liberty. Love is infinitely higher than liberty. No brother can boast of his right and his liberty and at the same time trample upon the law of love. To eat meat is good, but Paul would not eat it as long as the world stands, if he thereby should offend his weak brother.

Hast thou faith? Have it to thyself before God (14:22, 23).

We see then that all faith should not be confessed. Some faith we should keep hidden and shut up in our hearts. What faith does he mean here? The faith of the strong whereby they believe they may eat all things and drink all things. What a pity it is this warning has gone so often unheeded, because many have a fiendish delight to parade and trumpet forth their beliefs in this matter, which can be highly offensive to the weak. Paul does not say they should give up their faith, but that they should not display it rudely and offensively before the weak. He has called this in verse 20 a destroying of the work of God for meat. He calls that man happy, however, who does not condemn himself in regard to his eating. This clause is evidently addressed to the strong and not to the weak.

Overscrupulosity is never to the glory of God, but is often as bad as unscrupulosity. The last verse is a rebuke to the weak fully as harsh as that to the strong. He that "doubted" is "damned," literally, has been condemned, by the very fact he goes flagrantly against his own conscience, conviction, and belief, and hence stands self-

condemned. The man who does a wrong thing conscientiously ranks ethically higher than the man who does a good thing consciencelessly.

Negatively stated, the weak man has not eaten of faith; his act could therefore not please God, for what is not of faith cannot please God (Heb. 11:6). Positively, he ends here by saying that which is not of faith is sin. Faith alone does things according to God's will and to God's glory, and all we do without faith is sinful in itself and displeasing to God. Thus the apostle has taught the same thing in regard to the food as our Lord in Mark 7:15, and his practical teaching is the same as Christ's example, for as Son he did not need to pay the taxes of the temple, but said, "lest we offend them," go Peter and catch a fish - and pay for me and for thee.

CHAPTER 15

MINISTER TO THE GENTILES

Not to please ourselves (15:1-3).

This chapter division should not be here, since the teaching on the strong and weak still goes on. He says three things about "pleasing." He says in 8:8 that those who are in the flesh cannot please God, and there he uses the word *aresko* three more times. Let us see what he says about it.

• Christ did not even please Himself. If He had, He would have remained in heaven, in the very bosom of the Father. This simple but glorious fact is for the apostle, however, a sufficient reason why we should follow His example and not please ourselves.

• We ought not to please ourselves, but as strong, bear the infirmities of the weak. It is a general rule God in His mercy wants the strong to help the weak, the rich to help the poor, the sound to succor the sick, the normal to care for the abnormal, the wise to teach the witless. Mankind could not exist without this rule. The parents nurse and nourish the children. The vicarious idea runs throughout the whole human life. While we were without strength the mighty One of Israel died for us, the Just for the unjust, the Holy One for the unholy, the Sinless One for the sinful.

• Let everyone please his neighbor for his good to edification. Against the offending of the brother - the destroying of the work of God - he places again his great principle of edification. If Christ was willing to bear not only our infirmities, but even our sins, how gladly we should then bear the infirmities of our weak brother for whom Christ died. All the reproaches of the world fell upon Christ. This is clear proof He did not please Himself. The quotation from Psalm 69:9 is the fifty-first in this letter. He never goes far in this grand book but he corroborates his sayings with a quotation.

• Christ was rich, but He became poor. He was full of luster and radiance, since the glory of God was upon Him and in Him, but He laid all this glory aside voluntarily and emptied Himself of all this excellence and took all the reproach and shame of His enemies upon Him. How can His own acknowledge this and then offend the weak brethren.

Written for our learning (15:4).

Even here Paul does not leave his theme of mutual tolerance by the weak and strong. The strife was mainly by the Jewish and Gentile believers. While the former clung to the letter of the Law, the latter may have been cold to the whole Old Testament, hence this statement about the ancient Scriptures, and more particularly its purpose:

• It was all written for our learning. The particle *hosa* shows you may pick out anything in the Old Testament and know it is for your instruction. Note, it is not all for

us to do, not all for our emotions, not all for our learning. Even the books of Kings, which some missionaries among the raw heathen hardly dare translate, are for our instruction. Yea, even the imprecatory Psalms, which are the butt of the mockers, and the so-called immoral stories, proudly rejected by modern infidelity, are all for our instruction. In 2 Timothy 3:16 Paul goes a step farther with the instruction of the Old Testament when he says it is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness. He there views it as a whole while Paul here views more its parts.

• The higher purpose of the Scripture is hope. He is thinking of the hope of the Messiah and the glories He shall bring. By clinging to the Old Testament, Israel became the " prisoners of hope." To get this hope in our bones we need "patience" *(hupomone)* to remain perseveringly under the cross of suffering and shame and the comfort of the Scriptures. When we get the instruction of the ancient oracles, and also the patience and comfort, then the full blaze of the hope of the Scriptures will illumine our heart and life, our walk and work.

The God of patience (15:5-7).

Several remarkable names are given to God in this section:

• *God of patience.* This name is evidently connected with Christ's first coming and suffering, as appears from what was said in verse 3.

• *God of hope* (v. 13), which is connected apparently with the second coming of our Lord.

• *God of peace* is the name given twice in 15:33 and 16:20. He uses this name also in Philippians 4:9; 1 Thessalonians 5:23; 2 Thessalonians 3:16; seven times in all.

• *God of all comfort (paraklesis)* is the name He uses in 2 Corinthians 1:3.

• In Acts 7:2 we read, *God of glory;* and *God of all grace* in 1 Peter 5:10.

He prays in verse 5 that God may grant them to be likeminded, literally to think the same thing. This is an amazing prayer. It strains toward an ideal which can only be fully realized in the realms of endless glory, but God's will should be done on earth as in heaven. If they have patience and hope through the Scriptures as true Bible believers, they ought to be drawn close together in their thinking upon the dieting and day-observance.

This is not the only place where the apostle exhorts to such strict unity; see Ephesians 4:1-6; Colossians 1:4,5; Philippians 1:27; Romans 12:16; 15:30. The unity is in Christ, the cause, center, and object of all true unity. The unity is a sanctified union with Him. The closer we get to Him, the nearer we get to all His own.

Saints should take their fellow saints to their heart, even as Christ has taken us to His heart. The word *proslambano* does not merely mean receive but receive into your intimacy. When we laid dead in sins, Christ picked us up and took us into His heart with the blessed assurance He will never cast us out. In that glorious salvation He is our example and ideal standard as to our social life with the brethren. As He took us into His heart, so we are to do with one another. This forever excludes all wrangling as to material matters. By such unity in Christ, the Father will get all the glory.

Jesus Christ was a minister of the circumcision (15:8).

This important declaration is introduced by the words, "But I say." In the quarrel between the legalistic Jews and the free Gentiles, Paul concedes Jesus Christ "was," or has been made a minister (literally, a deacon) of the circumcision-the Jew. The word "minister" in verse 16 is *leitourgos*, a word denoting priestly service, while deacon is the general word for faithful service. It is of supreme importance to see clearly that Christ in the days of His flesh on earth was the minister of the Jews.

He declared repeatedly He had not been sent but to the lost sheep of the house of Israel. The Syrophenician woman and the Greeks who wished to see Him found this out. The circle of His labors was incredibly small. He never went to the coastal cities where many heathen sailors were found. He was only six miles away from Tiberias, but we do not read He was ever there, and in all probability He was not, because it was a Roman city with a Roman garrison. He never was in Hebron, the city of the patriarchs, for that lay far south to Egypt and had some Egyptians in its walls. He came only in the coast of Tyre and in the coasts, or parts, of Caesarea Philippi, and in the parts of Dalmanutha, meaning He was never in those places but only on the borders. He clung strictly to His orders and did not deviate a hair's breath from it.

He did this "for," in behalf of, the truth of God. God's promises had been directed to Israel alone and indirectly to the Gentiles only through Israel, to "confirm" or establish the promises. In His first coming He did not intend to fulfill all the promises, but set them fast in His own blood. All the four Gospels must be understood in the light of this verse. It was all direct to the Jews and in behalf of the ancient promises.

Having stamped this verse indelibly in our hearts, we should take one more glance at the ninth verse of the preceding chapter. He went to the Cross with the definite end in view to become the Lord of all. The Cross is the end of Christ's diaconate to the Jews.

There shall be a root of Jesse - he that shall rise to reign over the Gentiles; in him shall the Gentiles trust (15: 9-12).

The apostle has drawn here four contrasts:

• Between Jews and Gentiles.

• Between the truth and promises given to Israel and the uncovenanted mercy to the Gentiles.

• Between the silence of Israel as a whole about the Messiah and the great joy of the Gentiles in Him.

• Between the ministry of Christ and that of Paul as given in verse 16.

Not less than five quotations are made to prove the Gentiles some day would rejoice and praise God for His mercies through the Messiah (Ps.18:49; Deut. 32:43; Ps. 117:1; Isa. 11:10). It was anciently not revealed that the joy of the Gentiles would come through Israel's rejection of the Messiah as we see now. That was part of the Mystery then not revealed to the ages and generations of men but still hid in God (Col. 1:24-26; Rom. 11:25).

The word "trust" is hope in verse 12, and therefore Paul gives the name to God as the "God of hope." We Gentiles were originally without God and without hope in the world. Not a single direct promise was given us. We had nothing but a heavy load of sin and guilt, but God has now given us in Christ, dwelling in us, the hope of glory. Our hope is now set and settled on His appearing and our appearing with Him in glory (Col. 3:4). We shall then be like Him for we shall see Him as He is, not as He was, a minister of the circumcision, but as the Lord of glory. The world in our day [at the date of original writing during WWII] is hopeless and in despair; Israel is in great distress as perhaps never before; Christendom is split and splintered into a thousand parts; the nations are at each other's throat in a deadly and destructive war; Europe is being made a desolation; all the moral standards are subsiding; the earth is saturated with blood and tears; but in it all, God is our hope and refuge, and the indwelling Christ is the hope of glory. This hope makes us not ashamed. A joy, such as no earthly tongue can utter, fills our bosom.

Looking unto Jesus

We glory in his grace;

From glory unto glory changed,

Till we behold His face.

Fill you with all joy and peace in believing (15:13, 14).

The main thought in these two verses is the full life. Fivefold fullness is mentioned joy, peace, hope, goodness, and knowledge. The Roman believers had the last two, not the first three. It was a grand thing to be full of goodness and knowledge so they could admonish one another. They surely were considerably farther advanced than most believers, but they lacked the fullness of joy, peace, and hope. It is a question of consuming interest how we as believers can get these three most desirable things.

The apostle prays not only for the Romans, but also tells them briefly, yes clearly, how they can get these treasures worth more than gold. His answer is by "believing." Believing what? What God has said in the preceding pages of this book. If we believe God has freely justified, sanctified, glorified, and sealed us in Christ and will appear for us, then we shall indeed rejoice in the hope of the glory of God. When we believe God reckons the believer to have died in Christ's death and to have been raised in His resurrection to newness of life (6:1-10), and if we reckon after God that this is true, and the sinful, Adamic nature is crucified, dead, when we reckon ourselves as dead to sins (6:11); and if we yield our members as instruments of righteousness unto God, voluntarily abdicating from the throne of self-sovereignty and self-righteous ness and enthroning God as the Master of our lives, then we cannot but rejoice and have great peace and hope.

"Great peace have they that love Thy law," sang the Psalmist of old, but far greater peace have they who believe this "my gospel" of the apostle of the Gentiles. Joy and peace, and also hope, are the fruit of the Spirit. Paul has also written twenty-two times in Romans 8 about the blessed Holy Spirit, who makes us free from the law of sin (2, 13). He did not teach entire eradication of sin, the old Adamic nature, but he did teach

the Holy Spirit delivers from the dominion of sin. Believing what Paul taught gives joy, peace, and hope.

The grace that is given to me (15:15,16).

Here Paul drops the scrap between the strong and the weak, and expatiates to the end of this chapter on the importance of his own ministry among the Gentiles. Many believers in that day, and in our day, do not see the unique and important character of Paul and his ministry. Time and again he refers to the particular grace, not as saint or sinner, but as apostle to the Gentiles, an office given to him by God (1:5; 12:3; 15:15, 16; 1 Cor. 3:10; 15:10; 2 Cor. 13:10; Gal. 1:1; 2:9; Eph. 3:2, 7, 8).

It is exactly this grace of which he has so often spoken that the church until our day has never adequately understood unto her own great loss. By following Peter she became Rome. By following Acts she became Pentecostal. By following John she often lapsed into an unsound mysticism. Paul alone is the great apostle for the Gentiles and for the Body of Christ. Neglect of him means ruin sooner or later.

The word "putting in mind" is *epinamimnesko,* from + *epi,* upon + *ana,* again + *mimnesko,* bring to the memory of your mind. It occurs only here and means that Paul wishes to stamp his own particular ministry indelibly into their minds. Our word liturgy comes from the word he uses for minister. He uses four terms in verse 16 which denote priestly service:

• *leitourgos,* minister of worship.

• *hierougounta,* ministering, doing sacred work in the sanctuary.

• *prosphora,* offerings.

• *euprosdektos,* the favorable reception of an offering.

The second word occurs also only here. Paul is evidently thinking of the Christ as the spiritual temple and habitation of God in the Spirit, and he describes himself by the Spirit as the spiritual and leading servant in this new sanctuary. The old temple would soon be completely wrecked, but God had His new sanctuary and ministry all prepared. The Spirit now sanctifies the Gentile gifts. Paul evidently regards his converts and their love-gifts as a God-pleasing offering in the new sanctuary.

I have therefore whereof I may glory (15:17-19).

Paul has legitimate cause to glory in his commission and the fruits of his mission. His boast, however, is not through Christ merely but in Christ. Oh the pity this mystical union has been so weakened by this mischievous rendering. He hardly dares to speak of all that he did - no - of all Christ had done through him. It was the risen and ascended Christ who did all the work (Matt. 28:20; Mark 16:20; Acts 1:1; 2:33); and he will not presume to speak of the good works others have done, but will speak only of what Christ wrought through him.

Our version has missed the sense of the original. By the word of preaching and by the working of miracles he has led the Gentiles captive unto the obedience of Christ. He uses all the three main words for miracles in verse 19 to show the great wonders God had wrought by him; *dunamis, semeion,* and *teras.* In the days Israel was not yet fully

set aside, God worked many wonders through Paul (Acts 14:3; 15:12; 2 Cor. 12:12; 2 Thess. 2:9; Heb. 2:4). When the Pentecostal Acts period was ended and Israel peremptorily set aside in Acts 28, then the great miracles ceased, and there were no mass healings, resurrections, angel visits, miraculous earthquakes, tongues, prophecies and other signs after that. When Epaphroditus got seriously ill with Paul in Rome, Paul did not lay his girdle or handkerchief upon him as he formerly did, but prayed in his distress to God as we do today, and God heard him as he often hears and heals today. His field was large-from Jerusalem to Illyricum, perhaps the present Albania.

As to the character of his preaching, he says he fully preached the glad story of Christ. The word means literally fulfilled, but he means, perhaps, that he preached to the fullest extent that which he had received. Wherever he went he did not hold anything back. He had no mongrel or adulterated gospel. He preached the grace of God in its entirety.

Lest I should build upon another man's foundation (15:20-24).

Paul had three ambitions, for that is what the word *philotimonmenon* really means, as the margin also has it.

• He had the holy ambition to be well-pleasing to Christ (2 Cor. 5:9).

• He wants all Christians to be ambitious to be quiet (1 Thess. 4:11), which is the opposite of the unholy ambition to be popular and in the public limelight.

• He has the holy ambition to preach the gospel to untouched tribes.

Stark literally, the word means love of honor, hence he loves to make it a point of honor to please Christ, to labor unnoticed, and to reach the unevangelized with the glad tidings. He does not want to build upon another man's foundation. Was this only a private taste of Paul? No! Was it his independence or an idiosyncrasy which finds it hard to do teamwork with others? Was he what the Germans call an *einspanner?* No! Did he esteem himself better than others? Thrice no! He knew full well he was the "wise masterbuilder," called to lay the doctrinal foundation for all others. He was not called to build upon the foundation of others, but others are called to build upon his foundation in a doctrinal sense, as we are clearly taught in 1 Corinthians 3:10 and 2 Corinthians 10:11-18.

Verse 21 is a quotation from Psalm 52. For a long time Paul had been desirous to see Rome on his trip to Spain, but he had been much hindered. He does not say by what or by whom he was hindered, but the hint seems to be Satan hindered him. Verse 24 clearly shows Paul at this time had no idea whatsoever he would some day go to Rome as a prisoner and be kept there for some years as a captive. We cannot tell for sure whether Paul has been to Spain to preach the gospel of sovereign grace. We are inclined to think the great spiritual darkness which has fallen upon Spain is due to the rejection of the Pauline gospel.

The poor saints which are at Jerusalem (15:25-28).

Owing to the long parenthesis, the author begins the sentence afresh the same way as in verse 23. The poor saints in Macedonia and Achaia had been pleased to make a rich contribution for their poor fellow-saints in Jerusalem. Jerusalem, the old mother

church, had been impoverished by the persecutions, and perhaps also by the communion of goods, and now the daughter churches tenderly cared for the old mother. They in fact were the debtors of the saints in the holy city. Paul explains the word "debtors" by saying that the Gentile Christians had been made partakers of the spiritual values, *pneumatikoi,* of the Hebrew saints, and now it was a proper thing to cancel their debt with *sarkikoi,* or material matters.

The apostle speaks of the grace of giving of these Macedonian saints in 2 Corinthians 8:1-7. It was their good pleasure to give the poor believers in Jerusalem a freewill offering from the heart. Paul repeats this fact for the sake of special emphasis, but he hastens to add it was after a11 but the canceling of a debt, since the Gentile churches owed all they had to the church in Jerusalem, from which Christ, and the gospel, and Paul came. Carnal things for spiritual was but a little part-payment after all.

The word *koinonia,* contribution, according to some Greek scholars, was originally a reference to the most intimate intercourse between man and wife. It is in other places rendered communion (1 Cor. 10:16; 2 Cor. 6:14; 13:14) and fellowship (Acts 2:42; 1 Cor. 1:9; 2 Cor. 8:4; Gal. 2:9; Eph. 3:9; Phil. 1:5; 2:1; 3:10; 1 John 1:3, 6, 7).

Giving is called by Paul a grace, and many Christians are not gracious in this respect. Giving is also a rich source of fellowship and praise. Here he calls it fruit.

The fullness of the blessing of the gospel of Christ (15:29).

Generally this is understood to mean Paul would bring a rich and full blessing to the Romans, but in the light of his teaching on the word *pleroma,* used here, it is highly probable he is thinking of something deeper:

- "How much more their fullness" (11:12).
- "Until the fullness be come in" (11:25).
- "Love is the fulfilling of the Law" (13:10).
- "When the fullness of time was come" (Gal. 4:4).
- "Dispensation of the fullness of time" (Eph. 1:10).
- "The fullness of him that filleth all" (1:23).
- "With all the fullness of God" (3:19).
- "Stature of the fullness of Christ" (4:13).
- "In him should all fullness dwell" (Col. 1:19).
- "All the fullness of the Godhead bodily" (2:9).

Here is the use of *pleroma* in Paul's theology with the exception of 1 Corinthians 10:26, 28. In Romans he uses the term mainly in a threefold sense:

- As the filling up (of Christ) from the Gentiles.
- As the future filling up, or restoration of Israel.
- As the complement, filling up, of the Law.

In Ephesians he always uses it in a deep mystical sense, and in Colossians also. It is therefore highly probable, to say the least, that he is here not only thinking of a rich, full gospel, but of the fullness in the sense as he has used it, say, in 11:25, which does not exclude but includes the other meanings of the word *pleroma.* It is, moreover, seriously in doubt whether the phrase "of the gospel" is genuine. Stifler and many scholars claim it is spurious and we should read *"pleroma* of blessing of Christ." We can at any rate rest assured he would preach in Rome the same things as he has written in this book, and that he would not weaken the mystical meaning of *pleroma* in any sense, but rather deepen it with increased revelations from his heavenly Lord.

Strive together with me in your prayers (15:30-33).

Here is a beautiful request for combined and united intercession for Paul and his ministry. He beseeches them through Christ and the love of the Spirit that they may co-agonize with him in prayers. He has the wrestlers of the arena before his mind. The compound verb *sunagonizomai* is found only here, but the verb *agonizomai*, from which we get our agony and agonize, is found in Luke 13:24; John 18:36; 1 Corinthians 9:25; Colossians 1:29; 4:12; 1 Timothy 6:12; 2 Timothy 4:7. The noun, *agonia*, is used of our Saviour's agony in the garden (Luke 22:44).

The verb is translated strive, fight, labor fervently, and this is Paul's view of prayer life. To him it was a wrestling, an intense agonizing as the Savior did in the garden. He appreciated intercessory prayer for him and his ministry, and he often did the same for others. To ask for intercession is in itself no token of piety, because some of the ungodliest men on the pages of Holy Writ have asked for it, such as Pharaoh, Jeroboam, Saul, and Simon the sorcerer; but when our apostle asked for prayer, it was a distinct token of vital piety (see 2 Cor. 1:11; Eph. 6:19; Col. 4:3,4; 1 Thess. 5:25; 2 Thess. 3:1, 2). He felt trouble lay ahead for him in Judea (Acts 21:18-40; 22-23).

It was not mere patriotism or love for the poor which led him to Jerusalem, but a desire to preach the *pleroma* of the gospel of the grace of God, and a deep yearning to become conformed to Christ in His suffering and death. He hoped his gifts for the poor would be accepted in the right spirit, not as tainted money from the Gentile dogs, but as a sweet loveoffering of Gentile fellow-believers in the common Lord. He also again expresses the desire he may rest and thus be refreshed with them and be in their midst. Striving together in prayer and resting together.

CHAPTER 16

THE SACRED SECRET

I commend unto you Phoebe our sister (16:1-2).

Since this lady is named first in this list of twenty-four names, it is generally thought she was the bearer of this letter, but nothing beyond this single notice is known of her.

• She is a "sister," belonging to the large household of faith. She is a blood-relative but not by the blood of old Adam, but of the last Adam.

• She is a "servant" or deaconess, literally. Some think there was an organized class of Christian women who served as deaconesses, and an appeal might be made to 1 Timothy 5 in support of this view, but it cannot be proved.

• She served the church at Cenchrea (Acts 18:18). The word *ekklesia* meant originally a group of called out citizens, summoned for a definite purpose. Later it came to mean any group or mob of people, as the Ephesian mob in Acts 19:32, 40.

• She was "in the Lord" and to be received in the Lord. The place for women is not alone in the family but if they are in the Lord they are to be received in His church.

• She was a "saint," separated from sin and unto the Lord.

• She had a business for the Lord in which she needed the assistance of other saints. She needed the Roman saints as much as the Roman saints needed her. Business is *pragma*, thing, matter. It does not denote our business any more than 12:11.

• She had been a succorer of many and of Paul also. The word rendered succorer is *prostatis*, literally one who stands before others to help.

This long list of names, among which we find the names of seven women, shows saintly women held a large place in the early church. Many view the ministry of women too exclusively in the light of one or two misunderstood texts of Paul. Many women of the type of Phoebe would be a great blessing to the church of our day. In fact, there are many today like her.

Priscilla and Aquila (16:3,4).

That Priscilla, the wife, is mentioned a few times before her husband is undoubtedly because she was not merely the stronger personality of the two, but the one more spiritually advanced in the Lord. Several beautiful things are said of this couple. They were Paul's helpers in his gospel work. They were like him, tentmakers, weaving their wares of goat's hair. However, Paul does not think of natural help but of their spiritual help.

They were "in Christ Jesus." The apostle time and again refers to this dwelling "in Christ," the only refuge for the soul.

• Redemption is in Christ Jesus (3:24).

• We joy in God (5:11).

• In Jesus Christ our Lord (6:11).

• The gift of God is eternal life in Jesus Christ (6:23).

• No condemnation ... in Christ Jesus (8:1).

• The spirit of life in Christ Jesus (8:9).

• The love of God which is in Christ Jesus (8:39).

• I say the truth in Christ (9:1).

• Witness in the Holy Ghost (9:1).

• One Body in Christ (12:5).

• Persuaded in the Lord Jesus (14:14).

• Peace and joy in the Holy Ghost (14:17).

• Sanctified in the Holy Ghost (15:16).

• I may glory in Jesus Christ (15:17).

• Receive her in the Lord (16:2).

• My helpers in Christ Jesus (16:3).

• Who also were in Christ before me (16:7).

• My beloved in the Lord (16:8).

• Urbane, our helper in Christ (16:9).

• Apelles approved in Christ (16:10).

• Which are in the Lord (16:11).

• Who labor in the Lord (16:12).

• Labored much in the Lord (16:12).

• Rufus chosen in the Lord (16:13).

• Salute you in the Lord (16:22).

This was the real address of all these saints, and at the same time their safety, security, solace, strength, and self-sacrifice so that this worthy couple was willing to lay down their lives for Paul. The being in Christ is the center of Paul's theology.

The church in their house (16:5).

Romans is not a church epistle, addressed to any particular church. It is addressed to the saints in Rome in general, and only in these greetings is the church, *ekklesia,* mentioned a few times. We read four times in Paul's letters of an *ekklesia* being in the home of some saints. In those days there were as yet no church buildings. Some well-to-do couples who had a spacious house o place to work would fling open the doors for the worship of the saints. Priscilla and Aquila had also done this. In 1 Corinthians 16:19 we also read of the church in their house. Nymphas also had an assembly in his house

(Col. 4:15), and Philemon 2 makes mention of a third party who had such a group of saints coming to his house for worship.

There was far more simplicity in those days than in our day. Women would not make the fuss for a stranger coming to her home as our modern women are apt to do. In such homes folk got close together and close to one another's heart. The fires of love and the heart-fires were burning brightly. The church was not yet splintered into many fragments. They were willing to lay down their neck on the executioner's block, as this worthy couple had done for Paul. With this couple it was habitual to have the saints come to their home, for in 1 Corinthians 16:19 they had a church in their house in Ephesus and here in Rome.

Paul had never been in Rome but he knew surprisingly many details of church life. He kept informed not of current events, but of the things of the Lord. He may not have been abreast of the times, but he was abreast of the saints, and he also had the saints in his breast. He carried "daily the care of all the churches."

Behold how good and lovely it is for brethren to dwell together in unity. It is like the perfume on Aaron's beard and like the dew of Hermon.

Salute ... (16:5b-16).

Many omit this dry list of names, but it is redolent with the fragrance of Christ.

• We see first of all illustrated in a most practical way that there is in Christ no male or female, for we find in this list at least five women who are called "laborers" in the Lord or in the gospel (3, 6, 12).

• We see that in Christ there is no Jew or Greek or Scythian, for we find here Jewish, Greek and Roman names, yet they are all one in Christ. Foreign nations were generally despised but in Christ they are all beloved.

• We find here also a lovely illustration that there is in Christ no bond-slave or free man, for Tertius and Quartus, third and fourth, were only numbers as galley slaves, but the former wrote this Epistle in the Lord and Quartus was also a brother.

• We see here a sweet picture of the home life, social life, and church life of the early Christians. They had a church in their home, when they could fervently love one another. They were one big family.

• We see here a lovely picture of the service of the saints of many men and women. It is said they helped, labored in the gospel or in the Lord.

• We see here how the mystical union with the Lord should influence our whole life. Not less than eleven times we find the well-known monogram "in Christ" or its equivalent.

• We find with the unity of the saints in Christ at the same time the greatest variety, for some labored, others labored much in the Lord, four were beloved, others approved. The list reminds us of the list of David's different heroes. God always notices the unity and the differences, and so shall some day be the variegated reward (Rev. 22:12).

• We see here the sufferings of the saints. Some were Paul's fellow-prisoners.

• We see here the Christian courtesy and the honor given to all the saints. The gospel elevates, ennobles, penetrates, purifies, pacifies, and dignifies in the Lord Jesus Christ.

• We see also that Peter was at this time not in Rome, for if he had been there, Paul would surely have sent him a personal greeting. The "holy kiss" was a token of pure love between those of like sex.

Mark them which cause divisions (16:17-19).

False teachers caused divisions, schisms, stumblings, scandals. They should be marked as offenders and avoided as pestilential. Even if they came in the name of Christ, they did not serve the Lord Jesus, but their own belly (compare Phil. 3:17-21). By fair speeches they deceived the hearts of the simple. The art of flattery is used much by the devil and his imps. These men did not belong in this fine fellowship, this holy family or household of faith. God is harsh on those who cause schisms and divisions through false doctrine or wrong practice (1 Cor. 1:11; 3:3; 11:18; 2 Pet. 2:1; Jude 4). It is noteworthy he does not say, turn them away, or turn them out of the church, but turn away from these schismatics (2 Thess. 3:6, 14; 2 Tim. 3:5). There is very little proof in the Scriptures for the present-day turning away methods, but God exhorts again and again to the separated life from all the filth of the flesh and the Spirit. We are to be more separated than separators.

Verse 19 gives a friendly warning to be wise, discreet unto that which is good and simple, i.e., pure, harmless concerning evil. It is wonderful praise when he can truly say of the Roman saints that their obedience, the obedience of faith, as manifested in humble subjection to the gospel of grace, has come abroad to all men. This gave great joy to the heart of the man of God. Such believers are the best recommendation to the gospel. Their obedience radiated forth Christ's virtues more than their own. It has been rightly said that believers are the Bible of the world. Sinners read these living Epistles written with the finger of God. When these saints in Rome were obedient they did not know they would make Paul's heart leap for joy, nor were they aware of the fact they would be immortalized on the page of Holy Writ. Loyalty to our Lord is written down in heaven. Let us have much of it.

Offences contrary to the doctrine (16:17).

Four times "the doctrine" appears in this great doctrinal letter. In 12:7 and 15:4 the word *didaskalia* is used and is rendered by the words teaching and learning. In 6:17 and here "doctrine" represents the word *didache.* Paul uses the former word nineteen times, while it appears in the gospels only in Matthew 15:9 and Mark 7:7, and *didache* is used eight times by him.

It is a most remarkable fact that he speaks in his Pastoral letters several times of sound or hygienic doctrine, presupposing much unsound doctrine. It is also a noteworthy fact that the Scriptures always speak of doctrine in the singular when it concerns sound doctrine. The Bible knows no sound doctrines, at least it never speaks about them. Search where one will, but not once do we meet with the phrase sound or hygienic or good doctrines in the plural.

We find on the other hand when the word is used in the plural it is always used in the unfavorable sense of doctrines of men or of demons. The human doctrines of the Pharisees paralyzed the Word of God (Matt. 15:9; Mark 7:7). In Colossians 2:22 we also find doctrines of men. 1 Timothy 4:1 speaks of doctrines of demons in the last days, whereas Hebrews 13:9 speaks warningly of divers and strange doctrines. Right here lies the menace and futility of all human creeds and platforms. Men time and again will build fellowship upon a nice little string of doctrines, whereas God only acknowledges one sound doctrine. No creed or platform of doctrines, be it ever so fine, has ever been able to foster fellowship and purity of doctrine and life. It is simply not God's way. God looks at the whole volume of truth as hygienic doctrine.

And the God of peace shall bruise Satan under your feet shortly (16:20a).

The author has now spoken his peace. He has written of the common salvation. All the great subjects of sin, salvation, justification, sanctification, the two Adams, glorification, and Israel's past, present and future, have been touched upon. The saving and keeping grace he has underscored (4:1-8; 5:1, 8; 6:23; 16:20). He has not forgotten service and the separated life, but he has not said one word about Satan. Before he lays down the pen, he wants to say one grand sweeping statement about Satan, and he does give an all-embracive statement about our great enemy in the first part of verse 20, a declaration which is very heartening to the believing soul.

Paul saw in those false teachers the brood of the old serpent, and hence the occasion to this sudden, abrupt, crass, and crushing statement. The day will soon dawn wherein all the vile source of false teaching and division shall be forever removed. Just because God is the God of peace, he shall crush to a final and eternal defeat the cause of all war and strife. A world of comfort lies in this name of God. It guarantees the defeat of Satan and the everlasting kingdom of peace upon the earth. No wonder Paul uses this name six times. This expression shows the *proto evangelium* spoken in Paradise about the crushing of the old serpent has not been fully realized on the cross of Christ, for when this was said the crucified Lord had been nearly thirty years in heaven, and then it was still future. It is sure this bruising of Satan has not been accomplished since the year 60 A.D. It is not being done in our day, but still lies in the future day when Christ shall come from heaven to shut up Satan in the abyss for a thousand years (Rev. 20:1-6). When Satan goes down, all his ministers (2 Cor. 11:15) go down.

Amen (16:20b-24)

The great Biblical scholar Dr. Rudolf Stier has made the famous remark that whenever our Lord prefaced a saying with the double amen - "verily, verily" - He spake out of His coequality with His Father. This seems indeed to be the truth. How solemn His teaching rises before us in the light of that true remark. He always prefaced His sayings with it; thirty times in Matthew, fifteen times in Mark, seven times in Luke. A double amen, amen in John is found twenty-four times. "These things saith the Amen," we read in Revelation 3:14. Christ is the personal Amen of God. The Hebrew word means the spoken word is established and sure of fulfillment. Paul, unlike the Lord, never uses the word at the beginning, but always at the end of a statement. In our Epistle he has used it seven times; three times in the letter (1:25; 9:5; 11:36), four times

at the end (15:33; 16:20; 24, 27). It is unique in all the Epistles that we find so many amens at the end.

It seems the end of the letter was once found at 15:33; later the grand statement about Satan and the false teachers, his seed, was added. Then in another addition some greetings were added (verse 24), and finally when the full blaze of the hidden Mystery had been revealed to Paul, he made another P.S. or appendix. The last is omitted by some manuscripts, but is evidently an added note, not of Tertius, but by Paul himself.

The Word of the Lord is wonderful in its origin, in its essence, and in its mighty influence. All its promises are yea and amen in Christ. Christ Himself has amended all God ever spoke through Moses and the prophets, sighed and sang in the Psalmists, and was doctrinally stated by the great Paul, who called himself less than the least of all saints. The four amens at the close of Romans all look to the true Amen, the Lord of glory, who now fills heaven with his praise and glory.

The mystery which was kept secret since the world began (16:25-27).

This is one of the grandest doxologies of the apostle, and by way of doxology he states some important truths. First the establishing, strengthening power of believers lies in the "my gospel" of Paul. All in Christendom who are not in Christ shall some day be judged by Paul's gospel as he tells us in 2:16. That Christ is risen as the Son of David, i.e., as the King of Israel, is according to His gospel, and that He will some day reign and we with Him if we now suffer with Him is according to this "my gospel" (2 Tim. 2:8-11), and here we see this same "my gospel" is the secret of the believer's establishment. Things are so flabby and flat in Christianity because men with an open Bible in their home have forgotten this.

Second, to Paul has been given the great Mystery of the church, kept secret in the time of the ages. Mystery, parables, and tongues are always the result of Israel's failure. When Israel had failed in the days of Daniel, God gave to Daniel the secret of Gentile supremacy. When the Lord was rejected in Matthew 11-13, the disciples received the mysteries of the Kingdom and the preservation of an elect remnant. When Israel was finally set aside for this whole age in Acts 28, Ephesians shows the Mystery among the Gentiles which fills the gap during the period of Israel's blindness.

The sacred secret was told our apostle around the year 60 A.D. God had His wise reasons to keep it secret for a long time, but in His wisdom He has divulged the secret to the prophet Paul and the other prophets of the New Testament. It was hid in God and from all ages and men, and hence the Old Testament prophets knew nothing about it. Now it is God's definite command and will that all the nations should know it and obey it by faith. This is the immediate aim of the secret, that all nations know, believe, and obey it, whereas the higher purpose is glory to the only wise God through Jesus Christ for ever, Amen.